The Tide Keeps Our Names

A Gothic Romantic Tragedy

[AUTHOR NAME]

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For everyone who has ever kept a light burning for someone who might not come home.

A Note Before You Begin

This novel is a tragedy. It contains drowning, the deaths of major characters, family betrayal, institutional cover-up, and moments of intimacy between adults that are sensual but not graphic. It does not have a happy ending. It has, I hope, a true one.

Prologue

The Last Light

The night my mother died, the sea was black.

Not dark blue, not silver beneath the moon, but black—the color of ink spilled across a page before the words could be written.

I remember the storm.

I remember the lighthouse burning above the cliffs.

And I remember a woman walking toward it with blood on her hands.

She wore my mother's face.

I was eighteen years old when I saw her disappear into the rain.

For twelve years, I told myself it had been a dream.

Then, on the night I returned to Vale House, someone left a letter beneath my bedroom door.

The handwriting was unmistakable.

My mother's.

My darling Eleanor,

If you are reading this, then the sea has finally returned what I tried to bury.

Do not trust the man who promises to protect you.

Do not trust the man who tells you he loves you.

And whatever you do, do not go to the lighthouse after midnight.

Forgive me.

Mother

I read the letter three times.

Then I looked at the clock.

Eleven fifty-seven.

Outside, the lighthouse beam swept across the bedroom wall.

Once.

Twice.

And then, for the first time in twelve years, I watched it go dark.

Chapter One

The House That Remembered

Eleanor

The first thing I noticed about Vale House was that it smelled exactly as I remembered.

Salt. Dust. Old roses.

And something faintly metallic beneath it all, like blood hidden beneath floorboards.

The carriage stopped before the iron gates at half past four. Rain slipped down the windows in long, trembling lines, blurring the house into a shape that seemed less built than grown from the earth itself.

I had imagined this moment a thousand times during the twelve years I spent away.

In some versions, I stepped from the carriage and felt nothing.

In others, I wept.

In the worst of them, I saw my mother standing in the upstairs window, waiting for me.

I saw no one.

Only the curtains moving in a room that should have been empty.

“Miss Vale?”

The coachman opened the door.

I gathered my skirts and stepped into the rain.

The house stood three stories high, its gray stone walls darkened by weather. Ivy climbed the eastern wing. The windows reflected the dying afternoon light like blind eyes.

I had inherited the house, the estate, and a fortune I had never wanted.

I had also inherited its ghosts.

“Welcome home, miss.”

Mrs. Crowe stood beneath the entrance arch, her hands folded over her black dress. She had grown smaller since I last saw her, though her eyes remained sharp enough to cut.

“Mrs. Crowe.”

She took my gloved hand.

For a moment, neither of us spoke.

Then she said, “You have your mother’s eyes.”

I looked away.

“Everyone says that.”

“Your mother used to hate hearing it.”

“Why?”

Mrs. Crowe’s expression changed.

Only slightly.

Enough.

“She never believed herself beautiful.”

I had no answer.

The house swallowed me as I crossed the threshold.

The entrance hall was unchanged. The marble staircase curved upward beneath the enormous chandelier. My father’s portrait hung above the fireplace, his painted eyes fixed upon the door as though he had been waiting for me to return and disappoint him.

Beside it hung my mother’s portrait.

She wore a white gown and a string of pearls. Her dark hair was pinned loosely at the nape of her neck. The painter had captured her smile, but not her sadness.

I stopped beneath the portrait.

“Has anything been moved?” I asked.

“Nothing of importance.”

“That wasn’t what I asked.”

Mrs. Crowe lowered her eyes.

I looked at her.

“Has anyone entered my mother’s rooms?”

“No, miss.”

“Not even to clean?”

“The rooms have been kept as she left them.”

I should have felt grateful.

Instead, I felt afraid.

Because somewhere in the back of my mind, beneath twelve years of distance and carefully cultivated forgetting, I remembered a door closing.

A woman’s voice.

And the sound of something heavy falling into the sea.

That evening, I dressed for dinner in a black silk gown.

Adrian Ashcombe arrived precisely at seven.

He kissed my hand and smiled as though the years between us had been nothing more than a brief inconvenience.

“Eleanor,” he said. “You look beautiful.”

“You look unchanged.”

“Is that a compliment?”

“It depends on what you have been doing with your life.”

He laughed.

Adrian had always possessed the sort of charm that made people forgive him before he had done anything wrong. His dark hair was perfectly arranged. His suit was immaculate. Even the rain seemed reluctant to touch him.

He brought me a bouquet of white roses.

I accepted them.

“Thank you.”

“I thought they might remind you of happier times.”

I glanced at the flowers.

My mother had hated white roses.

She said they reminded her of funerals.

“How thoughtful,” I said.

Dinner passed beneath the watchful eyes of my father’s portrait.

Adrian spoke of London, of Parliament, of the future of the estate. He spoke of our wedding as though it had already happened.

I listened.

I smiled.

And all the while, I watched his hands.

When I was eighteen, I had seen those hands covered in blood.

Or perhaps I had dreamed it.

After dinner, Adrian walked me to the drawing room.

“There’s something I wanted to discuss.”

“Of course.”

“Our engagement.”

I felt my stomach tighten.

“We have been engaged for nearly a year,” he continued. “I believe it is time we announced the date.”

I looked toward the window.

Beyond the glass, the lighthouse beam moved across the sea.

“I have only just returned.”

“Precisely. The island needs something to celebrate.”

“And what do I need?”

His smile softened.

“You need someone who will never leave you.”

For a moment, I almost believed him.

Then I remembered the letter beneath my bedroom door.

The handwriting.

The warning.

And the lighthouse going dark.

“I need time,” I said.

Adrian’s expression remained gentle.

But his fingers tightened around mine.

“Of course, darling.”

He kissed my knuckles.

“Take all the time you need.”

That night, I woke to the sound of footsteps outside my bedroom.

Slow.

Deliberate.

They stopped at my door.

I held my breath.

Then something slid beneath it.

A folded piece of paper.

I waited until the footsteps disappeared before I rose from bed.

The paper was damp.

Inside, written in unfamiliar handwriting, were six words.

Your mother did not die alone.

Beneath them was a single name.

Gabriel Thorne.

Chapter Two

The Man at the Lighthouse

Eleanor

I did not sleep.

I sat in the window seat with my mother's letter in one hand and the stranger's note in the other, and I watched the lighthouse until the dark thinned to gray.

The beam had returned a little after midnight. It swept across the water exactly as it always had, steady and indifferent, as though it had never failed at all.

By the time the first gulls began to cry over the cliffs, I had read both papers so many times that the words had stopped being words. They had become shapes. Wounds.

Do not go to the lighthouse after midnight.

Your mother did not die alone.

Gabriel Thorne.

One paper warned me away from the lighthouse. The other pointed straight at the man who kept it.

Someone was playing a game with me. I only had to decide whether I was foolish enough to play.

"Who is Gabriel Thorne?"

Mrs. Crowe did not look up from the teapot.

The breakfast room was cold. The fire had not yet taken, and the windows were beaded with salt. She poured with a steady hand, but I had been watching her hands since the day before, and I noticed that the tea reached the rim of the cup and stopped there for a moment too long.

"The keeper, miss."

“I know that. I can see the lighthouse from my window.”

“Then you know as much as most do.”

“I do not want to know as much as most do.”

She set down the pot.

“He came six years ago,” she said at last. “After old Pennick drowned. The Trinity House sent a man to replace him, and the man they sent was Mr. Thorne.”

“From where?”

“The navy, they say.” She straightened a spoon that did not need straightening. “A surgeon, once. Some trouble with a ship.”

“What trouble?”

“A wreck, miss. The *Halcyon*. It went down off the Mare’s Teeth in a spring gale. His brother was aboard.”

“Was he lost?”

“He was never found. The sea doesn’t always give them back.”

I thought of my mother’s letter. *The sea has finally returned what I tried to bury.*

“And Mr. Thorne keeps to himself?”

“He keeps to the lighthouse.” Her eyes met mine, and for the first time that morning, they were not careful. “Miss Eleanor. Leave that man alone.”

“Why?”

“Because he has a way of finding people who are looking for something.”

“And what is it you think I am looking for?”

Mrs. Crowe took up the pot again.

“Whatever it is,” she said, “the island will not thank you for finding it.”

The path to the lighthouse began behind the walled garden and climbed through the gorse to the cliff edge.

I took it a little after nine, in a gray coat and walking boots I had not worn since London, with my mother’s letter folded against my ribs. I told no one. Adrian had sent word that he would call at noon, and I intended to be home before then, with a lie ready on my tongue and an answer in my hands.

The morning was washed clean. The storm had blown itself out in the night, and the sky had the pale, scoured look of a thing that had been crying. Below me, the sea moved slowly against the rocks. It sounded like something breathing in its sleep.

I had walked this path a thousand times as a child.

I had never once reached the end of it.

Don't go up there, Ellie. It's no place for you.

My mother's voice, twelve years gone and still perfectly clear.

I stopped. The wind pulled at my hair. A quarter of a mile ahead, the lighthouse rose from the headland like a white bone, banded in black, its gallery rail bright against the sky.

Beside it stood a low stone cottage with a slate roof and a curl of smoke rising from the chimney.

Someone was awake.

I walked on.

The door of the cottage was open.

I did not mean to look inside. I meant to knock, to announce myself, to behave as a lady behaves. But the room beyond the threshold was so unlike anything I had expected that I forgot to do any of it.

I had imagined a hermit's hovel. Instead I saw order.

Charts pinned neatly along one wall. A narrow cot, made tight as a soldier's. A table covered in brass instruments, each one polished until it gleamed. And books—so many books, stacked on the floor and the windowsill and the mantelpiece, their spines worn pale by handling.

A kettle sang on the stove.

"You're a long way from the road, Miss Vale."

I turned.

He stood at the foot of the lighthouse stair, one hand resting on the iron rail, a coil of rope over his shoulder. He was taller than I had expected. His sleeves were rolled to the elbow, his forearms pale and corded and marked with old, thin scars. His hair was dark and too long, and the wind had pushed it back from a face that looked as though it had been carved by someone in a hurry.

He was not handsome, exactly.

But he was the kind of man you remembered later, in the dark, when you were trying not to.

His eyes were gray.

Not the gray of the sea. The gray of the instant before a storm.

“You know my name,” I said.

“Everyone on the island knows your name.” He lowered the rope. “They’ve been saying it for a week.”

“I did not intend to be a spectacle.”

“Then you chose the wrong house to return to.”

It should have been rude. It was not. There was something in the way he said it, quiet and unhurried, that made it sound less like an insult and more like a diagnosis.

“Mr. Thorne,” I said.

“Miss Vale.”

“I believe you wrote to me.”

Something moved across his face. It was so brief that I might have invented it.

“I haven’t written to anyone in a long time.”

“Then someone else has been using your name.”

I took the second note from my coat and held it out.

He did not take it at once. He looked at the paper, and then at me, and then at the paper again, as though weighing the cost of touching it. When he finally reached for it, his fingers brushed mine.

His hand was warm.

His hand was shaking.

He read the six words. He read his own name beneath them. I watched his jaw tighten, a slow, controlled movement, the movement of a man holding something back by force.

“Where did you find this?”

“Beneath my door. Last night.”

“What time?”

“Some hours after midnight.”

“And the first letter?”

I stared at him.

“How do you know there was a first letter?”

“Because this one begins in the middle.” He folded the note along its crease and gave it back to me. “Whoever sent it expects you to have already received something else.”

I said nothing.

“You received something else,” he said.

“I did.”

“May I see it?”

“No.”

The word came out sharper than I intended. He only nodded, as though that had been the answer he expected, and he stepped back from the stairs and gestured at the room.

“Then you had better come in and tell me why you’ve climbed a cliff in walking boots to accuse me of something.”

“I have not accused you.”

“No,” he said. “Not yet.”

He made tea without asking whether I wanted it.

I sat at the table with my hands folded and my back straight, as my mother had taught me, and I let him pour. The cup was chipped. The tea was strong enough to stand a spoon in. He took the chair opposite and did not drink.

“Your light went out last night,” I said.

“Did it?”

“At twelve minutes before midnight. I watched it from my window.”

“Then you watched a failure of the mechanism.”

“Is that what it was?”

He was silent for a long moment.

“The lamp was extinguished by hand,” he said. “I found the lantern room door unlocked at a quarter past twelve, the wick turned down and the clockwork stopped. I relit it myself.”

“You were not there when it went dark?”

“I was in the oil store, at the foot of the tower. I did not hear a footstep on the stair.” His thumb moved along the rim of the cup. “I keep the key on my person. There is only one other.”

“Who has the other?”

“The magistrate.”

My heart gave a single, hard beat.

“Adrian.”

“Mr. Ashcombe holds the other key,” Gabriel said evenly, “as a courtesy of the Board. It has not been used in six years.”

“Someone used a key last night.”

“Or someone is very clever with a pick.”

“Why would anyone put out the light?”

He looked at me then, directly, and for the first time I understood that the thing in his eyes was not hostility.

It was fear.

“Because on the night your mother died,” he said, “the light went out too.”

The wind dropped.

I could hear the sea, and the kettle ticking as it cooled, and the sound of my own pulse.

“You were not here then,” I said carefully. “Mrs. Crowe says you came six years ago.”

“I have said very little to anyone.”

“Then how do you know the light went out that night?”

He did not answer.

I leaned forward. My hands were trembling now, and I flattened them against the table so he would not see.

“Mr. Thorne. I was eighteen. I was at the window. I saw a woman walking toward this lighthouse in the rain, and I saw the beam die, and I have spent twelve years pretending that I invented it. Now a stranger writes me notes in the dark and puts your name at the bottom, and you sit there and tell me what happened the night my mother died as though you had watched it yourself.”

“I did not watch it.”

“Then *how*—”

“There is a record,” he said. “In the logbook. Every keeper writes the same entry on the same night, every year. *Light extinguished at 11:52 p.m. by order of the Magistrate. Restored 1:14 a.m.* The first keeper recorded it. Pennick copied it. I copied it.”

“Why would a magistrate order a lighthouse darkened?”

“I do not know.”

“You are lying.”

It was not a guess. I watched the muscle move in his cheek, and I knew.

He rose from the chair, crossed to the shelf, and took down a ledger bound in black cloth. He laid it on the table between us, open at the last page.

The entry was dated the night before.

Light extinguished at 11:52 p.m. Not by order of the Magistrate. Restored 12:19 a.m.

Beneath it, in the same hand, he had added a line.

She has come home.

I could not breathe.

"I wrote that at one o'clock this morning," Gabriel said. "Before I knew your name had been put on any note. I wrote it because for twelve years the light has gone out on the anniversary of her death and nothing has happened. And last night, for the first time, it was *you* who went out into the dark to find out why."

"I did not go out."

"No," he said. "But you were watching. Weren't you?"

I had been.

God help me, I had been.

I left him at half past ten.

He walked me to the door of the cottage and no farther. The air outside had warmed a little, and the gorse smelled of honey and salt, and I stood in the sun with my mother's letter against my ribs and tried to decide whether I had just spoken to an honest man.

"Miss Vale."

I turned.

He was standing in the doorway with the light behind him, and I could not read his face.

"If you are wise," he said, "you will go back to the house and tell Mr. Ashcombe that the lighthouse is of no interest to you."

"And if I am not wise?"

"Then you will come back."

"Is that an invitation, Mr. Thorne?"

"It is a warning."

"They are beginning to sound very much alike."

Something that was almost a smile touched the corner of his mouth, and was gone.

“Yes,” he said quietly. “I had noticed that.”

I walked down the cliff path without looking back.

I did not see him step out of the doorway, or the way his hand went to his waistcoat pocket the moment I turned my back.

Gabriel

I watched her until she was a gray shape against the gorse.

Then I opened my hand.

A single pearl lay in my palm. Round, flawless, the size of a pea. I had carried it for twelve years, through two ships, one wreck, and every night of six winters at the top of this tower.

I had seen its sisters only once, strung at a woman’s throat, on the last night of her life.

I had not told Eleanor Vale that I knew her mother’s face.

I had not told her that I was the last person to hear her mother’s voice.

And I had not told her that the letter in her coat was not the only one her mother left behind.

Chapter Three

A Promise Made in Ashes

Adrian

I have always been good at being looked at.

It is a skill like any other. One learns where to stand in a room, how long to hold a glance, when to laugh so that others will laugh with you. My father taught me that. He taught me a great many things, and I have spent most of my adult life trying to decide which of them I am allowed to keep.

The Michaelmas supper was held, as it had been held for two hundred years, in the Assembly Room above the harbor. Long tables. Tallow candles. Goose and cider and the whole island in its best black, crowded shoulder to shoulder beneath beams that had been salvaged from ships.

I did not think about the beams.

I thought about Eleanor.

She sat at my right hand in a gown the color of wet slate, her dark hair drawn back, her mother’s eyes lowered to her plate. She had said perhaps forty words since we entered. She had looked at the windows eleven times. I had counted.

“You are quiet,” I said.

“I am listening.”

“To what?”

“The sea.”

“There is a great deal of it, I’m afraid.”

She did not smile. Twelve years ago she would have. Twelve years ago she would have laughed and kicked my ankle beneath the table and told me I was insufferable, and I would have gone home and lain awake with joy.

Now she turned her glass by the stem and said, “Mrs. Crowe tells me the light failed on Tuesday night.”

I kept my face perfectly still.

It is another skill. I have been practicing it since I was twenty-two.

“The mechanism is old,” I said. “I will speak to the Board.”

“Mr. Thorne says it was extinguished by hand.”

My knife stopped against the plate.

“Mr. Thorne,” I said, “says a great many things. He is a man who has spent six years alone with a lamp. One learns to expect eccentricity.”

“You have met him?”

“I appointed him.”

“Did you not hold the second key?”

I looked at her then. She was looking at the candle, not at me, and her voice was light, almost idle. But Eleanor had never been idle in her life. She had been a child who took clocks apart.

“It is in my desk at the courthouse,” I said. “Where it has been for six years. Would you like to see it?”

“No.”

“Then what would you like?”

She raised her eyes.

I have thought of that moment a great deal since.

“The truth,” she said.

And the whole room went on laughing around us, and the candles burned, and I lifted my glass and said, very gently, “Then I am afraid you have come home to the wrong island.”

I rose at nine.

The room fell silent by degrees, the way a field of wheat goes quiet when the wind drops. I had rehearsed the speech. I had written it twice. But standing there, with two hundred faces turned toward me and Eleanor's hand lying cold beneath mine on the cloth, I found that I did not want to give it.

I wanted to say *please.*

"Friends," I said instead. "Neighbors. Most of you knew Josiah Vale, and all of you knew Margaret. You know what this island took from that family. And you know that when Eleanor left us, it seemed to many that she would not come back."

Silence.

"She has come back."

Someone at the far table began to clap, and then another, and the sound spread through the room like a warm tide. I felt Eleanor's fingers tighten once on mine.

Not in pleasure.

In warning.

"I have asked Miss Vale to be my wife," I said, "and she has done me the honor of agreeing. We will be married at Christmas in the abbey church."

The room rose.

I will remember the noise as long as I live. Cups beating on tables, boots on boards, old Mrs. Penrose crying openly into her apron. I turned to Eleanor, and she was smiling, perfectly, beautifully, exactly as she had been taught to smile in the drawing rooms of London.

She did not look at me.

Over my shoulder, through the tall windows, she was looking at the lighthouse.

Afterward I walked her home.

It was a mile along the harbor road and then up through the old orchard, and I sent the carriage ahead so that we might go on foot. The storm had cleared. The stars were enormous. Below us, the sea lay black and enormous and smooth, with the white beam moving across it.

We did not speak until we reached the gate of Penhallow.

I had not planned to come this way. It was not the road. But my feet turned of their own accord, as they always did, and Eleanor stopped beside me, and we both looked at what was left.

The manor had stood for three hundred years. Now it was a shell. Black chimneys. Windows like missing teeth. The great stair open to the sky, climbing to nothing, and the garden gone to nettles and ash-pale grass.

“I haven’t been here since the night it burned,” Eleanor said.

“I know.”

“You stood in that doorway.”

“Yes.”

“You said—”

“I know what I said.”

She turned toward me. In the starlight her face was very young.

I had been twenty-three. She had been nineteen, and in mourning, and so thin that her wrists looked like they might snap. My father was ten hours dead in the cellar of the east wing. The fire had eaten the roof by dawn. And I had walked through the smoke and found her standing at the gate in her black dress with her hair coming down, staring at the flames, and I had said:

I will never let anything hurt you again.

It was the truest thing I have ever spoken.

It was also the most foolish.

“You have kept it,” Eleanor said quietly.

“I have tried.”

“Adrian.” Her gloved hand came to rest against my sleeve. “Did you love your father?”

The question went through me like a blade between the ribs.

“No,” I said. “But I obeyed him. It is a very different thing, and it took me a very long time to learn the difference.”

She was silent.

“And my father?” she said. “Mine?”

“He loved you.”

“That isn’t what I asked.”

I looked at the ruins and did not answer.

After a while she said, “I think I’d like to go home now.”

I took her hand and tucked it beneath my arm, and she let me, and we walked on up the orchard in the dark.

At the door of Vale House I kissed her forehead. She permitted it.

“Good night, my dear.”

“Good night.”

I stood on the step until the door closed. Then I stood there a little longer.

Behind me, across the water, the lighthouse burned.

I took out my watch and looked at the time. Eleven forty.

Twelve minutes.

For twelve years I had written the same sentence on the same night. *Extinguish the lamp at 11:52. Relight at 1:14.* I wrote it at my desk with a steady hand, and I signed it, and I sent it by the boy to the keeper, and I did not ask what the keeper thought of it.

This year, for the first time, I had not written it.

I had told myself it was for Eleanor’s sake. That she must not see the dark. That one night, at least, I could keep the light burning.

And the light had gone out anyway.

I watched the beam sweep once across the water, steady and white and true.

Then I walked home to Marlowe House and sat in my study until morning with the second key in my hand, and I did not sleep, and I did not pray.

I only wondered who had known to do my sin for me.

Chapter Four

The First Letter

Eleanor

“It was me,” said Mrs. Crowe.

She said it to the window, not to me. We were in the morning room, and the autumn light lay across the carpet in a long pale bar. She had come in with the tray and not put it down. Her knuckles had gone white on the handles.

“The letter,” I said.

“Yes.”

“You put it beneath my door.”

“I did.”

“Why?”

“Because I made a promise.” She set the tray on the little table at last and folded her hands in front of her. “She gave it to me the afternoon before. She said, *Hester, if anything happens to me, you are to keep this until the sea gives back what it took. Then you are to give it to Eleanor.*”

I stared at her. “Until the sea gives back what it took.”

“That’s what she said.”

“Twelve years, Mrs. Crowe.”

“Twelve years I have carried it in my apron, miss. In the pocket of every dress I owned.” Her voice cracked on the last word and she mastered it, as she mastered everything. “I wasn’t to give it until the sea gave something back. Not a body, not a boat. I did not know what. I thought I’d know it when I saw it.”

“And on Tuesday you saw it.”

“On Tuesday,” she said, “you came home.”

I sat down.

The room tilted gently, as rooms do in dreams. Outside, a gull cried and wheeled off over the garden wall. I thought: *She means me. I am the thing the sea has returned.*

“Did you write the second note?” I asked.

“What second note?”

I showed it to her. She read the six words. The color went out of her face so completely that for a moment I feared she would fall.

“No,” she whispered. “No, miss. That is not mine. I would never—”

“Do you know the handwriting?”

“I do not.” But her eyes had gone to the name at the bottom, and I watched her swallow. “You’ve been to see him.”

“Yes.”

“I told you not to.”

“You did.”

“And you went anyway, because you are your mother’s daughter.” She took a long breath. “Miss Eleanor. I will tell you what I can, and then I will tell you what I can’t. And you must not press me on the second part. Not yet.”

“That isn’t fair.”

“No. But it is all I have.”

What she could tell me was this.

On the night my mother died, Mrs. Crowe had been sent to bed at nine. She had heard voices below: my mother's, my father's, and a third she would not name. At half past nine she had heard glass breaking. At ten, my mother had come up the back stairs with her hands bleeding and her face like paper, and had asked for a pen.

"She wrote for ten minutes," Mrs. Crowe said. "Then she folded it and gave it to me. She put on her cloak. She said, *Do not let Eleanor leave her room.* And she went out into the storm."

"And you did not stop her."

"I tried."

"You did not *stop* her."

"Miss," she said, very low. "Nobody ever stopped your mother from doing anything."

It was true. I closed my eyes.

"And who was the third voice?"

"That is the part I cannot say."

"Cannot, or will not?"

"Both."

"Was it Adrian's father?"

She flinched. It was the tiniest motion, a shiver of the shoulders, but I saw it. I had been watching people lie for twelve years in London drawing rooms, and Mrs. Crowe was a poor liar for a woman who had kept a secret so long.

"I'll say nothing against the dead," she said.

"Then say something about the living. Did Adrian know?"

She did not answer.

"Mrs. Crowe."

"I think," she said carefully, "that Mr. Ashcombe has always loved you very much."

"That isn't what I asked."

"It's what I'm able to say."

I stood. I went to the window and put my forehead against the cold glass. My own breath fogged it. Below me, the garden stepped down to the cliff in terraces of wet lavender and box, and past the wall the lighthouse rose from its headland, small and white and impossibly innocent in the morning.

"I am going to find out," I said. "All of it. Whatever it costs."

“I know, miss.”

“Will you help me?”

“I will do what I promised your mother.”

“Which was?”

“To keep you alive.”

She went out and closed the door very softly behind her.

I played the piano that afternoon.

I had not meant to. I had passed the music room twice with my hand on the knob, and twice I had walked on. But the afternoon dragged, and the letters lay folded inside my corset like two hot coals, and the house pressed around me with all its held breath.

The instrument was a Broadwood grand, rosewood, with ivory keys yellowed to the color of old teeth. My mother had played on it every evening of my childhood. Chopin, mostly. Schubert when she was sad. Bach when she was angry, hard and precise, like a woman scrubbing a floor.

I sat down and put my hands on the keys.

They remembered.

It was the strangest thing. I had not touched this piano in twelve years. But my fingers found the opening of the Schubert impromptu as though no time had passed, and the room filled with it, that rippling, aching sound, a stream running under ice.

I played for an hour. I played until the light turned gold, and then amber, and then the color of old brandy. I played until I forgot to be afraid.

When I reached the end of the piece, I lifted my hands and let the last chord fade.

And in the silence, I heard the sea.

It was not the sea beyond the cliff. It was nearer. It seemed to come from inside the piano, a faint, wet, rushing sound, like a shell held to the ear.

I frowned. I bent and put my ear to the lid.

Nothing.

I struck the low A.

The note hummed. And beneath it, from somewhere under my feet, came an answering hollowness, a faint echo, as though the floor itself were an instrument.

I knelt and pressed my palm to the boards.

They were cold.

Colder than the rest of the room.

And when I rapped them with my knuckles, they gave back a sound that no solid floor should make.

The piano bench had a lid.

I had sat on it a thousand times and never lifted it. Inside lay sheet music, yellowed, familiar: Chopin, Schumann, the Bach preludes with my mother's pencil marks in the margins. I took them out in stacks and laid them on the carpet, and beneath the last of them, taped flat to the wood with a strip of linen gone brittle with age, I found a key.

Small. Black iron. A single notch cut in the bit like a bird's beak.

On the linen strip, in my mother's handwriting, were five words.

For when you are ready.

I held the key in the palm of my hand and felt it grow warm.

All my life I had thought of my mother as a woman who left things behind. Gloves. Bookmarks. A smell of orris and lamp oil in an empty room. I had never once thought of her as a woman who had *planned* it.

Someone knocked at the door of the music room.

I shut the bench so quickly it banged.

"Eleanor?"

Adrian.

He stood in the doorway with his hat in his hand, smiling, a little flushed from the wind. "Mrs. Crowe said you were playing. I did not like to interrupt."

"You didn't," I said.

"You've left your music on the floor."

"I was looking for something."

"Did you find it?"

"No," I said, and closed my fingers around the key.

He crossed the room and bent and gathered the sheets, one by one, and set them in order on the piano. He did it carefully. He did it the way one might touch a dead thing, with great tenderness and no hope of waking it.

"She played beautifully," he said.

"Yes."

“You play better.”

“That is not true.”

“I heard you from the garden, Eleanor.” He did not look up. “I stood there for twenty minutes. I could not make myself come in.”

I was silent.

“Come to dinner tomorrow,” he said at last. “Marlowe House. I will have the good wine opened. We shall talk about nothing.”

“I would like that.”

“Would you?”

I made myself smile. It cost something.

“Yes.”

He looked at me, then, steadily, and for the briefest instant I had the terrible feeling that he knew about the key. That he could see it through the glove of my fist. That he had always known exactly where I was.

Then he lifted my other hand to his lips and went away.

I waited until the front door shut. Then I walked, very quietly, to the entrance hall.

Beneath the great staircase, where the paneling met the floor, there was a door I had never in my life seen opened. A shallow door, painted the same dull green as the wall. A door for brooms. A door you stopped seeing.

I knelt before it.

The lock was small. The notch in the bit was like a bird’s beak.

And the key turned as if it had been waiting twelve years to be asked.

Chapter Five

The Room Beneath the Stairs

Eleanor

I went down with a candle in one hand and my skirts in the other, and the steps were slick with age.

There were eleven of them. I counted. They curved into the dark under the great staircase, in a stairwell so narrow my shoulders brushed the walls, and the air that rose to meet me smelled of tallow, damp stone, and something else, something sweet and old that I could not name.

At the bottom, a door.

It was not locked.

I stood with my hand on the iron latch and listened to my own breathing. *For when you are ready.* I was not ready. I do not think anyone ever is. But I had spent twelve years being not ready, and it had taught me nothing but how to wait.

I pushed.

The room was small, perhaps twelve feet square, and it had been a study.

A desk. A lamp. A reading chair with a shawl still draped over the arm, the wool gone gray with dust. Shelves of books on three walls; on the fourth, a chart table, and above the table, pinned with brass tacks, a vast sheet of paper covered in my mother's hand.

I went to it as one goes to a bed where someone lies sleeping.

It was a map of the island.

Not the sort printed for visitors. This was a working map, drawn in ink and annotated in pencil, with every cove and cliff and reef named. The Mare's Teeth were there, a ragged line of black marks off the eastern headland. The lighthouse. The abbey. Penhallow. Vale House. And scattered across the water, in tiny red crosses, nineteen marks, each with a date written beside it.

I read them.

14 Nov. 1863.

2 Mar. 1866.

30 Sept. 1871.

19 Jan. 1874.

On and on, down the years, in a hand that grew steadier as it went. The last cross was dated *28 Sept. 1879.*

The night she died.

I put the candle down.

Nineteen crosses. Nineteen dates. Beside each, a tiny notation: the name of a vessel, the tonnage, the port she had sailed from.

Anne Marie, brig, Bristol.

Constant, schooner, Falmouth.

Sparrowhawk, brig, Cardiff. 14 souls.

I turned to the shelves.

Ledgers. Dozens of them, bound in cloth and labeled in the same hand by year. I took down the nearest and opened it, and it was a book of weather. Wind, tide, moon, barometer. Hour by hour, night by night. A woman had sat in this room and recorded every storm that struck the island for sixteen years.

And beside each storm, a second column.

Light: burning.

Light: burning.

Light: burning.

Light: DARK.

I looked up. I looked at the map. I looked at the red crosses.

Light: DARK.

The pages went pale in my hands.

It does not happen in one stroke, understanding. It comes in layers, like the tide coming in over flat sand, so slowly that you cannot say when you began to drown. I thought of the shipwrecks I had heard of as a girl, the poor drowned sailors, the way my father said *the Teeth took her* as if the rocks were a beast with a will. I thought of the Michaelmas supper. The beams in the roof, salvaged from ships.

The beams in the Assembly Room.

The silver candlesticks on my father's sideboard, the lacquered chest in the hall, the Chinese bowl my mother would not allow us to use. Cargo. Every one. Dragged up from the foam and the rocks and the drowned.

I sat down heavily in the reading chair, and a puff of dust rose around me.

"Oh, Mother," I said aloud. "What did you find?"

There were letters in the desk drawer.

Not mine. Not hers. Drafts, scored with crossings-out, addressed to men whose names I knew: the Bishop of Truro, the Board of Trade, a magistrate at Penzance. The first was dated June of that last year. *Sirs, I write with the greatest hesitation, and with the knowledge that you will think me mad.*

The second was blotted with something that might have been tears.

The third was not a draft at all. It was a clean copy, sealed, stamped, and never sent. Addressed to the Reverend Thomas Blackwood. Beneath the seal she had written, in small neat letters: *To be delivered by hand. Not by post. Not by any servant of this house.*

I did not open it.

I held it for a long while, and then I put it back, because I knew what it would tell me, and because I could not yet bear to be told.

At the bottom of the drawer lay something else.

A small velvet bag, drawn shut with a cord.

I loosened it and tipped it into my hand, and nine pearls rolled into my palm, round and flawless and cold.

I counted them twice.

Nine.

On my mother's portrait upstairs, the necklace had been strung with ten.

I do not know how long I sat there.

At some point the candle began to gutter, and I took a fresh one from the shelf and lit it from the stub. The flame steadied. In its light I saw, behind the chart table, a narrow door I had not noticed, set into the stone and no taller than my shoulder. Its iron hinges were fresh with oil.

I bent to it.

It was bolted from this side.

Beyond it, I could hear air moving. Slow. Cold. A long, low exhalation, like something breathing in a cave.

I drew the bolt.

The door swung inward onto a passage cut in the living rock. The walls sweated. The floor sloped away into the dark. And at the edge of my candle's glow, three paces in, there was a footprint in the damp.

A man's boot. Large. Fresh.

Beside it, a smear of wax, still soft.

My candle shook.

Someone has been here.

Someone has been here today.

I thought of the footsteps outside my bedroom door. The slow, deliberate tread. I thought of the note that had come in the night, the damp paper, the unfamiliar hand. I thought: *The house is not empty. It has never been empty. It has other doors than the ones I know.*

From somewhere far down the passage, a sound drifted back to me.

A cough.

Low, rasping, human.

Then a scuff of leather on stone. Then nothing.

I stood in the mouth of the tunnel with my heart in my throat and my mother's pearls in my fist, and I did not go in.

I am not brave. People say I am. I am only stubborn, which looks the same from outside.

"Who's there?" I said.

The tunnel swallowed my voice and gave back nothing.

I waited a full minute. Then, very softly, I closed the little door, shot the bolt, and backed away.

The reading chair creaked as I passed it.

On the arm lay the shawl, and under the shawl, something I had missed: a small book, bound in black cloth, its spine unmarked. I took it up. It was warm, as though a hand had just left it.

I opened it to the first page.

This is the private diary of Margaret Vale. If you are not Margaret Vale, you should stop reading. If you are Eleanor, I am so sorry.

I closed it.

I opened it again.

I read the first line, and the second. Then I heard, high above me, the heavy tread of boots in the entrance hall.

"Eleanor?"

Adrian's voice.

"Eleanor, my dear. Mrs. Crowe says you've vanished. Are you in the house?"

I blew out the candle.

In the dark I stood very still, holding my mother's diary against my heart, and listened to the man I was going to marry walk across the hall above my head, back and forth, back and forth, slow and unhurried.

He stopped.

Directly above the green door.

I did not breathe.

Then, as slowly as he had come, he went away.

Chapter Six

The Sound of the Sea

Gabriel

She came back on the third morning.

I had told myself she would not. I had told myself so with great firmness for two days, while I trimmed wicks and scrubbed brass and polished the Fresnel lens until I could see my own face distorted across a hundred glass prisms. A man can tell himself anything if he is busy enough.

At a quarter to eight I heard boots on the gravel, and I knew them as I would have known my own heartbeat.

I did not go to the door. I stood at the chart table with a rag in my hand and listened to her knock, and I counted to five, and then I opened it as though I had not been waiting.

She wore the gray coat again. Her cheeks were flushed from the climb. A few strands of dark hair had come loose in the wind, and she had not bothered to tuck them back, and I discovered that I was looking at her mouth.

I stopped.

“Mr. Thorne.”

“Miss Vale. You are early.”

“I thought you were a man who rose early.”

“I thought you were a woman who took my advice.”

“You were mistaken,” said Eleanor, “in both cases,” and walked past me into the cottage as if it were hers.

She laid the things out on my table one at a time, like a surgeon laying out instruments.

A black velvet bag. A faded sheet of paper, folded in eight, which when she unfolded it proved to be a map. A small iron key.

“I found a room,” she said, “under the stairs of Vale House.”

I said nothing.

“My mother kept it. For years, I think. It is full of her handwriting. She recorded every storm, Mr. Thorne. Every wreck. Every night the light failed.” She tapped the map with one gloved finger. “Nineteen ships. Nineteen crosses. The last one is the night she died.”

“The *Sparrowhawk*.”

“You know the name.”

“It’s in the logbooks.”

“Is it in the logbooks that fourteen men drowned?”

I looked at her. “Yes.”

“And that the light was dark?”

“Yes.”

“And that this is not a thing that happens by accident, nineteen times in sixteen years, always in a gale, always on the ship with the richest cargo?”

I put down the rag.

“No,” I said. “It isn’t.”

She drew a breath, as though she had been braced for me to deny it. I think she had. It was a courageous breath, and it shook a little at the end.

“My mother found out. She wrote to the Bishop. She wrote to the Board of Trade. And then she died.”

“Miss Vale—”

“Do you know who held the key to the lantern room twelve years ago?”

“The magistrate.”

“Lord Ashcombe.”

“Yes.”

“Adrian’s father.”

I could have lied. It would have been so easy. But I had looked at her face in the doorway of this cottage on that first morning, and I had seen what it cost her to ask a question she already knew the answer to, and I found that I could not add to the weight.

“Yes,” I said.

She closed her eyes.

For a moment, neither of us moved. Gulls cried on the cliff. The kettle ticked on the stove. And I thought, with the clarity of a man watching a wave come in: *I am going to touch her. I am going to put my hand on her shoulder, and there will be no going back.*

I put my hands in my pockets instead.

I took her up the tower because I could not think what else to do.

It is a hundred and twelve steps. The stair is iron, spiraling up through the whitewashed throat of the lighthouse, and by the fortieth she had stopped talking and by the eightieth she was breathing hard. I did not offer my hand. She did not ask for it. At the top she stood with her palm flat against the lantern room door and said, between breaths, “You might have warned me.”

“I did. I said it was a long climb.”

“You said *a lot of steps.* It’s not the same.”

“It’s a lot of steps.”

She laughed.

It was the first time. It startled both of us. It came out of her short and bright and genuinely surprised, like a bird flushed from a hedge, and she put her hand over her mouth, and her eyes above it were wet and shining.

I opened the door of the lantern room.

Morning poured in.

The glass walls blazed with it. Sky on every side, a bowl of blue and silver; the sea below like hammered metal; the whole island laid out like a map unrolled on a table. And in the center of it all, the great lens, taller than a man, a beehive of brass and prisms that took the morning and broke it into a thousand pieces, a thousand rainbows crawling over the walls.

Eleanor stood perfectly still.

“Oh,” she said.

I have seen men weep at that sight. Seamen, hard as nails. I have seen a Trinity House inspector take off his hat. And I have lived with it for six years, and it still stops my breath, and I have never been able to say why. But I watched her face as the light moved across it, and I understood, in a rush, that I had been wrong. I had not been seeing it. I had been *waiting* to see it. For her.

“It’s a lens,” I said, uselessly. “It concentrates the lamp. One flame, twelve miles of reach.”

“I know what it is.”

“Do you.”

“I’ve been looking at it from my window since I was five years old.” She moved closer, and her fingertips hovered an inch from the glass. “I never imagined it was so *near.* Or so beautiful.”

“It’s very old.”

“Don’t.”

“Don’t what?”

“Be gruff,” she said, turning. “You’re doing it on purpose. You hide behind facts. I’ve been doing it for years in company, so I recognize the technique.”

“What technique?”

“Telling the truth in such small pieces that no one can ever see the shape of the whole.”

I opened my mouth and had nothing to put in it.

She smiled at me, a small tired knowing smile, and I felt the floor of my chest go out from under me.

We sat on the gallery afterward, on the stone, with our backs against the lantern wall and the sea a hundred feet below.

The wind was cold. She had taken off her gloves. Her hands were long and narrow, the fingers a little roughened at the tips, and I watched them lie in her lap and thought of the music I had heard from the cliff path two nights running.

“You play,” I said.

She looked at me. “How do you know?”

“Vale House carries sound. The wind comes off the water, up the terraces. I’ve heard Schubert on three evenings.”

“You listen to me?”

“I can’t help it. It comes in through the glass.”

“What did you think?”

I considered lying. I considered *very nice, Miss Vale.* Instead, I said, “That I’ve never heard anything lonelier.”

She was quiet for a time.

“Do you know,” she said, “what I was most afraid of, coming back? Not the house. Not the ghosts. I was afraid I would find that I’d forgotten her. That after all these years there would be nothing left except a portrait and an empty room, and I would have to pretend it hurt.”

“And?”

“And I have found her handwriting in a hole beneath the stairs, and a map of the dead, and she is more alive to me than she has been since I was eighteen.” Her voice caught. “And I can’t tell whether I’m grateful, or whether I’m going to be sick.”

“Both,” I said. “Usually both.”

She turned her head.

I had not meant to say it. It was out before I could stop it, and she heard in it what I had not meant to give. A small, quiet, terrible knowledge. The knowledge of someone who has also lost a person and cannot decide whether to curse the grief or the gift.

“Who?” she said.

“My brother.”

“Samuel.”

“Yes.”

“Mrs. Crowe said he was never found.”

“He wasn’t.”

“I’m so sorry.”

“Don’t be,” I said. “It was a long time ago.”

“Six years is not very long.”

“No.”

She reached out then, and laid her hand over mine on the stone.

It was a small thing. An ordinary gesture of sympathy, such as any decent woman might make. But her hand was warm and I had not been touched in six years. Not once. Not a hand, not a sleeve. And I felt it go through me like a current through a wire, down my arm and into my chest and out into the soles of my feet.

I did not move.

She did not move.

The wind moaned in the rail. Below us, a long swell rose and broke on the Teeth, a boom like a distant door.

“Gabriel,” she said.

It was the first time she had used my name.

“Don’t,” I said hoarsely.

“Why?”

“Because I’ll answer.”

“Yes,” said Eleanor, very softly. “I rather thought you might.”

I took my hand out from under hers.

It was the hardest thing I have ever done. Harder than the amputations. Harder than the night of the wreck. I stood up, and I looked out to sea so that I would not look at her, and I said, "You're engaged to be married."

"I know."

"To a man I've given you every reason to distrust."

"I know that, too."

"Then go home. Please."

For a long time she sat where she was. Then she rose, brushing her skirts, and picked up her gloves, and stood at my shoulder looking out at the horizon.

"I'll go," she said. "But I'll be back tomorrow. And the day after. And when I come, Gabriel Thorne, you will tell me what you know, or I will find it without you."

"Eleanor—"

"I am not asking permission."

She went in. I heard her boots on the iron stair, a long ringing descent, fading, and then the door of the cottage, and then silence.

I stood on the gallery for a very long time.

In my pocket, wrapped in a square of lint, a single pearl pressed against my thigh like a closed eye.

I thought: *She has nine.*

I thought: *She has no idea what she's holding.*

And I thought, with a despair so clean it was nearly joy, that I would tell her. Everything. In time. And that when I did, she would never touch my hand again.

Chapter Seven

A Photograph in the Rain

Eleanor

The dinner at Marlowe House was exactly as dull as I had feared, and exactly as dangerous.

Adrian had opened the good wine. He had lit every candle in the dining room. He had even, with a lover's absurd precision, ordered the table laid with my mother's favorite blue china, which he had somehow acquired from the sale of the Vale effects. I sat there in my black silk gown and ate his chicken and let him tell me about London, and I watched his hands.

They were steady, elegant, beautifully kept. They were the hands of a man who had never been afraid.

I saw those hands covered in blood.

"You are very quiet, my dear."

"I'm sorry. I was thinking of the abbey."

"The abbey?"

"I thought I might see it. Before the wedding." I sipped the wine. "I never went inside as a girl. My mother wouldn't let me."

His glass paused an inch from his lips.

"There is nothing to see," Adrian said. "It's a ruin. The roof fell in during the great storm of '74. The Reverend holds services in the parish church now."

"Mr. Blackwood keeps the records there?"

"Who told you that?"

"No one. I assumed."

"You assume a good deal." He smiled, and it was a good smile, a smile that had won over bishops. "I'll take you up myself in the spring, if you like. It's too dangerous to wander alone."

"Of course."

"Promise me you won't go on your own."

"I promise," I said, and added the lie to the pile.

It rained for two days.

Not the soft gray rain of the mainland, but the hard salt kind, driven sideways off the Atlantic, that stripped the last leaves from the orchard and turned the cliff path to a river of red mud. I waited until Thursday afternoon, until Mrs. Crowe had gone down to the village, and I put on my oldest boots and my mother's oilskin and went out the kitchen door like a thief.

I told myself I was going to read the diary.

I had been reading it in stolen quarters of an hour for three nights, in the window seat, by a stub of candle, and it had broken my heart in small clean pieces. Not for the grand reasons I'd expected. For the small ones. *Eleanor has a cough again. The ham was dry. J. has gone to Truro and I confess I am glad.* She had written the way women write who know no one is listening, with an honesty so plain that I felt I'd been given a key to a locked room.

But there was a hole in it.

Four pages, torn out. The entries between 3 June and 14 August of that last year. And after the gap, the tone had changed. The shopping lists were gone. The little domestic jokes. In their place, a hard dry vigilance, like a woman on a ship in fog.

I have told no one what I saw in the crypt. Not Eleanor. Not Hester. Certainly not J.

I have found a friend. I did not expect it. He is young and he is frightened, and he is the only person on this island who has looked at me in a month and seen a woman instead of a wife.

Who?

The diary didn't say. Only *he*, and *the boy,* and once, *our G.*

I stood at the top of the cliff path in the rain, and my boots sank to the ankle, and I said the letter aloud. *G.*

Then I walked on.

The cottage door was closed.

I knocked, and no one answered, and I knocked again. The rain came harder. The sky above the lantern had gone the color of slate, and the beam, which should not have been lit before four, was already turning, a slow white arm in the murk.

I pushed the door open.

"Gabriel?"

The room was empty. The stove was lit. A kettle steamed gently on the hob and the table was laid for one: a mug, a heel of bread, an open book face down beside them. I stood dripping on the stone floor and called again, and heard only the hiss of the fire and the roar of the rain on the slates.

He must be at the top of the tower.

I should have waited. I know that. A woman of sense would have sat in the chair by the stove and let him come down. But I had walked a mile and a quarter through a storm to hear something true, and the room was warm and silent, and on the table beside the open book lay a second book, thick and black with a cracked spine.

I picked it up.

I told myself I was only moving it to dry my gloves.

It was a medical textbook. *Gray's Anatomy, 1877.* The paper was soft with handling, and a pressed flower marked a page in the middle, a sea-pink gone brown. I turned the cover over, and a photograph slid out into my hand.

It was a small thing. Three inches by four, on stiff cardboard, brown with age. A carte de visite, the kind that were all the rage in the seventies, with a photographer's stamp on the back: *Fenwick & Son, Penzance.*

Three people stood in front of a painted backdrop of a balustrade and a cloudy sky. A stout man in a black coat, with a grave tired face: Dr. Silas Reed, who had treated me for scarlet fever when I was six. A boy of nineteen or twenty with dark hair and gray eyes, standing a half step too far from the others, as though he were not sure he was allowed.

And between them, in a pale gown, with a pearl necklace at her throat and her hand resting lightly on the boy's sleeve, my mother.

She was laughing.

She was laughing as I had never seen her laugh in life. Her head tipped, her eyes narrowed with it. The photographer had caught her mid-breath. She looked about twenty-five years old, and happy, and unguarded, and she had her hand on Gabriel Thorne's arm like a woman touching someone she loved.

I read the date on the back.

Aug. 1879.

Six weeks before she died.

The photograph did not fall. I do not know why I thought it might. I stood with it in my hand, and the world went very quiet and far away, and I thought, in a clear cold voice that did not seem my own: *He knew her.*

He knew her. He lied to me. He sat on that gallery with the sea at his back and said "I am sorry for your loss" and let me weep on his sleeve, and he knew her.

"Eleanor."

I turned.

He stood in the doorway with the rain running off his oilskin and an oil can in his hand. His hair was plastered to his forehead. His face was white.

He looked at the photograph.

He looked at me.

"You went through my things," he said.

"Yes."

"You had no right."

"No." I held up the card. "Neither did you. Tell me this isn't what it looks like."

"It's exactly what it looks like."

"Then you *lied.*"

"I never said I didn't know her."

“You said you had never been on this island before six years ago!”

“I said I came as keeper six years ago. Mrs. Crowe told you the rest.”

“Don’t.” My voice broke. “Don’t use that voice on me. Don’t do the small true pieces. I asked you on the first day, I *asked* you, and you sat across from me and drank your tea and let me think —”

“Eleanor—”

“Who were you to her?”

He set the oil can down on the table. He did it with great care, as though it might go off.

“I was her friend,” he said.

“A *friend.* She is touching you.”

“She was kind to me.”

“Is that all?”

“What do you want me to say?”

“That it wasn’t what I think!”

“What do you think?”

I could not answer. Even to myself, it was only a shape. A chill, a shadow, a drowned thing turning over in the deep. I had seen the way she touched his sleeve, and I had read the word *friend* in her diary, and I had wanted, with a vehemence that frightened me, for it to be a lie. A lie I could hate him for. A clean lie, with edges.

“Tell me,” I said. “Tell me now, or I will walk out into that rain and not come back.”

He took a breath. I saw the muscle jump in his jaw.

“I cannot,” he said.

“Cannot?”

“Not today. Not this way. Not with you standing there looking at me like that.” His voice cracked. “I promise you, I will tell you every word. I’ve told no one. I’ve carried it so long I don’t know how to set it down. But you’ll hear it from me, and in order, and I will not have you hear it in anger.”

“That is not good enough.”

“It is the only thing I have.”

“Then it is nothing.”

The words were cruel. I knew it as I said them. I watched them land, and watched his face go quiet and shut, like a house in which every light has been put out at once.

I pushed past him, into the storm.

He did not follow.

I got as far as the gorse.

The rain was blinding. My mother's oilskin hung off my shoulders like a sack of wet sand. The path was a ditch of red water, and I slipped, and caught myself, and slipped again, and found that I was weeping, which I had not planned.

"Damn him," I said aloud. "Damn him, damn him."

Behind me, I heard the cottage door.

Not footsteps. Only the door, opening, and then, over the wind, a voice that carried across the headland in a cracked thin shout:

"Eleanor! The path is breaking! Stay on the left!"

I stood still.

"The left! The cliff's undercut past the second stile!"

I looked at the ground. The edge, three feet to my right, was not an edge at all but a lip of crumbling turf with nothing under it. In the dim light I had been walking along it for a hundred yards.

I moved left.

When I looked back, he had gone in. The door was shut. The lantern burned above the cottage like a white star, steady and watchful, as it had burned for sixty years.

I walked home with the photograph still clenched in my fist, and I did not realize until I reached the kitchen door that I had taken it.

I stood on the flagstones, dripping, and looked at my mother laughing.

Tell me you didn't love him, I thought.

Tell me what he was to you.

Tell me what he is to me.

Chapter Eight

The Magistrate's Secret

Adrian

There is a particular silence that falls in a man's study after midnight, when the servants are abed and the fire has burned down to the shape of a face.

I have known it all my life.

It was the silence of my father's study, which I entered as a boy only to be punished and as a man only to be instructed. It was the silence of the courthouse, where I sat in judgment on fishermen who had taken a salmon out of season. It was the silence of the long years in London, when I dined with men who spoke of the island as one speaks of a pretty colony, and I nodded, and smiled, and counted the days.

Tonight it was the silence of a man deciding to burn a house down.

Not a house. A page.

I had it before me on the blotter, flattened under a brass paperweight shaped like a lighthouse. A foolish ornament. Eleanor had given it to me when she was fourteen and I was eighteen, wrapped in a handkerchief, with a note that said *so you will always know where home is.* I had kept it for sixteen years.

The page beneath it was a leaf from the Harbor Register for the autumn of 1879.

I knew every line of it by heart.

Sept. 28. Wind SW, strong, rising. Barometer falling. Brig Sparrowhawk, *Cardiff for Falmouth, 14 hands, sighted at four bells in the afternoon watch, standing in to shelter.*

Light dark, by order.

Vessel struck at 12:08 a.m. All hands lost.

Three lines in a clerk's neat copperplate. I had found them that afternoon in a tin box at the back of Marlowe House cellar, under a sack of seed potatoes, where my father had hidden them thirty years before and where, I suppose, he trusted I would never look.

By order.

By *his* order.

I read the lines again. I had read them four times already, and it did not help.

I should say here what I knew.

I have promised myself to be honest in these pages, though I do not know who will read them. Perhaps no one. Perhaps the fire. But it is a small mercy to set the thing down in order, so I will.

I knew that my father had darkened the light on stormy nights. I had known it since I was fifteen, when he took me up the cliff path in a gale and showed me, as another man might show his son how to fish, the three turns of the key that stopped the lamp. *It is an old arrangement,* he said. *It feeds the island. Your grandfather did it. His father did.* I asked him about the ships. He said, *The sea takes what it wants. We only help it decide.*

I was fifteen. I believed him.

I knew that Josiah Vale had a share. That every autumn a chest of silver was carried quietly up the Vale House drive, and that Margaret did not ask whence it came.

I knew, because I was told, that on the night of the twenty-eighth of September, 1879, my father had put out the lamp for the *Sparrowhawk.*

And I knew, because I was *there*, because I was twenty-two and had followed him to the cliff in the rain out of some stupid boy's curiosity, what happened on the gallery after Margaret Vale came up the stair.

I did not know what to call it.

I still don't.

I know only that when I came to myself I was standing on the rocks below the lighthouse with my arms in the sea to the shoulder, and that the thing I was holding was a woman's body, and that the water was black, and that there was blood on my hands that would not wash off.

Eleanor saw me. I knew it that night. She stood at the window of Vale House, a white blur behind the glass, and watched me carry her mother up the cliff.

I never knew how much she remembered.

I think I have been waiting twelve years for her to tell me.

A knock.

I looked up. Thorne stood in the doorway.

Not Gabriel Thorne. Never him. I would have known his tread. This was a boy of fifteen, in a wet jersey, one of the fishermen's sons; he held his cap in both hands and his eyes were round.

"Mr. Ashcombe, sir. I'm to give you this."

He held out an envelope. I took it. My name, in an unfamiliar, slanting hand, and below it, in smaller letters: *Tonight.*

"Who gave you this?"

"A man, sir. At the harbor wall."

"What man?"

"I couldn't see his face. He had a hood." The boy swallowed. "He said you'd know."

I slit the seal with my thumb.

Mr. Ashcombe. You have a page that does not belong to you. Burn it, and Eleanor Vale lives. Keep it, and she will find it. I am not your enemy. I only want it finished. A friend.

I read it three times.

Then I looked at the paper under my paperweight, and the paper in my hand, and thought: *Who knows I have it? Who could possibly have known?*

“Sir?” said the boy.

“Go home,” I said. “Tell no one.”

He fled.

I burned the page at one o’clock in the morning.

I held it by the corner over the fire and watched the flame take the first line, *Sept. 28,* and curl up the paper in a brown tongue. It was a small fire. It made almost no sound. The ink went black, then gold, then white. *Brig* Sparrowhawk *… Light dark, by order … All hands lost …*

I watched it all go.

When it was ash, I crushed it between my fingers and let it fall into the grate, and I stood there with my hand black to the wrist and thought: *I have done it again.*

I have done what my father would have done.

It is a curious thing, the shame of becoming one’s father. It does not strike like a blow. It comes up like damp through a wall. One morning you find that your gestures are his gestures, and your silences his silences, and the very thing you have sworn all your life never to be is looking out at you from the mirror with your eyes.

I had sworn to protect her.

I had never once asked from what.

The clock struck two. Somewhere under the floor the old house groaned, settling in the cold.

I went to the window and drew the curtain.

Across the dark water, the lighthouse turned its patient arm. And at the foot of it, so far away that I might have invented it, a single point of yellow light burned in the keeper’s cottage window.

Thorne.

I had seen them together on the cliff, that Tuesday. A hundred yards off, through a glass. I had watched Eleanor’s face lift to his, and the way he stood very straight with his hands clenched at his sides, the way a man stands who is holding himself back from a fall. I had watched her touch him.

I had put the glass down and gone indoors and drunk a bottle of brandy, and not told a soul.

I loved her. I want to be plain about that, in this one place where it can do no harm. I loved her from the day she was fourteen and gave me a brass lighthouse wrapped in a handkerchief. I loved her through the years of silence, the letters she never answered, the long London winters. I loved her when she came home. I loved her when she looked at me across the dinner table with her mother's eyes and said *the truth.*

I would have given her anything.

I could not give her that.

Because the truth was a house with only one door, and on the other side of it, Margaret Vale lay in the water with her eyes open, and my father stood above her on the gallery with the lamp key in his hand, and I—

I did nothing.

That was the whole of it. That was the secret that had kept me awake for twelve years, and drawn me to the bottle, and pulled me into the magistrate's chair with a hand I could not control.

I did nothing.

I let it happen, and then I carried her, and then I helped him bury it.

At three, I went down to the cellar.

The tin box was where I had left it. I put the lid back on, and took it up the stairs, and out the back door into the garden, and I buried it beneath the roses with a spade I found by the shed. The earth was cold and wet. I dug until my arms ached, and when I had done I stood leaning on the handle and looked at the freshly turned soil, black and raw and unmistakable.

Burn it, and Eleanor Vale lives.

Whoever had written that note had understood me perfectly. They knew I would do anything for her. They had known exactly which string to pull.

I did not know whether they meant to help me or to make me complicit. I did not know whether it was Reed, or the Reverend, or one of the old sailors who had never forgiven the island. I only knew that I had been warned, and I had obeyed, and that in obeying I had become something I could never undo.

I put the spade back in the shed.

I washed my hands in the scullery sink, a long time, with carbolic soap, until the skin was raw.

The blood did not come off.

It never does.

But in the morning I put on a clean collar, and I took my hat, and I walked up the road to Vale House with a bunch of yellow chrysanthemums, because Eleanor's mother had loved them and Eleanor had said, once, that she did too.

Mrs. Crowe opened the door.

"Mr. Ashcombe."

"Mrs. Crowe. Is Miss Vale at home?"

She looked at me, hard, for slightly too long.

"She's in the music room," she said. "She's been playing since dawn."

I stood in the hall with the flowers in my hand and heard it. Chopin. A nocturne. Slow, grieving, perfect.

I stood and listened until the last chord faded.

Then I put the chrysanthemums in a vase, and straightened my cuffs, and went to tell the woman I loved a lie.

Chapter Nine

The Night of the Shipwreck

Gabriel

She came on the fifth day, and she did not knock.

It was dusk. I was in the kitchen of the cottage, scraping the skin off a pot of porridge that had scorched, because I had stopped eating properly and had begun to treat meals as an inconvenience, and I heard the latch lift. I turned with the spoon in my hand.

Eleanor stood in the doorway in the red light of the dying sun.

She had been crying. She had stopped. The traces were still there, faint and pink around the eyes, and her chin was lifted in a way I was beginning to know.

"I have not forgiven you," she said.

"I didn't expect you to."

"I've read my mother's diary."

"All of it?"

"There are pages missing."

I put down the spoon.

“But I know enough,” Eleanor said. “I know she had a friend, a young man she called *our G.* I know she paid for his schooling. I know she was frightened of something, and that she trusted him. And I know that you are he, and you never told me.” She drew a breath. “I came to say that I will hear it. Everything. From the beginning. And that I will not interrupt.”

“Not tonight.”

“Gabriel.”

“There’s a part of it I can’t tell you yet.” I met her eyes. “But there’s another part I can. It’s the part you asked me first, on the first morning. Why I abandoned the navy. Why I came to this place. I’ll tell you that. If you’ll sit.”

She looked at me for a long moment.

Then she took off her gloves, and sat down at my table, and folded her hands.

“I was surgeon’s second on the *Halcyon,*” I said.

I will tell it as I told it then. I find I cannot tell it any other way.

“She was a frigate, ten years old, built at Chatham. A good ship. Four hundred men, give or take. I’d been with her three years; I’d gone out as a junior dresser and been promoted when Dr. Hallam died of fever at Alexandria. I was twenty-six. I had a cabin the size of a coffin and a medicine chest and more responsibility than I knew what to do with. And I had my brother.”

“Samuel.”

“Samuel was seventeen when I took him aboard, and twenty by the night of the wreck. Our mother was dead; our father had been drowned off Bude. I’d been a poor guardian, always away. I thought I might make him into something. A midshipman, perhaps. He had a quick head. He could read a chart by moonlight.” My voice thickened. “He was the best of us.”

Eleanor said nothing. She had said she would not interrupt, and she was a woman who kept her word.

“We were homeward bound. Three years on the station, a cargo of invalids and brass and two hundred barrels of Madeira. It was April. The Channel had been wicked for a week. We’d been two days beating up against a south-westerly with the storm jib split, and the captain was a careful man, Captain Wray, and he did not want to anchor in open water with a rising glass.”

The window glowed behind her. The light moved on the table between us, red going to rose.

“He knew of a harbor. A refuge, on the Cornish coast, with a lighthouse. A good old light, he said. On the Mare’s Teeth. Visible twelve miles. We’d run in under its lee and ride out the night.

“We raised it at nine o’clock. I was in the sick bay, strapping a man’s ribs. I heard the lookout call, and I heard a cheer go along the deck, and I thought: *thank God.* I thought it would be over soon.”

“And the light—”

“It was burning.” I stared at the grain of the table. “It was burning at nine. At ten. At eleven. We made our approach along the line of the beam, as every sailor on earth would have done, and there was a swell running, and a hard flaw out of the southwest, and at five minutes to midnight, the light went out.”

I could hear her breathing.

“It did not flicker. It did not fade. It went out like a hand over a candle. One moment there was a lighthouse, and the next there was a hole in the sky where it had been.” I swallowed. “And the captain shouted for the helmsman to bring her about, and the helmsman couldn’t see to do it, and I felt the whole ship lift under my feet and come down on something that was not water.”

“The Teeth.”

“The Teeth.” I pressed my palm flat on the wood. “She broke her back in eleven minutes. I counted. I counted because I could not do anything else. I was on the orlop deck with forty men in hammocks and the whole ship was screaming. The water came in through the gunports. It came up the companionway like a white tongue. I got as many out as I could. Eleven. I carried a boy up the ladder with a broken leg, and when I came on deck there was nothing on the sea but wreckage and men, and the rain, and the dark.”

“And Samuel?”

“I saw him once.”

I stopped.

She did not speak. She did not touch me. I will never forget that; she simply waited, her hands very still, and let the silence be as long as it needed to be.

“He was clinging to a spar. Forty yards off. I shouted. He saw me. He raised an arm. I swam to him, or tried to. There was a wave.” I shut my eyes. “I remember the wave. I remember it standing up behind him like a wall. And then he wasn’t there, and I was in the water, and something hit me in the head.”

I touched the old scar above my left ear. I did it without thinking. I had done it a thousand times.

“They found me on the beach at dawn. Two fishermen. I’d washed ashore half a mile from here, with a cracked skull and a lung full of salt water. I lay in a bed at the Reed house for three weeks, and when I woke I learned that two hundred and eleven men had died, and that the lighthouse keeper, old Pennick, had been found drowned at the foot of his own tower the morning after.”

Eleanor made a small sound.

“And I knew,” I said. “I knew in my body, as you know a thing in a dream. I’d stood at that rail. I’d watched that light. It does not go out by itself. It was *put* out. Someone knew we were coming, and they put it out, and they let two hundred men die.”

“Gabriel—”

“I went to the Admiralty. Court of Inquiry. I told them everything. They listened. They thanked me. They said the light had failed through the negligence of a drunken keeper, God rest his soul, and that no further inquiry was necessary.” A laugh, ugly and short. “A drunken keeper. Pennick, who’d never taken a drink in his life. They wrote it up and filed it. I was told I had suffered a blow to the head and that my recollections of the sequence of events were unreliable. They offered me a pension and a rest cure.”

“And you refused.”

“I resigned my commission. I wrote to Trinity House. They had a vacancy. They did not ask why a naval surgeon wanted to keep a lamp on a headland in the middle of nowhere.” I looked up at last. “I came to find out who had killed my brother.”

There was a long silence.

The sun had set. The red had drained out of the room, and the kettle had begun to cool, and in the corner the stove ticked softly as the iron contracted. Eleanor’s face was in shadow. I could not see her eyes.

“You did not come to find out who killed Samuel,” she said at last. “You came to find out who killed my mother.”

I went very still.

“You said it yourself,” she went on. “On the first day. The light goes out on the anniversary. You had the logbook. You knew what I would find. You were not simply a survivor. You were *looking.* You’d been looking since you arrived, because the island’s secrets were already in you.”

“Yes.”

“Because you knew her.”

“Yes.”

“Because you were there that night.”

I did not answer.

I did not need to. She had stopped being a woman who needed answers. She was a woman who read faces, and mine was an open book, and I watched her read it. Watched the understanding come into her features, slow and terrible, like a dawn after a disaster.

“Gabriel,” she whispered. “What did you do?”

“Not tonight.”

“What did you *do?*”

“I will tell you,” I said. “I swear on my brother’s name. I will tell you when I have something that can prove it. Not a confession, Eleanor. A *fact.* Because I’ve sworn a thousand oaths in six years and every one of them has turned to water in my mouth, and I will not give you another that I cannot keep.”

She stood.

She stood slowly, one hand on the back of the chair, and for a moment I thought she would strike me. Instead she crossed the little room, three paces, and stood before me in the dark.

“Look at me,” she said.

I looked.

Her eyes were wet. Her mouth was set. She was the loveliest and most terrifying thing I had ever seen.

“I do not know you,” she said. “I do not know whether you are a murderer or a martyr. I know that my mother loved you. I know that you flinch when I touch you. And I know that, God help me, when you told me about your brother, I believed every word.”

“Then—”

“So we will do this together,” said Eleanor Vale. “You and I. We’ll find the proof. The ledger. The names. The witness. Whatever it is. And when we have it, you’ll tell me the rest. And I will decide.”

“What if you decide against me?”

“Then I will have been wrong about you,” she said. “And I will have found out in time.”

She held out her hand.

It was the right hand, bare, with the long fingers and the roughened tips. It trembled a little. I looked at it for a long time.

Then I took it.

It was cold, and it was strong, and it did not let go.

Outside the sea breathed in and out against the Teeth, patient as the dead, and the first lamp of the evening spun up in the tower above us, and began to turn.

Chapter Ten

The Diary

Eleanor

Mrs. Crowe brought me the missing pages at six in the morning, folded inside a hymnal.

She did not knock. She came into my bedroom with a candle and a cup of tea I had not asked for, and set the tea on the nightstand, and stood by the bed with the hymnal pressed to her chest like a shield. In the guttering light she looked a hundred years old.

"I told you I'd say what I could," she said. "This is the rest of what I can."

"What is it?"

"Your mother tore them out herself. The week before she died. She gave them to me and said, *If anyone comes asking for the diary, Hester, give them the book and not these.*" She held out the hymnal. Her hand shook. "I have kept them in a place no one would look. The Book of Common Prayer is not a thing a man like Mr. Ashcombe would trouble to open."

I sat up. I took it.

Inside the cover, tucked between *Hymns Ancient and Modern* and the flyleaf, four sheets of cream notepaper had been folded in thirds. My mother's hand. The ink had faded to the brown of dried tea.

"Why now?" I whispered.

"Because I watched you come in from the rain on Thursday with your face like a ghost's," said Mrs. Crowe. "Because I am sixty-six years old and I have been afraid for twelve of them. And because that man up on the headland looked at you from his doorway as though you were the last thing in the world he was permitted to want." She turned to go. "Read it, miss. And then decide whether you'd have been better off not."

3rd June, 1879.

I have done something I swore I would not do. I went down to the abbey crypt alone.

I should say how it came about. The Reverend asked me in April to catalogue the old parish papers, which have lain in tea chests since the roof fell, and I said yes, for it gives me an excuse to leave the house, and J. likes to think I am being charitable. So I have been going three afternoons a week to the vestry. Dust, mice, a sleeping cat. Baptisms and burials and a hundred years of bad handwriting.

Today, behind a rotting press, I found a door.

It was not locked. It was only stuck, swollen with damp. I forced it with the poker. Behind it, a stair going down. I took a lantern. At the bottom I found a chamber cut in the living rock, perhaps forty feet long, that opens on the seaward side to the water. At low tide you can walk to the edge. At high tide it fills to the shoulder.

On the walls, scratched in the stone with some sharp instrument, were names.

Hundreds of them.

Next to the names, dates. Next to the dates, a ship.

I stood there with the lantern shaking in my hand and read until I could not read for tears. They were the drowned. Someone, over the centuries, had been recording them. Marking each as it came. A priest, perhaps. A fisherman's widow. They had come down in the dead of night and scratched the names on the wall where the tide would wash them, so that the sea might keep what the island would not.

The last I could read was dated 1871.

Below it was a space, a long smooth space of bare stone. As if the hand that wrote had grown too tired to go on.

14th June.

I have found the ledger.

It was in the same chamber, in an iron box in a niche above the water line. It is bound in oilcloth and tied with a cord. On the first page, in an old clerk's hand: "A True Account of the Island's Share."

I will not set down here what it says. I will say only that I recognized the handwriting of Josiah Vale's father in the third column. And the Ashcombes, father and son, in the fifth. And a figure in the margin, in pounds, per ship.

I am married to a man whose family has been paid by the sea for sixty years.

I am the mother of a child whose bread, whose silk, whose piano, were bought with the lives of drowned men.

I did not weep. I sat on the damp floor for an hour with the ledger in my lap and I found that I was not even surprised.

29th June.

Eleanor cut her hand on the garden gate today and I held her while Dr. Reed dressed it. She cried and then she laughed. She is eighteen, and she is still so frightened of everything and so sure that I will keep her safe.

I cannot keep her safe. I am only learning this now.

Reed's new apprentice came with him to the house. A tall dark boy, the sort who can't decide where to put his hands. He took the dressing from Reed without being asked and finished the bandage so neatly that Eleanor admired it. She asked his name.

"Thorne, miss. Gabriel Thorne."

"Do you mean to be a surgeon?"

"If I can afford the college."

I looked at the quiet worn face and thought: here is someone who is not afraid of blood.

9th July.

I have helped G. with his fees. I told him it was from a fund of Papa's, for deserving boys. He is clever enough to know I lie. He took the money anyway, with such a look of shamed gratitude that I had to turn away to the window.

He has told me about his brother. The little one, Samuel. Fourteen, apprenticed to a fisherman at the north harbor, and (I gather) dreadfully light-fingered. G. says the boy takes after their mother. I said, laughing, that all the best people do.

He did not laugh back.

22nd July.

I have told G. about the ledger.

I had not meant to. I was alone in the vestry with him, helping carry tea chests, and he said something kind, and the whole dreadful week came up in me like sickness. I told him everything. He listened in silence. When I had done he said, "Mrs. Vale, you must tell the magistrate."

"The magistrate is Lord Ashcombe."

Silence.

"Then you must tell someone who isn't," G. said. "The Bishop. The Board of Trade. Anyone."

I have written to them. I do not expect a reply.

14th August.

I cannot write what I saw tonight. I will write only that I was in my room, at the window, and I saw a light go out on the headland. That is nothing. It goes out sometimes when the wind catches the shutters. But it went out at the very moment J. came into the room behind me, and he looked at the window, and then at me, and there was something in his face I had never seen in twenty years of marriage.

Calculation.

"You've been in the crypt," he said.

"I have not."

"Margaret."

"I have been cataloguing the parish papers."

“You have been going places you should not.”

His voice was perfectly gentle. That was the horror of it.

I have been married to a stranger.

I have given G. a sealed letter and told him to keep it in his breast. Not to open it. To give it to Eleanor on the day she is a woman grown, if anything should happen. He asked, “What should happen?” and I said, “I don’t know.” He took it. He put it inside his coat. He said, “I’ll never let it out of my sight.”

He is twenty. God keep him.

I read the four pages three times.

Then I folded them along the creases my mother had made, and lay back on the pillow, and looked at the plaster ceiling until the dawn turned it from black to gray.

The crypt. The names. The ledger. The gentle voice of a man who had held my hand at my mother’s funeral and bought me a pony for my sixteenth birthday.

A boy of twenty with a letter inside his coat.

I’ll never let it out of my sight.

I thought of a velvet bag, nine pearls, a breaking string. I thought of a dark head bent over a medical textbook, a pressed sea-pink marking his page, and a pearl wrapped in lint against a man’s thigh.

I will tell you when I have a fact.

He had it. He had always had it. It had been against his heart for twelve years, sealed with my mother’s wax.

I rose. I dressed in the dark, without ringing for the maid.

I did not go to the lighthouse.

I went to the music room, and sat at the Broadwood, and played the Schubert from the beginning, softly, with the pedal down. I played it again. I played until the sun came into the room and lay along the keys like a hand.

I had been wrong about one thing.

I had thought the worst would be learning that my mother had been betrayed.

It was not.

It was learning that she had been *brave.*

Reading the diary was meant to give me a name. Instead it gave me a debt.

That was the thing nobody tells you about the dead. They leave you what they could not finish. And they do it so lovingly that you cannot refuse.

I wrote these lines in the margin of my own copy of Schubert, in pencil, that morning, and I do not know why. Perhaps it was to see them. Perhaps it was only because I had to put the grief somewhere other than my body.

I am glad I did.

Years later, when the island had forgotten almost everything else, someone found that page, still pencilled and faintly gray, tucked in the lid of the Broadwood.

By then it was the only part of me left that spoke plainly.

Chapter Eleven

The Unforgiven

Gabriel

I knew she was coming before she crossed the stile.

Six years of solitude had given me the senses of an animal. I could tell the weight of a footstep, the rhythm of a walk, the particular rustle of wool against gorse. I was at the foot of the tower, oiling the door hinges, when the gray coat topped the rise, and I stood and watched her come down the path with her chin high and her hands knotted at her sides.

She did not smile.

“You have a letter,” Eleanor said.

I set the oil can on the step.

“You have it in your breast, or you did,” she went on, reaching me, “and you have had it for twelve years, and she told you not to let it out of your sight. She said to give it to me on the day I was a woman grown. I am thirty, Gabriel. I have been a woman grown for a very long time.”

I said, “Who told you?”

“She did.”

I closed my eyes.

“She kept a diary. You must have known. She wrote everything.”

“She wrote it for no one.”

“She wrote it for me.” Her voice trembled. “Whether she knew it or not.”

I took her into the cottage.

It was a gray morning, with a wind that slapped the shutters, and I built up the fire because my hands needed something to do. She sat at the table with her coat on. She did not take off her gloves. I knelt on the hearth and fed the flames one stick at a time, and felt her watching my back, and when I could not put it off any longer I stood and turned.

“I have the letter,” I said. “It’s in a place I can’t reach just now.”

“You can’t reach it?”

“I can reach it. I can’t open it. There’s a difference.”

“That’s an excuse.”

“It is a condition,” I said. “She made me swear on my life that I would not give it to you until it was safe. Not safe for me. For you. She knew what was in it. I don’t.”

“And you think it is not safe.”

“I think there are people who would kill to have it. And that one of them is in this parish.”

She was silent a long time.

“Tell me what you can,” she said finally. “I’ll take the rest when it comes.”

So I told her the first half of the night.

I told it as plainly as I could, because the truth does not need ornament and because I had told it so many times to the ceiling that I knew every beat.

“I had been at Dr. Reed’s all evening, keeping the fire in, because the storm was already building and he expected calls. At nine, Mrs. Crowe came to the door. She was soaking and white as a plate. She said, *Mrs. Vale has hurt herself and won’t have the doctor. She asked for the boy.*

“I went.

“She was in the kitchen of Vale House, sitting at the big table with her hands in a basin. They were cut, Eleanor. Both palms, across the heel, and the fingers torn to the bone. As though she’d been clawing at a door.”

Eleanor’s breath caught.

“I asked what she’d done. She said, *I forced the crypt.* I didn’t understand. She said, *They’ve sealed it. I went down with a crowbar to bring up the ledger, and the door was bolted from the outside, and I*— She stopped. She was shaking, not from cold.

“I cleaned the wounds. I stitched what I could. Eleven stitches in the left hand, nine in the right. I used silk from my own kit. She never made a sound. She only talked.”

“What did she say?”

“That she’d been betrayed. That someone had told Lord Ashcombe she had the ledger. That she’d seen lights on the headland and knew a ship was coming and knew what they meant to do.” My throat was raw. “She said, *There’s a brig out there with fourteen men aboard, Gabriel. I can hear her bell.*”

Eleanor’s gloved hand went to her mouth.

“I begged her not to go. I told her I’d go myself. She said, *No. They won’t harm you if they think you’re a boy. They’ll harm me, but they cannot let it be known. They would not dare.*” I breathed. “She was wrong.”

“Who betrayed her?”

I did not answer. I had not told her that part of the diary, and I would not tell her now. I had no right.

“She put on her cloak,” I said. “She gave me nothing, said nothing; she only touched my face. Like this.” I lifted my hand to my own cheek. “And she went out the kitchen door. And I stood there for a count of ten like a fool, and then I ran after her.”

“You followed her.”

“I followed her to the lighthouse.”

“And?”

I looked at the fire.

“And by the time I reached the base of the tower,” I said, “the light was already dark. I climbed. I took the stair three steps at a time. I heard voices on the gallery. I came up through the hatch and there was a man standing at the rail, looking down. A big man with a lantern. He turned, and I saw his face.”

“Lord Ashcombe.”

“Yes.”

“Where was my mother?”

“The rail. The rail was broken.”

The fire hissed. A log shifted. Somewhere above us, in the gallery, a loose shutter beat against its frame like a heart.

“He told me she had fallen,” I said. “He said it was the storm. That she must have lost her footing. He said there was nothing to be done.” I lifted my eyes. “And I did what any boy would have done. I went to the rail and looked.”

“You saw her.”

“I saw the water.”

“But did you see her?”

“I—”

I stopped.

It was the first time in twelve years that anyone had asked me a straight question about that moment. And I discovered, in the pause, that I could not answer it.

Eleanor leaned forward.

Her voice was very quiet, very gentle, and it went through me like a probe through a wound.

“What aren’t you telling me?”

I should say that I could have told her.

I should say it so that you understand. There was a moment, in that small hot room, in the silence after her question, when I could have opened my mouth and let it all out. *I had her wrist. I held it. I held it for nine seconds. Ashcombe said a name, and I loosened my hand.*

I could have said it.

I would have lost her.

Not “lost.” That implies I’d had her. I had had nothing. Only a hand on a gallery, and a glance across a table, and the memory of a woman who wanted to be left in peace.

But I had had her *regard.* I had had her anger and her trust and her gloved fingers on my sleeve, and I had known with a miserable clarity that if I told her now, in this kitchen, with her mother’s pearls in a velvet bag in her pocket, she would stand up from that chair and walk out into the wind and never speak to me again.

I am a coward.

It is the simplest word, and the only accurate one.

“I did not see her,” I said. “I looked, and I couldn’t. And then Ashcombe took my arm, and he said, *You’ll say nothing, boy, or your brother hangs.* And I ran.”

She was silent.

“I should have fought him. I should have gone down the rocks. I should have—” I could not finish. “I did not do any of it. I went back to Reed’s. I sat at his table with my coat soaked through and I said nothing. And in the morning they found her body on the Teeth, and Reed signed the certificate. *Accidental drowning.* And I held my tongue, and was paid for it.”

She went rigid.

“Paid.”

“A letter came from London. A bursary. For a medical college. It was signed by a solicitor, but I knew whose money.” I made myself look at her. “I took it, Eleanor. I took Ashcombe’s money for my silence, and I went to sea.”

Silence.

It was longer than any I have known. The fire popped. The kettle began to sing.

“Thank you,” Eleanor said at last.

“For what?”

“For telling me that. It must have cost you a great deal.”

“It cost me twelve years.”

“Yes.” She rose from the chair, slowly. She stood with her hands pressed flat to the table. “I don’t forgive you. I want to be honest. I don’t think I can, today. You had a hand on a gallery rail and a woman in the water and you took money. And I loved her, and she loved you, and I do not know what that means.”

“I know.”

“But you’ve given me the first true piece. And I will give you the same in return.”

She went to the door. She turned.

“My mother’s letter to the Reverend. The one in the study. It’s unopened. I’d like you to read it with me.”

“Why?”

“Because you are the only person alive who knew her as I did,” said Eleanor, “and I can’t bear to read it alone.”

I stood very still.

Outside, the wind was rising, and the sea had begun to pile up gray on the Teeth, and the first spots of rain struck the window.

“Come tonight,” she said. “After supper. Through the garden door. Mrs. Crowe will let you in.”

She looked at me one last time, steadily, with those grave dark eyes.

“I forgive nothing yet. But I know the difference between a coward and a liar. You are only the first.”

She went out.

I stood in the cottage and listened to her footsteps die away, and I thought: *I have told her half. Only half. And the half I kept is the half that matters.*

And I thought, with a bleak, rising certainty:

She will find out. And when she does, it will not be me she hates. It will be herself, for having believed.

Chapter Twelve

The First Kiss

Eleanor

He came at ten, through the garden door, with rain on his shoulders and no hat.

Mrs. Crowe let him in. She did not speak; she only looked at him with an expression I could not read, the look of a woman handing a child to a stranger over a river. Then she took her candle and went up the back stairs and left us in the dark kitchen, two people who had not decided what they were.

“This way,” I said.

I led him through the hall. We went on tiptoe past my father’s portrait, past my mother’s, past the long shadow of the staircase. The green door was open a hand’s breadth. I took his sleeve and drew him down the eleven steps, and I felt, through the wet wool, the tension in his arm, like a drawn bow.

At the bottom he stopped.

He stood in the doorway of my mother’s study with the candle on the desk throwing his shadow up the wall, and he looked at the room, the chair with its gray shawl, the chart, the shelves of storm books, and I saw his face change.

“She sat here,” he said.

“You’ve been in this room.”

“Once.” His voice was strange. “I carried her books down. In July. She asked me not to tell.” He touched the back of the reading chair with two fingers, very lightly, and took them away. “I always thought she would have made a very fine physician.”

“She would have hated it. The smell.”

“Yes.” He almost smiled. “She would have.”

The letter lay where I had left it, in the desk drawer, sealed with red wax. The paper had yellowed. The ink of the address was still dark and clear.

To the Reverend Thomas Blackwood. To be delivered by hand.

I held it out.

He did not take it. “It isn’t mine to open.”

“It isn’t mine either. He’s the addressee.”

“Then perhaps we ought to give it to him.”

“We’ll give it to him,” I said. “After we know what’s in it. I am done being the last to learn things in this house.”

He looked at me. In the candlelight his eyes were the color of rain on slate. Then he nodded, once, and took the letter from my hand, and broke the seal with his thumb.

He read it first. I watched his lips move on the last line. Then he gave it to me.

Thomas,

If you are reading this, I am dead, and you have the proof in your keeping. I know you will do what is right. I know it because you married me to a man I did not love and wept at the altar, and because you have never once pretended that the Church is anything but a weak and weathered thing.

I have put the ledger in the third niche of the seaward wall, behind the broken column, under the stone with the cross cut upside down. You will know it when you see it. Do not trust the vestry. Do not trust the key. Go at low tide and go alone.

The names are on the wall. I have added the Sparrowhawk’s as they came to me, from the harbor books. There will be fourteen. By the time you read this there may be more.

I ask three things.

First, that you tell no one at Vale House. My husband is not a villain. He is only a weak man who has found a reason to be weak. But he has a fear in him that is stronger than love, and I will not be the cause of its turning on my child.

Second, that you take the ledger to the Bishop’s court. Not to the magistrate. Not to the Crown officer. I have written to them and had no answer, and I think the answer was a hand closing in the dark.

Third, that if my daughter should ever return to the island, you will tell her I loved her. And that I was not brave. I was only too stubborn to be afraid.

Margaret.

I read it twice.

When I finished I laid it on the desk, very carefully, as though it might bruise, and put both my hands flat on either side of it.

“She wrote that she was not brave,” I said.

“Yes.”

“She was the bravest person I ever knew.”

“Yes.”

“And she thought—” My voice cracked; I let it. “She thought it was *stubbornness.*”

“It’s the same thing,” Gabriel said quietly. “From the outside.”

I laughed. It came out as a sob. I put my face in my hands, and he did not move, did not reach for me, did not say a word; he stood in the dim light with his arms at his sides and let me weep. And I understood that this was a courtesy, rarer than any comfort, the courtesy of being left alone in a room with someone.

At last I took a breath, and wiped my eyes with the heel of my hand.

“The third niche,” I said. “The upside-down cross.”

“I know the one.”

“You’ve been in the crypt?”

“Only once. I never found the ledger. I thought it had been taken.” His eyes were fixed on the letter. “She said low tide.”

“The next spring tide is the fifth.”

“Eight days.”

“We’ll go together,” I said. “At night. With Mr. Blackwood’s blessing or without it.”

“Eleanor—”

“I know.” I looked up at him. “It is dangerous. I know. You have been telling me since the first morning. I still want you to come.”

His mouth moved. He said nothing.

I do not remember who moved first.

I have gone over it a hundred times, in the long weeks after. I would like to say it was he. I would like to say that he stepped forward and took my face in his hands and kissed me with all the long starvation of six silent winters. It would make a better story. It would make *him* a better man in my memory, a villain or a hero, anything but what he was.

But I think it was I.

I think I rose from my mother’s chair with her letter still warm in my fingers, and crossed the narrow space between us, and stopped with my forehead nearly touching his collarbone. I could smell the sea on him. Lamp oil, salt, tar soap, and under it the plain clean smell of a man who has worked with his hands.

“Gabriel,” I said.

He did not answer.

“Look at me.”

He looked.

I have been looked at by men all my life. I have been admired, flattered, assessed. I have been undressed by eyes in London ballrooms, and found it faintly funny. But no one had ever looked at me as though I were a frightening and miraculous thing that had stepped out of a book.

“I am going to marry Adrian Ashcombe,” I said. My voice trembled. “That has not changed. I have a duty and a promise. You know the situation.”

“Yes.”

“I don’t want it to be only that.”

“Eleanor—”

“I would like one thing,” I said, “that I have chosen.”

He closed his eyes.

His hands came up, slowly, and cupped my face. They were rough and warm, and they smelled of oil, and they shook. His thumbs moved once across my cheekbones, brushing away the last of the tears. It was the gentlest touch I have ever known. It was the touch of a surgeon for a wound.

“I’m not worthy of this,” he said.

“I did not ask if you were.”

“I did something terrible.”

“I know.”

“You’ll hate me.”

“Probably.”

“Then—”

I rose on my toes and kissed him.

It is hard to say what it was like.

I have played Chopin for twenty years, and never once captured it. It was not fire. It was not a storm. It was something much quieter and much worse: a kind of recognition, as though two halves of a broken line had found each other in the dark.

His mouth was careful, at first. Asking. Then my hand went to the back of his neck and his fingers slid into my hair and the whole careful world went out like a candle. He made a sound, low in his throat, that was almost pain. He pulled me against him. I felt the hard length of him through my gown and the wild hammer of his heart against my breast, and I thought, dazedly: *so this is what everyone was talking about.*

I tasted salt.

I did not know whose tears they were.

When at last we broke apart, we stood forehead to forehead, breathing as though we had run a mile. His hands had not left my face. My fingers were knotted in his collar. Above us the old house creaked and settled; on the desk, the candle guttered in a draft from the tunnel door.

“That was a mistake,” said Gabriel, hoarsely.

“Yes.”

“We’ll make it again.”

“Probably.”

“I should go.”

“You should.”

Neither of us moved.

The knock came from above.

Three raps, clean and distinct, on the green door at the top of the stairs.

We froze.

I felt the blood leave my face. Gabriel’s hand closed around mine, hard. In the silence, I heard the latch lift.

“Eleanor?”

Adrian’s voice, soft, almost amused. It drifted down the narrow stair like smoke.

“I know you’re down there, my dear.”

I did not breathe.

“Mrs. Crowe left the garden door unbarred. And there are wet footprints in the hall.” A pause. A very light, very pleasant laugh. “I thought I’d bring you the Michaelmas pie. You left before dessert.”

Gabriel’s eyes met mine.

He knows.

I put my finger to my lips. I took the letter from the desk and tucked it into my bodice. I turned and, silent as a cat, pushed the iron-hinged door in the stone wall, the one bolted from the inside, and drew Gabriel in after me.

The tunnel closed behind us.

Above, I heard Adrian's boots begin to descend, slow and unhurried, one step, two, three.

In the dark, Gabriel's arm came around my waist and held me against his chest, and I thought, absurdly, *I have never been so frightened in my life, and I have never been so happy.*

The stairs creaked.

Adrian said, quite gently, to the empty room:

"I'll wait."

Chapter Thirteen

A House Full of Ghosts

Eleanor

We waited in the tunnel for forty minutes.

I counted them in Gabriel's breathing. He stood with his back against the wet rock and his arm around me, and neither of us said a word. I could hear Adrian's tread overhead, back and forth across the study, the scrape of a chair, the soft slide of a drawer. Once, a long silence, and I knew he was reading the draft letters. Once, a laugh, short and dry, with no mirth in it.

At last, the boots climbed. The green door shut. The latch clicked.

We did not move for another ten minutes.

"He knows," I whispered.

"He knows you were here," Gabriel said, very low. "He doesn't know what you've found."

"He read my mother's drafts."

"He read some drafts. Not the letter." His breath stirred my hair. "He left because you weren't there. A man who truly wished to confront you would have broken the door."

"What does he want?"

"For you to come to him."

I shivered. "He will ask me tomorrow."

"Then tell him you went to the abbey. A walk, alone, to think. He'll believe the lie that costs you least."

I turned in the circle of his arm. In the dark I could see only the pale oval of his face.

"You're very good at this."

"I've had practice."

"At what?"

“Being afraid of men I once trusted.”

I did not sleep.

I lay in my four-poster with the curtains open and the moon on the counterpane, and the house gave up its sounds one by one. The tick of a cooling pipe. The scurry of mice in the wall. The settling groan of a floor. Somewhere below, very faintly, a note of music: not the Broadwood, which was shut, but something thin and high, a fiddle, or a woman humming.

I rose at four and went to the window.

The garden lay silver and black. At the end of the lawn, where the terraces met the cliff, a figure stood in the moonlight looking up at my window.

A woman.

She wore a long pale dress. Her dark hair was loose. She stood perfectly still, with her hands at her sides, and the wind that stirred the lavender did not stir her hem.

My breath stopped.

I put my hand to the glass.

She raised her head.

I could not see her face. The moon was behind her. But I knew the line of the shoulder, the tilt of the chin, the long fingers. I knew them as I knew my own hands.

“Mama,” I whispered.

She lifted one arm. She pointed. Not at me. Past me. At the corner of the east wing, where the ivy grew over a window that had been bricked up years ago.

Then she was gone.

I did not scream. I did not run. I stood at the window with my palm on the cold glass and counted my heartbeats until the dawn came gray over the sea. When I could move again I found that my nails had cut into my palm, and a thin line of blood ran down to my wrist.

I told myself it was a dream.

I told myself I had grown too accustomed to dreaming.

But I put on my dressing gown, and I went down through the sleeping house, and I walked to the east wing.

The room behind the bricked window was a nursery.

I knew it as soon as I found the door. A narrow door in the wainscoting, papered over with a trellis of roses that had faded to the color of tea. The wallpaper had been slashed and peeled back. Someone had used a knife.

Behind it, a corridor. Seven feet long. A door at the end.

The door was open.

I stood on the threshold and smelled dust, and old paper, and the faint sweet scent of lavender and orris. And I thought: *This was her room.*

It was a girl's room. A girl who had become a woman and never changed it. A small iron bed. A washstand with a cracked pitcher. A shelf of books: Scott, Austen, a battered *Pilgrim's Progress.* On the wall, a watercolor of the lighthouse, signed *M.R., aged 15.*

Margaret Rayner. My mother's maiden name.

She had come to this house at nineteen as a bride. I had never known she kept a room in it.

On the bed lay a little wooden box, and beside the box, a candle stub burned down to a puddle of wax, and beside the candle, a child's slate with chalk writing on it.

Three words, in a hand I knew.

Ask Hester. Now.

I found Mrs. Crowe in the kitchen at six.

She was alone, kneading dough, her sleeves rolled to the elbow and her forearms white with flour. She looked up when I came in. She saw my face. She saw what I held.

She stopped.

"Where did you find that?"

"You know where."

"Miss—"

"You knew about the room."

"I did."

"You knew about the study. The tunnel. The crypt. You've known all of it, for twelve years, and you let me walk about this house like a blind woman."

"I promised."

"You promised *her.* I am not her. I am not a thing to be protected from the truth. I am *thirty years old* and I have been a stranger in my own home since the day I came back." I laid the slate on the table, hard. "Someone wrote that in chalk this morning. It is not my mother's hand. It is someone who knows the house. Who is it?"

Mrs. Crowe wiped her hands on her apron. She did it slowly, thoroughly, finger by finger.

Then she sat down at the kitchen table, heavily, like a woman who has been standing since before she was born.

“Sit,” she said.

I sat.

“I’ll tell you the whole of it,” said Mrs. Crowe. “And I’ll not be interrupted. And when it’s done you may dismiss me, and I’ll go quietly, and I will understand.”

“I would never—”

“Hush.”

“I was in service here from the age of fifteen,” she said. “Your grandmother’s time. I saw your mother come as a bride. A slip of a girl, white as milk, who’d never been farther than Penzance. She laughed at everything. She laughed at the fish on the table. She laughed at the servants’ hall. I thought: she won’t last a winter.

“She lasted twenty years.

“I’ll not say Mr. Vale was cruel. He was never that. He was a man who hated a quarrel. When trouble came, he went out walking, and trouble waited for him until he came home. He let things be done in his name that he’d never have done with his own hand. And your mother saw it, bit by bit, as the years went on, and it broke something in her that never mended.

“She found the ledger in June. I knew the day. She came back from the vestry white as the dead, and she sat in the kitchen with a cup of tea and did not drink it. I said, *Madam?* She said, *Hester, who do we work for?*”

I could barely speak. “What did you say?”

“I said, *Mr. Vale.* And she said, *Yes. And whose money is it?*”

A log settled in the range.

“I knew what she meant. I’d known for years. Everyone in the house knew, the way you know the smell of the sea. The chests that came at night. The silver. The cargo that was never quite described. I told myself it was salvage. Lawful salvage, from the wrecks. That the sea gave it and we only took what it gave.”

“And the lights?”

“I told myself the lights were weather.”

Her voice was flat and dry.

“On the twenty-eighth of September I was in bed when I heard the study door. Your father’s. I came down the back stairs in my nightgown, and I saw him in the hall with Lord Ashcombe. Lord Ashcombe was in oilskins. He had a lantern. Your father gave him a key.”

“A key.”

“The lantern-room key. It had hung on a nail in your father’s study for forty years. The Ashcombes keep one, and the Vales another, for the old arrangement. Lord Ashcombe took it and put it in his coat and said, *Is she upstairs?* And your father said, *She’s in the kitchen with the boy.* And Lord Ashcombe said, *Keep her there.*”

My lips were numb.

“And did he?”

“No, miss. Your father went upstairs and stood outside the kitchen door and did nothing. He heard her go out through the scullery. He heard her go. And he went back to the study and poured himself a brandy, and sat in his chair in front of the fire, and when I came in he said, *Go to bed, Hester.* In a voice like a man ordering the post.”

I stood up.

I did not know I was going to. My chair went over with a crash. I walked to the window and stood there with my back to the room, and the garden outside blurred and ran together in the light.

“Did he know?”

“I don’t know.”

“Did he *know?*”

“Miss Eleanor.” Her voice cracked at last. “I think he knew exactly.”

I turned.

She was weeping. Silently, with her mouth shut, tears running down the grooves of her cheeks. She did not wipe them. She sat with her hands in her lap and let them fall.

“I have carried it twelve years,” she said. “I loved her. I loved you. I loved him, too, God forgive me, a little. And I thought: if I tell her, she’ll hate us both. And if I do not tell her, she’ll come to hate the house. And the house is all there is.”

“Mrs. Crowe—”

“I will go, if you like.”

“You will not.”

I crossed the kitchen. I knelt before her chair, and took her floury hands in both of mine, and held them. They were small and hard and cold.

“You kept her letter,” I said. “You kept her pages. You waited twelve years in a house that was strangling you, so that I would have something to find. If that is cowardice, then God help the brave.”

She bent her head.

We stayed there a long time, the old woman and the young one, in a kitchen full of the smell of yeast.

When at last I rose, I found that the slate was lying face up on the table, and the chalk had been scrubbed from it clean.

Ask Hester. Now.

It was gone.

“I didn’t touch it,” said Mrs. Crowe, staring.

“Neither did I.”

We looked at each other.

And from the far end of the house, from the music room, came a single note.

Low A.

Struck softly. Held.

And let go.

Chapter Fourteen

The Missing Witness

Gabriel

Dr. Silas Reed had agreed to meet me at dusk.

I had written him a note, two lines, and sent it by the Penrose boy. *Eleanor Vale knows. She wishes to hear it from you. Come to the lighthouse on Thursday after sundown, and bring the certificate book.* I had expected nothing. Reed was a man who had spent twelve years drinking himself quietly toward the grave, and I had given up hoping he would find a conscience at the bottom of any bottle.

But the boy came back at noon with a single word, written on the back of my own note in a shaking hand.

Yes.

By four o’clock I had swept the cottage, built the fire, and set out three chairs. By five I had polished the lens twice. By six, when the sun slid under the edge of the sea and the whole

western sky turned the color of an old bruise, I stood on the gallery with my hands on the rail and watched the cliff path.

Eleanor was beside me.

She had come at five, out of breath, with a basket from Mrs. Crowe and a face that told me she had not slept. We had not spoken of the study. We had not spoken of anything. She had stood in the doorway of the cottage for a moment, and I had stood in the middle of the floor, and the memory of her mouth had gone through the room like a bell struck once. Then she had said, *Is he here?* and I had said, *Not yet,* and we had both turned with relief to the business of waiting.

“He’s late,” she said now.

“He’s a doctor. They are never on time.”

“He was kind to me, when I was small.” She did not look at me. “He used to give me barley sugar from his pocket. He said it was medicine.”

“He gave it to me, too.”

She turned her head.

“The first week,” I said. “Before I knew what I was apprenticed to. I thought: here is a man who keeps sweets in his coat. I thought him the kindest man alive.”

“And now?”

“Now I think kindness is a thing a coward does when he cannot be brave.”

She was silent.

Down on the headland, the shadows had thickened to blue. The first star came out over the Teeth. Behind us, in the tower, the lamp turned in its cradle with the low steady whir that had become the pulse of my life, and the beam went out across the water, white, patient, strong.

Seven o’clock.

Eight.

At half past eight, Eleanor said, very quietly, “He isn’t coming.”

“No.”

“Something’s happened.”

“Perhaps he lost his nerve.”

“Perhaps.”

She was looking at the dark. I saw in the lamp’s reflected glow that her lip was caught between her teeth, and that the fingers on the rail were white.

“I’ll go to him,” I said.

“We’ll go.”

“Eleanor—”

“I know what you’ll say. It’s dangerous. I am more use to you than you think.” She stepped away from the rail. “Besides, if he’s dead I would like to be told by someone who isn’t Mr. Ashcombe.”

Reed’s house stood at the north end of the harbor, a narrow gray building with a brass plate and a blue door.

The door was ajar.

I stopped on the step, and Eleanor stopped behind me. I put out an arm. We listened. Somewhere in the house a clock was ticking; a draught moved the curtain in an upstairs window; a gull stalked along the harbor wall, scraping its claws on the stone. Nothing else.

“Dr. Reed?” I called.

Silence.

I pushed the door wide.

The surgery lay to the left. A small room, cluttered, clean in the way of rooms kept by a man who has outgrown cleaning. Glass jars, a stained leather couch, a bookcase of dusty pharmacopoeias. I knew it as I knew the palm of my hand. It was the room where I had spent a winter learning to sew men’s skin.

It had been searched.

Not violently. Whoever had done it had been methodical. Every drawer in the desk pulled halfway and pushed shut again. Every book removed, shaken, replaced a half inch out of line. The leather couch cushions slit along their seams, the horsehair stuffing teased out and tidily stacked.

“They were looking for something,” Eleanor whispered.

“The certificate book.”

I crossed to the desk. The top drawer was empty. The pen tray, the blotter, the inkwell: all in place. But on the blotter, in the pool of lamplight, lay a pair of spectacles, folded, with one lens cracked across.

I picked them up.

They were warm.

Not from a hand. From the lamp. They’d been lying under the glow for an hour at most. The cracked glass caught the flame and threw back a small bright wound.

“He wouldn’t leave without these,” I said.

“He’s nearly blind without them.”

“Then he did not leave.”

I looked around the room again. The chair behind the desk was pushed back at an angle, as though someone had risen in a hurry. The coat stand by the door was bare. A dark smear on the edge of the blotter, no larger than my thumbnail, glistened under the lamp.

I touched it with the tip of my finger.

Wet.

I held it to the light.

Red.

We searched the house. The kitchen, where a half-eaten supper lay on a plate. The bedroom upstairs, where the bed was made and a nightshirt hung over the chair. The cellar, where forty bottles of port stood in a rack with a few gaps. Nothing.

Nothing, until I came back to the front hall and noticed what I had missed on entering.

His bag was gone.

The black leather bag that had hung on a peg beside the door for twelve years. The one that held his instruments, his stethoscope, his notebook. The one he had never in my memory allowed out of arm’s reach.

“He took it,” Eleanor said.

“Or it was taken.”

“Why would anyone take a doctor’s bag?”

“Because of what’s in the lining.”

She looked at me.

“He sewed the certificate into the lining,” I said. “The page from the ledger. The original. Eleven years ago, he said, when he first started to be afraid. A small leather pocket under the false bottom. I helped him cut it.” My mouth was dry. “I thought he’d destroyed it. I thought he’d drowned it in whisky like everything else.”

“And now—”

“And now somebody has it.”

A step sounded on the cobbles outside.

Heavy. Measured. Two men.

Eleanor grasped my sleeve. I put my hand over hers.

“Stay behind me,” I said.

The man in the doorway was Nathaniel Corbett.

I knew him by his shape before I saw his face. A big square body in a black coat; a wide flat face like a shovel blade; hands the size of dinner plates, scarred to the knuckles from forty years on the quay. He was Lord Ashcombe’s steward. He had been Lord Ashcombe’s steward for thirty years, and was now, in the nominal sense, the magistrate’s. In the real sense, he was no one’s. He did what he’d always done, which was whatever was necessary.

Behind him stood a constable in a stiff blue coat, young, pale, with the look of a man who would rather be at home.

“Mr. Thorne,” said Corbett.

“Mr. Corbett.”

“Miss Vale.”

“Good evening,” said Eleanor, with a self-possession that startled me. “What brings you here at this hour?”

“A report of disturbance.” His small pale eyes slid over the room, taking in the overturned cushions, the open drawers, the spectacles in my hand. “A neighbor heard noise.”

“There is no one here.”

“So I see.” He took a step into the surgery. The boards creaked under his weight. “Dr. Reed’s gone off, I understand. This afternoon. On the packet to Falmouth.”

“The packet?”

“Left at three. Said he’d a patient on the mainland and might be some days.” He smiled, with no part of his face but his mouth. “A man gets tired of the island, now and again.”

“He left his spectacles,” I said.

“Did he?”

“Cracked. With blood on the blotter.”

The constable shifted. Corbett did not.

“A doctor cuts himself shaving,” he said gently. “Now, Mr. Thorne, I’ll ask you to step outside with me. The magistrate would like a word. And Miss Vale, I’ll see you home.”

“I’ll see myself home.”

“Mr. Ashcombe was most particular.”

“I’m sure he was.”

“It’s dark, miss. And the cliff road is bad.”

“I walked it this morning, Mr. Corbett.” She lifted her chin. “Tell Mr. Ashcombe that I’m quite well, and that I’d be obliged if he’d call on me in the proper way, by day, with a card, like a gentleman.”

I thought for a moment that Corbett would take her arm.

He looked at her. Then at me. Then, slowly, as though reading some unwritten line, he stepped back.

“As you say, miss.”

“Thank you.”

We walked out through the blue door, past the constable, into the harbor night. Behind us I heard Corbett’s heavy tread cross the surgery floor, the scrape of a drawer, the dull *thunk* of something put down hard.

We were at the end of the quay before Eleanor let out her breath.

“Did you see his hands?” she said.

“No.”

“There was blood on the left cuff.”

I stopped walking.

“Fresh,” she said. “Under the button. A brown stain the size of a sixpence. He tried to turn his wrist away.”

The packet *Sea Swallow,* I remembered, had a rope-burned hull and a captain named Trevennick who owed me a favor for setting his daughter’s arm. I stood on the quay in the cold, with the water slapping the stones, and made a decision.

“Go home,” I said. “Lock the door. Tell Mrs. Crowe.”

“What are you going to do?”

“Ask the captain whether he took on a passenger at three.”

“Gabriel.”

“Eleanor.” I took her hands. “Dr. Reed is the only man alive who can put his name to a certificate that says your mother was struck before she fell. If he’s dead, the case is dead. And if he is not dead, then somebody has him, and he has perhaps a day.”

She looked at me, her eyes enormous.

Then she kissed me.

Once, quickly, hard on the mouth, in the open street, under the lamp.

“Come back,” she said.

“I will.”

“If you don’t, I swear I shall come after you.”

“I believe you.”

I watched her go up the road, a small dark figure with her chin high, until she turned the corner of the churchyard wall.

Then I walked down to the boats.

The captain of the *Sea Swallow* told me, with great reluctance, over a mug of rum at the Gannet, that the packet had sailed at four, not three. That she had carried six passengers, all islanders, all known to him by name. That nobody had come aboard with a doctor’s bag.

That a man had been seen at the quay at dusk, a stout man in a long coat, arguing with two others.

That the stout man had been put into a cart.

“Whose cart?” I said.

Trevennick looked at his rum.

“I couldn’t swear to it,” he said at last. “But it was drawn by a gray mare with a white star. And there’s only one gray mare with a star on this island.”

It belonged to Marlowe House.

It belonged to Adrian Ashcombe.

Chapter Fifteen

The Price of Devotion

Adrian

I called on her at noon, with a card, like a gentleman.

It was her rebuke, delivered through Corbett, and it was just. I had sent my steward to do what I had not the stomach to do myself. I should have gone in person. I should have come to the surgery in the dark, and stood in the street, and watched her face as she told me what she had seen.

Instead I had sat at my desk and let a man I despised bring me her words in pieces.

Tell Mr. Ashcombe that I’d be obliged if he’d call on me in the proper way.

I had read it aloud, twice, to the empty room. And then I had put on my best coat.

She received me in the morning room. The sun came in low through the windows, laying long gold bars on the Turkey carpet, and she sat in the window seat with a book open in her lap and did not rise. She was in gray wool, her hair coiled low on her neck. She looked tired and very young. Her hands lay quiet on the page.

I stood in the doorway with my hat and could not speak.

“Adrian.”

“Eleanor.”

“You will want to sit.”

“I would rather stand.”

“As you wish.” She turned a page she was not reading. “Have you found Dr. Reed?”

I could have lied. It was the easier road, and I took it for a heartbeat. *Gone to Falmouth. A patient. Back within the week.* The words were there on my tongue, round and smooth as pebbles.

Instead I said, “He is in my cellar.”

I will describe what happened to her face. I find I want to describe it exactly, because it is the last time I saw it unguarded.

She did not move. Her lips parted, very slightly. The color went out of her cheeks, not all at once but in a slow tide, and her eyes, those dark honest eyes, widened and then narrowed. A kind of wild calculation passed through them. I watched her weigh fear against anger and decide, with cold and terrible clarity, to feel neither.

“Alive?”

“Alive. Drunk, and extremely frightened, and very much in need of a bath. Corbett’s men found him at the quay. He was trying to board a boat to Penzance with a bag of papers and no spectacles.”

“Why?”

“Because he is a coward, my dear. Because he had a letter from a man on the mainland saying that I was about to hang him.” I permitted myself a dry smile. “I said no such thing. But a man who has done what he has done begins to see gallows in every shadow.”

“What has he done?”

“He signed a certificate.”

“I know that. You *took* him.”

“I took him,” I said, “because if I had not, someone else would have. And that someone would not have been so careful of his life.”

She laid the book aside.

“You’ll let me see him.”

“No.”

“Adrian—”

“Not yet.” I came into the room at last and sat opposite her. I put my hat on my knee. “I will tell you why. And then I’ll tell you everything I can, which is more than you think. And at the end of it you may do as you wish.”

“I’m listening.”

I looked at my hands.

“My father,” I said, “was a monster.”

I told it plainly. I had practiced the speech on the road from Marlowe House, and it all went out of my head, and I found that the truth did not need rehearsing.

I told her that the Ashcombes had been wreckers for four generations. That my grandfather had bought the magistracy with salvage money. That the lantern key, one of two, had been passed from father to son the way another family hands down a watch.

I told her that I had learned it at fifteen.

I told her that I had been taken up the cliff path in a gale and shown the three turns of the key, and that the lesson had been delivered with a firm hand on my shoulder and a gleam in my father’s eye, as a farmer shows his son the slaughter of a lamb.

I told her that when I was twenty-two I had stood beside him on the night of the *Sparrowhawk,* and that I had been sick in the grass.

“And your father pushed my mother,” Eleanor said.

My heart stopped.

“Gabriel told you.”

“He said the rail was broken. He said Lord Ashcombe was standing over it. He said he looked down and saw only water.” She regarded me steadily. “I’m not stupid, Adrian. I’ve known since the first night. I only wanted to hear you say it.”

I could not.

I sat with the words behind my teeth, and felt them press and shift like something alive. I thought: *If I tell her, I will lose her.* I thought: *If I do not, she will find it. And then I will lose her anyway.*

It is the great cruelty of the thing. There was no road that led back.

“I cannot say it,” I said at last.

“Why?”

“Because I do not know it.”

“You were *there*.”

“I was on the stair.” My own voice sounded strange, thin, like something heard through a wall. “It was dark. It was storming. I heard a cry, a man’s voice, and then a crash of timber. I came up the last steps and the gallery was empty. The rail hung over the sea. My father stood at the edge with his back to me.”

“And Gabriel?”

“I did not see Thorne.”

It was almost true.

I had not seen him *arrive.* I had seen him *after.* A tall boy, soaked, on his knees at the rail, staring at his own hand as though it belonged to someone else.

I did not say that.

I said, “I ran down the rocks. I got to her. She was in the water, face up. I thought—” My voice cracked. “I thought she might be alive.”

“And?”

“She was warm.”

There was a long silence.

“I carried her up the cliff,” I said. “I laid her in the grass. I wrapped her in my coat. And I looked up and saw your window, and you in it, a white shape against the dark.”

“I remember.”

“I have wondered for twelve years what you saw.”

“A man with blood on his hands,” said Eleanor, “carrying my mother.”

“Yes.”

“I thought it was you who had killed her.”

I closed my eyes.

“I know,” I said.

I did not weep. I want that understood. I am not a man who weeps. But my chest ached as though I had swallowed a stone, and for a moment the room swam, and I heard the clock on the

mantel and the beat of my own pulse and a sound from very far away that might have been the sea.

When I opened my eyes, she was standing before me.

She laid her hand on my cheek.

“Adrian.”

“Don’t.”

“You were twenty-two.”

“I was a coward.”

“You were a boy.” Her thumb moved. “You carried her. You did not run. You stayed with her in the dark.”

“I kept silent for twelve years.”

“Yes. You did.” She drew her hand away. “And that is what I cannot forgive.”

I looked up.

“I could forgive the other,” she said. “A boy, frightened, in a storm. I think I could forgive almost anything of that boy. But the man, Adrian. The man who sat in my father’s dining room and ate my mother’s blue china. The man who told me I’d come to the wrong island.”

“I was protecting you.”

“From what?”

“From *this.*”

“I don’t want to be protected,” said Eleanor. “I want to be told.”

I stood. I could not remain in the chair. I crossed to the window and stood with my back to her, looking down the garden to the cliffs.

“You do not understand what I have given up.”

“Tell me.”

“I have paid your father’s debts. Forty thousand pounds. The estate was mortgaged to the last acre; the bank was on the point of foreclosing; I bought the notes at a discount and held them in my own name so that no one would know. I had the roof of Vale House mended. I paid Mrs. Crowe’s wages out of my own purse when the trust ran dry. I have kept your father’s name clean on this island for eight years, and the Assembly Room would have burned him in effigy if I had spoken a word.”

“I did not ask—”

“No. You did not. That is the point.” I turned. “I did it because I love you. Because I watched your mother die and I could not bear that you should lose the roof over your head as well. I

have spent my fortune, and my father's, on keeping this family from the gallows. And I would do it again."

Silence.

"I am not asking for gratitude," I said. "I am asking you to understand that every lie I told was a lie for you."

She looked at me for a long time.

"I believe that," she said.

My heart leapt.

"But it doesn't make them true."

She did not ask me to leave. She did not ask me to stay. She stood by the window seat with her arms at her sides, a small straight figure, and I saw in her face something I had never seen before. It took me a moment to name it.

It was pity.

God help me, it was pity.

"There is one more thing," I said. I had not meant to say it. It came up out of me like water through a crack. "You've been to the lighthouse."

"Yes."

"You know what Thorne is."

"I know exactly what he is."

"Do you?" I drew a breath. "Then ask him what he did on the gallery. Not what he saw. What he *did.* Ask him what he did with his hands."

Her face did not change.

"I saw it, Eleanor. I was on the stair. I saw the whole of it, and I have never told a living soul. If you want the truth, ask him. Make him say it. And then ask yourself why a man who held your mother's wrist for nine seconds in a storm would keep a letter in his coat for twelve years."

"Adrian."

"Ask him."

I took my hat.

I walked out of the morning room, down the hall, past my own portrait's rival, my father's heavy painted eyes, and out the front door into the afternoon light. The air tasted of salt and cut grass. A blackbird sang in the orchard.

I stood on the gravel for a moment.

Then I put my hand over my mouth, and for the first time in twelve years, I wept.

Chapter Sixteen

The Night We Surrendered

Eleanor

I did not ask him.

I want that understood, before anything else is told. I had Adrian's words in my pocket like a stone. *Ask him what he did with his hands.* I had walked the cliff path at dusk with the question lodged in my throat, and I had stood outside the cottage door in the thin blue light with my fist raised to knock, and I had known exactly what I would say.

Then the door opened.

He stood there without his coat, his shirt open at the neck, his hair wet from washing. He had a towel over one shoulder. He looked at me, and I saw the whole day's weariness drop from his face, replaced by something so naked and glad that I could not bear it.

"You came," he said.

"I said I would."

"I thought—after the quay. I thought you might have—"

"Come in out of the wind," I said, "before you catch cold."

He stepped aside.

I walked past him into the warm room, and he shut the door, and the sea sound went out of the world. The fire was lit. A pot of something simmered on the stove. On the table lay a loaf, a knife, a plate of cheese, and a blue enamel mug set out for two.

"You expected me."

"I hoped."

"Then you're a fool."

"I've been told."

I stood in the middle of the floor with my gloves in my hand.

I had one question, and he had one answer, and between us lay the whole bleak weight of a night twelve years gone. I could have said it. I opened my mouth.

Gabriel took a step toward me. "Eleanor," he said, very low. "If you've come to tell me to leave you alone, I'll do it. I swear I will. Whatever else I've failed at, I can do that."

“That’s not why I came.”

“Then why?”

I looked at him. At the scar above his ear. At the hollow of his throat, where a pulse beat quick and visible. At the hands he held away from his sides as though afraid of what they might do.

Ask him what he did with his hands.

“Tonight,” I said, “I don’t want to know anything.”

“I don’t—”

“No truths. No letters. No ledgers, no tides, no names.” My voice shook. “One night, Gabriel. Out of all the nights there are. I want one that has nothing in it but the two of us.”

He was silent.

“And tomorrow?”

“Tomorrow I will ask you whatever I must,” I said. “And you will answer. And whatever you say, I’ll have had tonight.”

His eyes closed.

When he opened them, there was something in them that I would see for the rest of my life, in the dark, in my sleep, in the face of every stranger on every London street.

He crossed the room in three strides. He took my face between his hands, and bent his head, and for a long moment he only breathed against my lips, as though he wished to learn the shape of the air.

“Are you certain?”

“No,” I said. “Are you?”

“No,” said Gabriel. “God help us both.”

I will not tell it all.

There are things a woman keeps. There are pages of a life that are not meant to be read by strangers, and I have written enough of other people’s secrets to know the value of leaving one’s own alone. But I will say a few things, because they are true, and because I have no other way to say them.

He undressed me as if I were something delicate and foreign that he had been charged to carry across a border. He took off my gloves first, finger by finger, and kissed the inside of each wrist where the pulse beat. He undid my hair. He found every hook and button of my gown, one at a time, and the room filled with the soft scrape of silk against skin. He was slow. He was endlessly, unbearably slow. I had thought myself brave and I discovered I was not, that I could be reduced to a trembling creature by a thumb drawn along a collarbone.

“Tell me if I hurt you,” he whispered.

“You won’t.”

“Tell me anyway.”

The cot was narrow. We did not care. The fire threw red light across the whitewashed walls and made a gold cave of the little room. I saw his scars: a long pale line down the forearm, a puckered mark on the shoulder, a seam of old surgery on the ribs. I traced each with my fingertips, and he shivered, and I thought: *this is a man who has been hurt in every way a man can be hurt.*

I said so.

He said, “I’ve been healed more than you know.”

“By whom?”

“By tonight.”

I do not remember what I answered. I remember that I laughed and then did not, that my breath caught on a sound that was not quite his name. I remember the weight of him, the heat of him, the astonishing gentleness of his hands. I remember a moment when he paused, trembling, and looked down at me as though I were a country he had only ever seen on a map, and said, “Eleanor. You’re sure.”

“Yes.”

“I’ll be careful.”

“Be whatever you are,” I said.

And he was.

Gabriel

I woke at three, in the dark, with her head on my chest.

The fire had burned to coals. The room glowed faintly, a red, drowsy, living gloom. Above us, through the open stairwell, the lamp turned and turned, its beam sweeping slowly across the ceiling like a hand smoothing a sheet. Outside the wind had dropped. The sea had gone quiet. It was the quietest night in six years.

She slept.

Her hair lay across my arm in a heavy dark spill. One hand was curled loosely against my ribs. In sleep her face was unlocked, the guardedness all gone, and she looked a girl of eighteen. I lay without moving, and I looked at her, and I thought:

I will remember this.

When the rest of it is ash, I will remember this.

I had known desire. I am not a monk. In the navy there are ports, and in ports there are rooms, and I had gone into some of them with other men's loneliness in my pockets and come out with a little less of my own. But I had never known this. This slow, aching, pouring-out. This tenderness so enormous it frightened me. I had held a man's heart in my hand once, in an operating theatre in Alexandria, still beating, and I had thought: *this is the most fragile thing there is.*

I had been wrong.

This was.

She stirred.

"Gabriel?"

"Here."

"Is it morning?"

"It's the middle of the night. Go back to sleep."

"You're thinking."

"I'm always thinking."

"About what?"

I brushed the hair from her cheek. "How it will end."

"Don't."

"I have to."

"You don't." She lifted her head. Her eyes were dark pools in the dark. "Not tonight. You promised."

"I did not."

"You didn't refuse."

A breath of laughter. "That is a lawyer's argument."

"I'm marrying a magistrate. I've picked up the trade."

I kissed her. I could not help it. I kissed her mouth, her chin, the corner of her eye, the soft place under her jaw, and she made a small sound and slid up my body and pressed her lips to my throat, and the thought of endings went out of the world like a candle in a draught.

Afterward she lay with her cheek on my shoulder and her fingers moving idly on my chest, tracing the scar over my heart.

"What's this one?"

“A bullet.”

“In the navy?”

“In Alexandria. There was a riot.”

“You never told me.”

“I never told anyone.”

“Why not?”

I thought for a long time.

“Because it would have been a story,” I said. “And I didn’t want to be anyone’s story. I’ve been a lot of things. A boy with a drowned father. A surgeon. A coward. A keeper. I never wanted to be a tale told in the dark.”

“You’re not a tale.”

“No?”

“You’re a man.” She raised herself on one elbow. “Gabriel Thorne, aged thirty-two, who keeps a lamp, who has a bullet scar, who is afraid of a letter in his own coat. I know you. I do not need a tale.”

I could not speak.

She laid her palm flat against my face.

“Whatever you did on that gallery,” she said, softly, “I think it was not what you believe.”

I went rigid.

“Eleanor—”

“No. Not tonight. I only wanted you to hear it.” She leaned down and kissed my forehead. “I have been looking at you for weeks. I know what a coward looks like. They don’t hold a letter against their hearts for twelve years. They don’t stay.”

I closed my eyes.

She lay down again. I put my arm about her. We said nothing more. Her breath slowed and deepened, and the red light on the ceiling dimmed, and the lamp went round and round overhead, and I lay awake beside her with her words lodged in me like a splinter that was also a blessing.

I think it was not what you believe.

She did not know.

She could not.

But oh, God, I wanted to believe her.

Eleanor

I woke before dawn, with the cold on my face.

Gabriel was up, standing at the window in his shirtsleeves with the shutters open an inch. A strip of pale gray lay across his shoulder. He did not turn. He stood with his hands on the sill, looking out at a sky just beginning to separate from the sea.

I watched him for a long while.

Then I rose, wrapped the blanket around me, and went to stand at his side.

“The light’s still burning,” I said.

“I’ll put it out in a moment.”

“Don’t. Not yet.”

He glanced down. The sunrise caught the edge of his face, making a gold line along his cheek.

“You’ll be missed.”

“I know.”

“Corbett will be at the gate.”

“I know that, too.” I slipped my hand into his. “Let him wait.”

Down on the water, the first fishing boats were putting out. Little brown sails, dotted across a bruised, lilac sea. The air smelled of salt and woodsmoke. A single gull stood on the cliff edge, motionless, as though it, too, were listening.

“Eleanor.”

“Hm?”

“Whatever happens.”

I turned. His face was grave.

“I wanted you to know. This was not a mistake.”

“I never thought it was.”

“I know. But I wanted to say it.”

I stood on my toes and kissed him, once, softly, the way you might seal a letter.

Then I dressed, and he put out the lamp, and we walked together to the door of the cottage and stood a minute on the threshold in the cold bright morning.

The island lay below us, small and wet and shining.

I took a breath.

And all down the long cliff road, from the stile to the gate of Vale House, I saw a single figure waiting. A big square man in a black coat. His hands were clasped behind him. He had been standing there, motionless, for who knew how long.

Nathaniel Corbett lifted his head, and looked, and did not wave.

Chapter Seventeen

The Dead Man's Name

Eleanor

Corbett said nothing.

He walked me home along the cliff road, two paces behind and to the left, like a servant. He did not speak. He did not look at me. When we reached the gate of Vale House he opened it, and I passed through, and he shut it behind me and stood on the other side with his hat in his hands.

"Mr. Ashcombe will call at four," he said.

"I shall be at home."

"Yes, miss."

That was all. But I felt his eyes on my back all the way up the gravel, as cold and steady as a hand.

I bathed. I changed. I sat on the edge of my bed with my hair wet down my back and my mother's letter on my knee, and I stared at the wall and thought: *Everything that was safe about me has been spent.*

I was not sorry.

That was the dreadful part. I looked for sorrow the way one looks for a lost glove, in all the likely places, and found it nowhere. I found only a quiet, drowned, shining gladness, like the color of a street after rain, and under it a bright thread of fear.

I would have to tell Adrian.

I would have to tell him before Corbett did.

But I did not, as it happened, have the chance.

Mr. Blackwood sent for me at noon.

A boy brought the message, a small round fisher-child with a runny nose and a note in a clerical hand. *Miss Vale: I have been requested by your late mother to speak with you. If you are able, come to the vestry today. I do not trust the post. T.B.*

I read it twice.

Then I sent for my cloak.

The parish church of St. Piran stood on the headland above the harbor, a squat gray building with a stumpy tower and a graveyard that fell away in terraces to the sea. Behind it, a quarter mile north along the cliff, lay the ruins of the old abbey. I had never visited either. As a child I had been taken to service in the carriage, in my best white, and made to sit very still; my mother had always insisted on the front pew. Now I went up the lych-gate alone, in the thin cold noon, with a gray wind pulling at my hat.

The Reverend Thomas Blackwood met me at the vestry door.

He was a spare man in his late sixties, with a stoop and a white fringe of hair and eyes the color of weak tea. He wore his cassock with the air of a man who had worn it too long and had grown to resent the cut. He took my hand in both of his. They were dry and papery and very cold.

“Miss Vale. I did not think you would come.”

“You wrote that you’d been asked by my mother.”

“I was.” He drew me inside. “Come. We will not be overheard.”

The vestry was a low room with a stone floor and a fireplace and a long oak table covered in books. Shelves ran floor to ceiling. Baptismal registers, burial registers, marriage registers. A hundred years of births and deaths in tidy columns. The air smelled of mouse and old leather.

“You have read her letter,” said Mr. Blackwood.

I started. “How do you—”

“Because Hester Crowe has not slept in a week and has been seen going into the church at dawn.” He gave a thin smile. “I am old, my dear. I am not blind.”

“Then you know what it said.”

“I know what it ought to have said. I have known for twelve years.” He lowered himself into a chair with a creak of bones. “Margaret wrote to me in the summer before she died. Three letters. I answered none.”

“Why not?”

“Because I was afraid.”

The words fell into the room like stones.

“I am a priest,” he said. “I have buried a hundred drowned men. I have said the office over empty coffins, because the sea did not give them up. I have stood on that headland in a gale with a prayer book in my hand and wept for people I never knew. And when your mother wrote to me that the lights were being put out by the very men who sat in my front pews, I burned the letters.”

“You burned them.”

“I did. And then I went to the Ashcombe house for dinner, and I ate roast mutton, and I said nothing.” He met my eyes. “I have been saying nothing ever since.”

I did not know what to answer.

“I was not worthy,” Mr. Blackwood said. “But I was left something. And I have kept it.”

He rose, with effort, and went to a cupboard in the corner. It was locked; he took a key from a ring at his waist. From the shelf inside he lifted a large leather-bound volume, heavy as a family Bible, and laid it on the table between us.

“This,” he said, “is the burial register for St. Piran’s, from 1860 to the present.”

I opened it.

Columns of names, in many hands. Dates. Ages. The cause, where known. *Drowned. Drowned. Fever. Drowned. Consumption. Drowned. Drowned.* The ink changed with every clerk, brown to black to brown. My fingers trembled on the pages.

“I have marked certain entries,” said Mr. Blackwood. “In the margin. In pencil. There are twenty-three. These are the burials I conducted on the day after a wreck.”

I turned to the first.

14 Nov. 1863. Anne Marie. Eleven unknown seamen, buried together.

Beside it, a faint pencil cross.

I turned. *1866. 1871. 1874.* A cross by each. I found 1879 and my breath snagged: *Sparrowhawk. 14.*

Seven pages on, in a different hand, the entry for the following spring.

Halcyon. H.M. frigate. 211 hands. Buried as found. And below, in smaller letters, a list of the identified dead, thirty-one names, with their ratings.

And then another list, shorter, headed *Not recovered.*

I read down it.

Wray, Capt. Hallam, Surgeon (previous). Duffy, Midshipman. Penrose, W., Gunner’s mate.

And near the bottom, in a neat clerical hand:

Thorne, Samuel. Age 20. Ordinary seaman. Lost.

Beside it, a small, perfectly drawn cross. And a note, in the margin:

Memorial stone placed at request of the brother. Churchyard, north wall.

I looked up.

“I have seen the stone,” I said. “Coming in. A little slab by the wall. I did not read it.”

“It was erected by Gabriel Thorne at his own expense. Six winters ago. He stands there some evenings, in the dusk.” Mr. Blackwood’s eyes were distant. “I used to watch him from the window. I did not like to intrude.”

“Why have you shown me this?”

“Because of what you will find on the next page.”

I turned it.

It was a loose leaf, not bound into the book. A folded sheet of foolscap, tucked between the pages, soft with age. Written in a boy’s hand, round and careless, the letters not quite level.

It was a list of dates. Seven of them. And beside each date, a word.

Oct. 4. Vestry. Bread.

Nov. 9. Vestry. Bread, cheese.

Dec. 15. Vestry. Coat.

I stared at it. “I don’t understand.”

“They are my own accounts,” said Mr. Blackwood quietly. “Of charity. The entries of a parish priest who feeds those in want. There were many that winter. Many men came to this door without a coat.”

“These dates—”

“Are from the last year.”

“But—”

“Look at the signature.”

At the foot of the page, scrawled in a looping hand beneath a column of figures, was a name.

S. Thorne.

The room went still. I could hear the wind in the chimney. I could hear my own heart.

“That cannot—”

“It can.”

“Samuel Thorne is *dead.* He drowned six years ago. There is a stone.”

“There is a stone.” Mr. Blackwood rested his hands on the table. “And there is a man who signs for his bread in my vestry, on the fourth of each month, in the hour before dawn. He is thin and

silent. He has a scar across his jaw. He eats with his hands, as a hunted creature does. And he asked me, the first time he came, not to tell his brother."

I put my hand over my mouth.

"He thinks Gabriel betrayed him," the priest said. "He believes his brother took Ashcombe's money. He believes that the light went out because his brother, a naval surgeon, was bought. He has been hiding in the abbey for six years, Miss Vale. Living on what he can steal and what I leave in the porch. Writing notes in the dark. And waiting."

"For what?"

"For you."

"For *me?*"

"For the daughter of Margaret Vale." His gaze fixed on mine. "He has known since the day you arrived that you would come to the lighthouse. That you would find Gabriel. That you would unmake the lie. He put out the lamp on Tuesday. He wrote you the note. He slid it under your door by way of the passage behind the pantry, which he has known since boyhood."

"He has been in my house."

"Several times. He has not harmed anyone. He has only watched."

I stood. I could not remain in the chair. My knees shook.

"Does Gabriel know?"

"No."

"Why haven't you told him?"

"Because Samuel forbade it. And because—" He closed his eyes. "Because I am old, and a coward, and I have broken enough promises."

"I must tell him."

"You must."

"Now."

"Miss Vale."

I stopped at the door.

"There is one thing more," said Mr. Blackwood. "The boy is ill. He has a cough. A bad one, wet, in the lungs. He cannot stay in that crypt another winter. And he has said he will not come out until he has seen the ledger put into the right hands." He swallowed. "He means you. I think he means to give you the means to destroy us all."

"Us?"

“The Vales. The Ashcombes. The island. The whole rotten structure.” His voice cracked. “And God forgive me, I think he is right to.”

I went out into the churchyard.

The wind hit me like a slap. The sky was enormous and pale, scoured clean, the color of a bone. Below me the cliff fell away in a long green slope to the sea. And at the north wall, among the gorse and the wind-bent grass, a small gray slab stood alone.

I walked to it.

In memory of SAMUEL THORNE, aged 20 years, lost with H.M.S. Halcyon, April 1885. “He maketh the storm a calm.”

Someone had left a posy of sea-pinks at its foot, wired together with a bit of string. The petals were fresh.

I knelt.

And behind me, in the porch of St. Piran’s, a thin figure in a long dark coat stepped back into the shadow, and watched me, and was gone.

Chapter Eighteen

The False Confession

Adrian

Corbett told me at breakfast.

He stood at the end of my dining table, hat in hand, while I buttered a piece of toast I had no intention of eating. He told it plainly, in the flat voice of a man reporting a change in the weather. Miss Vale had gone up the cliff path at dusk. She had not come down. At first light she had left the cottage with the keeper. They had stood on the step for some minutes. They had not touched.

“Not touched,” I repeated.

“No, sir.”

“But she had spent the night.”

“The lamp burned. The shutters were closed. At two in the morning I saw a figure at the window.” His small eyes did not waver. “A woman’s, sir.”

I laid down the knife.

I had known. I think I had known since the day I saw them on the headland through a glass. But there is knowing and there is *being told,* and the second is a different animal. It came into my chest and sat there and put its claws in.

“Thank you, Corbett.”

“Will there be anything else?”

“No.”

“I might remark, sir,” he said, “that the keeper’s position is not secure. The Board of Trade has a standing complaint against him. Moral conduct. A word from the magistrate—”

“I said thank you.”

He bowed, and went out.

I sat for a long time with my hands flat on the cloth. A clock ticked. Sunlight lay on the silver. And I understood, quite calmly, with the cold clarity of a man contemplating a surgical amputation, that there was one thing left that I could do.

I could tell her the truth.

Not all of it. I am not a fool. But enough.

I called at four, as appointed.

She received me in the library of Vale House. She had chosen it deliberately, I think: a long room paneled in oak, lined with Josiah’s unread books, with a leaded window that looked out on the sea. She sat at the writing table with her back to the light, and there was nothing on the blotter but a pen.

She had not slept. I could see it. But there was a new quality in her, a kind of luminous stillness, like water just after rain. It cut me to the heart.

“Eleanor.”

“Adrian. Please sit.”

I sat.

She did not offer tea. She did not offer anything. She regarded me across the table, and I was struck, as I had been struck at the supper, by how much she looked like her mother. The same level brow. The same unflinching eyes.

“You said you would tell me everything you could,” she said.

“I did.”

“I’ve come to hold you to it.”

I drew a breath.

“There is a paper in my pocket,” I said. “I wrote it last night. It is a statement, and I have signed it, and had Corbett witness the signature. I wish you to take it.”

“What is it?”

“A confession.”

She did not move.

I took the sheet from my coat. Four pages, closely written in my own hand. I laid them on the blotter and turned them so that she could read, and I watched her lower her eyes to the first line.

I, Adrian Thomas Ashcombe, Magistrate for the Isle of Penhallow, do hereby declare…

She read for a long time.

I will set down what I wrote, because I wrote it with great care and I think it was the best lie of my life.

I wrote that on the evening of the eleventh of April, 1885, I had been approached by a man named Lazarus Quick, a smuggler out of Roscoff, who offered fifty guineas for a single night’s blackout of the lighthouse. That the cargo was brandy. That the revenue cutter was due off the headland, and that the darkness would let the lugger slip in unseen. That I had agreed, God forgive me, believing no other ship was expected.

That I had given the order to Corbett. That Corbett had carried it to Pennick. That Pennick had refused. That Corbett’s men had, in the scuffle, struck the old man, and he had gone over the rail of the gallery. That they had put out the lamp themselves.

That at a quarter to midnight, a naval frigate had come in out of the storm.

That two hundred and eleven men had died.

I wrote that I was guilty of manslaughter, or something worse. That I would submit myself to the Assizes whenever she bid me. That I would resign the magistracy. That I would make restitution to the families of the dead, to the last farthing.

I wrote that I was sorry.

It was all true.

Except that it was not. Except that the lamp had gone out on the *Halcyon* by the same three turns of the same key that had put out the *Sparrowhawk,* in the same way, by the same hand. Except that I had not given the order in the smuggler’s name. Except that Quick had been a fiction invented by my steward and, I now suspected, by a man much deeper in my own pay than I had ever admitted to myself.

The truth was uglier. The truth was that the habit of my father’s house had never left me. That in the spring of 1885 the island had been poor, and the harbor dues low, and Corbett had come to me with a ledger of expenses and a suggestion. *One night, sir. Just one. A ship we won’t miss.*

I had said yes.

I had not asked which ship.

She read it twice. When she had finished, she squared the sheets against the blotter and laid her hand on top.

“Thank you,” she said.

“You believe it?”

“I believe you believe it.”

My stomach clenched. “What do you mean?”

“I mean, Adrian, that you have confessed to the *Halcyon,*” Eleanor said quietly. “And you have been kind enough to explain it as a mistake. A smuggler. A misunderstanding with a steward.” She tapped the page. “But you haven’t said a word about my mother.”

“I have told you all I—”

“You told me you were on the stair. You told me you heard a cry. You told me you carried her.” She looked up. “This says nothing of the lighthouse. Nothing of the key. Nothing of the *Sparrowhawk.* You’ve confessed to the lesser crime and left the greater out.”

“Because I don’t know—”

“Don’t.”

It was the quietest word I have ever heard.

“I have been lied to,” Eleanor said, “by an expert. I have been lied to in the kindest way imaginable, by a man who loved me. I recognize the technique.” She turned the pages over. “This is very good. It is very nearly true. And it is a confession that will hang Corbett, and ruin your name, and save the one thing you actually care about.”

“Which is?”

“Your father’s grave.”

I stared.

“You cannot bear to say it,” she said. “Not about him. Not out loud. You’ve been loyal to him all your life; it is the only fidelity you’ve ever had. So you’ve given me the *Halcyon,* which is yours, and kept the *Sparrowhawk,* which is his. And I think—” She stopped. Her voice shook. “I think there is something else under that, which you have not even told yourself.”

I stood.

“You have no right—”

“I have every right. It was my mother.”

“She was a woman who—”

“Careful,” said Eleanor.

I stopped.

It was the way she said it. Not loud. Not angry. A single quiet word, with all the weight of the dead behind it.

I sat down again.

I do not know how long we remained like that. The clock struck the quarter. A cart passed on the road below, creaking. In the grate a coal shifted and fell.

At last she lifted the confession from the table.

“I’ll keep this,” she said.

“I meant you to.”

“As surety?”

“As proof of my good faith.”

“It’s a start.” She slid the pages into the drawer of the writing table and turned the key. “You’ll release Dr. Reed.”

“I can’t.”

“You can, and you will.”

“Eleanor, he is under my protection. If I let him go, Corbett’s men will—”

“Then keep him. But I’ll see him. Today. In the cellar, or the study, wherever you like. Alone.”

I thought about it.

I thought about the Reed I had left on a pallet bed, in the cool dark, with his bag of papers and a flagon of water. A shaking, wizened man who had wept when I came down. *Don’t give me to Corbett, Adrian,* he’d said. *I’ll tell you anything.* And I had said, *I know.*

“Tomorrow,” I said. “Midday.”

“Tonight.”

“Eleanor.”

“Tonight, Adrian.”

I looked at her. At the straight back, the clear eyes, the mouth set in a line of such weary determination that I wanted to weep.

“Tonight,” I said.

I stood in the hall, afterward, buttoning my coat.

Mrs. Crowe appeared at my elbow with my hat. She handed it to me without a word.

“Mrs. Crowe.”

“Sir.”

“How is she?”

“As you see.”

“Does she sleep?”

“Not much.”

“Does she eat?”

“Enough.”

I put on my hat. I stood with my hand on the door.

“You have known her since she was born,” I said. “You know her better than I.”

“Better than anyone, I think.”

“Then tell me.” I could not look at her. “Is there anything left in her that is not grief?”

The old woman was silent.

“There’s a great deal, sir,” she said at last. “But none of it’s yours.”

I nodded.

I think I had expected it. I think I had known it since the day she came home and I saw her step from the carriage in her black traveling dress with the rain on her face, and I understood in a flash of unbearable clarity that the girl I had kept in my heart for twelve years was gone. That a woman had come back instead, a stranger, a magnificent stranger, who did not need me.

I went out.

The evening was clear. The first stars came out over the sea, and the light on the headland began to turn.

I walked down the drive and through the gate and stood in the road for a long moment, looking up at the lighthouse.

She loves him.

I had never said it to myself in words.

She loves him, and she is going to take him from me, and there is nothing I can do.

I laughed.

It was a terrible sound. It startled a rook from the hedge. I stood in the road with the wind tugging my coat and laughed until the tears ran, and then I wiped my face with my sleeve and went home to Marlowe House, and took out my father's old pistol, and cleaned it.

Slowly.

Thoroughly.

With the tenderness of a man preparing for a long journey.

Chapter Nineteen

Beneath the Abbey

Eleanor

I told him in the dark, on the headland, in the wind.

I had meant to do it gently. I had rehearsed it in the carriage on the way back from the vestry, a speech of three careful sentences that began *Gabriel, I have something to tell you and you must sit down.* But when I reached the cottage the lamp was already turning above and the door stood open and he was kneeling on the hearth, trimming a wick, and he looked up and smiled at me with such joy that every sentence fled.

"Samuel is alive," I said.

The wick fell from his fingers.

He did not speak. He did not move. He knelt on the stone with the scissors in one hand and his face gone blank as paper, and the fire made a red flicker in his eyes.

"I saw his name," I said. "In the vestry. In the Reverend's accounts. He has been signing for bread. He wrote the note, Gabriel. He put out the lamp. He's in the abbey. He has been there six years."

"No."

"Mr. Blackwood told me—"

"No."

"He thinks you were bought. He thinks you betrayed him. He's been waiting—"

"*No.*"

It was not a shout. It was a sound I had never heard from a human throat, a long low ragged exhalation, the sound of a man struck in the breast with a pike. He rose. He stood with his hands open. Then he went past me and out of the door and across the grass, quite slowly, like a sleepwalker, and I followed.

He stopped at the edge of the headland.

Below us the sea was black and rising. The wind whipped his shirt and tore at his hair. He stood with his hands at his sides, and his shoulders shook, and I stood a yard behind him and did not touch him.

“Six years,” he said.

“Yes.”

“I put up a stone.”

“I know.”

“I carried flowers.” His voice cracked and split. “I stood there in the dark and told him I was sorry.”

“Gabriel—”

“I was *sorry!*” He turned. His face was wet and wild. “I gave up everything. I came to this place. I lived like a monk. I thought, if I could only find the man who did it, if I could only bring the truth to light, then he would not have died for nothing. And all the while he was in a *hole.*”

“He’s ill.”

“He is a fool!”

“He’s *twenty-six,*” I said. “And he’s frightened. And he thinks his brother sold him.”

Gabriel’s mouth worked.

“Where?” he whispered.

“The crypt.”

“I’ll go.”

“Not alone. Not now. The tide’s making.” I took his sleeve. “Tomorrow, at the ebb. The spring low is at four in the morning. We’ll go together. You and I and a lantern. We’ll find the third niche, and the ledger, and we’ll find him.”

“I can’t wait that long.”

“You can.”

“Eleanor—”

“You can,” I said, “because if you go now, in this state, you will frighten him. He will bolt. He will go down the sea passage and we shall never find him.” I held his sleeve tighter. “He has been hiding for six years. Do you think a man like that comes out for shouting?”

He was silent.

Then, slowly, as though every joint in his body ached, he bent his head and rested his forehead against my shoulder.

I put my arms around him.

We stood there, on the edge of the world, until the first stars came out, and the beam went round above us, and a long swell broke against the Teeth like a distant cannon.

We went down at ebb tide, a little after four.

The abbey stood a quarter mile north of the church, a roofless ruin of tawny stone, its nave open to the sky. The great east window gaped like a missing eye. In the moonlight, the broken arches seemed to float, and the grass between the pillars was silver and soft as a fleece. Owls cried in the dark.

“This way,” Gabriel said.

He had a dark lantern in his left hand, shuttered to a slit. In his right was a crowbar from the tool store. He wore a rough jersey and a leather coat, and he moved with the unhurried alertness of a man who had once been a soldier of sorts.

I followed, in my mother’s old oilskin, with the iron key in my fist.

We crossed the nave. We passed beneath the chancel arch. In the south transept stood a ruined vestry, its roof gone, its walls hung with ivy. In the corner a massive oak press leaned drunkenly against the stones, its doors hanging.

“Behind it,” I said.

Gabriel shifted the press. It moved with a groan. Behind it, a low door of black wood, bound with iron, hung half open on a single hinge.

Cold air breathed out of it.

He held the lantern higher. A stair descended into the dark. Twenty-three steps. I counted. The walls were slick and green with weed, and the air smelled of brine and rot and something sharper, the cold clean smell of deep water.

At the bottom, the crypt opened out.

It was a vast cave, hewn from the rock, with a vaulted roof and a floor of wet black stone. Pillars stood in rows, rough-hewn, the carved tops long since broken. At the far end, perhaps fifty feet off, the cave simply stopped. There was no wall. There was only the sea, a wide dark mouth of it, rising and falling in a long slow breath, and the moon shone down across the water and laid a white road on the floor.

And on the walls, in the silver light, I saw the names.

I had read of them.

I had read my mother's account, three nights ago, in the quiet of my bed. But words are small things, and the crypt was vast, and for a long moment I could only stand with my hand at my throat and look.

They covered every surface. The walls, the pillars, the vaulting, the stairs. Thousands of tiny strokes. Tens of thousands. Name upon name upon name, scratched in the soft stone with nails, with knives, with fragments of iron. Some were deep and clean, the work of a patient hand; some wandered and wavered like writing in a dream. Beside each, a ship. A date. A trade.

Tom Hocking, cook, Anne Marie.

Unknown boy, aged about 9, Constant.

Jean Le Goff, Breton, Marie-Josèphe.

Mary Teague, passenger, Aurora. With her child.

I put out my hand. I laid my palm on the cold wet surface of the wall and felt the grooves under my fingers like the veins of a body.

"It's a ledger," I whispered. "It's the *other* one."

"Yes."

"They kept them. All of them."

"The island kept what it could." Gabriel's voice was rough. "Priests, mostly. Widows. The ones who survived the wreckers. They came down in secret and scratched the names, so the sea would remember."

"The tide," I said.

He looked at me.

"It comes in over them every night, doesn't it? It fills the whole place. It washes over every name." I turned slowly, taking in the vault. "And at the ebb it goes out again, and they're still there."

"The tide keeps our names," said Gabriel.

I closed my eyes.

When I opened them, I saw what I had missed.

At the very back of the cave, near the open sea, a smaller space was cut into the wall. A kind of bay, shoulder-high, with a flat stone ledge. On the ledge lay a bundle of blankets. A tin cup. A candle stub. A coat. A heap of orange peel. A small, neat row of pebbles arranged along the edge in the form of a ship.

A camp.

It was empty.

Gabriel went to it like a man in a dream.

He knelt by the blankets. He lifted the coat, a long dark coat of rough serge, patched at the elbow, much too thin for the season, and held it to his face. I saw his shoulders heave. He did not make a sound.

“It’s still warm,” he whispered.

“Then he’s near.”

“Samuel!”

His voice went out into the vault, huge and broken, and the echoes ran away down the arches. *Samuel. Samuel. Samuel.* The names on the walls gave it back. The sea sighed. A drop of water fell somewhere, *tink,* and was silent.

“Sam! It’s Gabe!”

Nothing.

“I never took the money for you! I took it *after!* I didn’t know about the *Halcyon!*” He was weeping openly now, on his knees on the stone. “Sam, I thought you were dead!”

A cough.

It came from the dark beyond the lantern light. Wet, tearing, hollow. The cough of a man with half a lung. And a voice, hoarse and cracked and young, that said:

“You were right.”

Gabriel went rigid.

“I’m dead,” said the voice. “I’ve been dead six years. Don’t call me back.”

“Sam—”

“Stay where you are.”

“Sam, please. Let me see you.”

“Don’t.” A click: the sound of a hammer drawn back on a pistol. “I will shoot the lady.”

I stood perfectly still.

“I don’t want to,” said the voice. “I’ve come to like her. She’s got her mother’s way of standing. But I can’t have you rushing me, Gabe. I’ve waited a long time for this, and I mean to do it right.”

“Do what?”

“Tell me why you took his money.”

A pause.

Then, very low, Gabriel said:

“Because I let her go.”

My heart stopped.

I heard it. I heard each word as though it were being struck on a bell. *I let her go.* The simple words dropped into the vault and sank, and the names on the walls seemed to lean in to listen.

“Eleanor,” Gabriel said. He did not turn. “I’m sorry. I meant to tell you properly.”

I could not speak.

“I had her wrist,” he said. “On the gallery. For nine seconds. Lord Ashcombe said, *Let go, boy, or your brother hangs.* And I—” His voice failed. “I let go.”

The sea breathed in.

The sea breathed out.

And in the dark at the back of the crypt, a pale figure rose from the shadow, thin as a rake, with a pistol in his hand and a face like a drowned man’s, and said:

“Hello, brother.”

Chapter Twenty

The Last Page

Eleanor

Nobody moved.

The pistol hung in Samuel Thorne’s hand, loosely now, its muzzle pointed at the floor. He stood at the edge of the lantern light, a gaunt scarecrow in a ragged shirt, and I saw that he was shaking. Not with fear. With cold, and fever, and a rage so old it had worn through to bone.

He was twenty-six. He looked forty.

His hair was long and matted. A white scar ran from the corner of his mouth to the hinge of his jaw, a seam as clean as a surgeon’s. His eyes were Gabriel’s eyes, gray and level, sunk in bruised hollows. And across the whole of his face, under the grime, lay the unmistakable architecture of the brother who had knelt weeping on the stone.

“Say it again,” Samuel said.

Gabriel got to his feet.

He did it slowly, with his open hands held out from his sides, as a man approaches a horse that has been beaten. He took one step. Another.

“I let go of her wrist,” he said. “I had her. I could have held on. Ashcombe said your name, and I —” He stopped. “I was twenty. I thought they’d hang you. I thought, if I do as he says, he’ll let the boy go.”

“He did let me go.”

“Yes.”

“With a flogging.”

“I know.”

“With a *flogging,* Gabe.” Samuel’s voice cracked. “Forty lashes. In the yard of the courthouse. I was fourteen. Do you know what it was for?”

“For the silver.”

“For *stealing* it. From the wreck of the *Sparrowhawk.* The very ship.” He gave a wild, ragged laugh. “I was down on the rocks that night with the other boys, picking the bodies, and I put a spoon in my pocket. A spoon. And Corbett saw. And Lord Ashcombe found a use for me.”

I made a sound.

“He used me to buy you,” Samuel said. “That’s what you were never told. I was the bait. He didn’t need to threaten me. He only needed you to *think* he would. And you were such a good brother that you took it.”

Gabriel’s face was ashen.

“I didn’t know.”

“No.”

“I would never have—”

“You would,” said Samuel, softly. “That’s the worst of it. You’d do it again.”

The silence was dreadful.

Then Gabriel said, very low, “Yes. I would.”

I held my breath.

“God help me,” he said, “I would. Not for her. For you. And I have hated myself for it for twelve years, and I will hate myself for the rest of my life. But I won’t lie. You were fourteen years old and you were all I had.”

Samuel stared at him.

The gun wavered.

“And the money?” he whispered. “The bursary?”

“I took it because I couldn’t stand to be in that house another hour. Because Reed would not look at me. Because you were in a cell and I couldn’t help you.” His voice broke. “I took it so I could become something. So that someday I could stand in a court and say, *this is what I saw.* I was going to come back. I swore it.”

“You took six years.”

“I know.”

“You took six *years,* Gabe. You were in the navy. You came home in your uniform and sat in your lighthouse and *waited.* While I—” Samuel coughed. It tore through him, long and wet and wrenching, and he doubled over, bracing one hand on the wall. Blood flecked his lips.

Gabriel was across the space in two strides.

He caught his brother as he fell.

I will not tell all that followed.

It was not mine to tell. I stood at the edge of the cave, with the sea breathing behind me, and watched two men who had spent six years believing each other dead cling together on a floor of wet stone. I saw the pistol go skittering into the shadow. I saw Gabriel’s hand cup the back of his brother’s head, large and tender. I heard the broken sounds they made, the half-words and the sobs, and the tide came slowly up the floor of the crypt and wet my boots, and I did not move.

When at last they drew apart, Samuel’s face was streaked with tears and dirt. He was laughing.

“You look like a bloody gentleman,” he said.

“You look like a corpse.”

“I’ve been practicing.”

Gabriel laughed too, a cracked, wondering, almost frightened sound. He wiped his face with the heel of his hand.

“Sam. You’re burning up.”

“It’s nothing.”

“It’s a lung fever. You’ve had it for months.”

“I’ve had worse.”

“You’ll come out of here.”

“After.”

“Sam—”

"*After,*" said Samuel, with a flash of the old stubbornness. "I haven't waited six years in a hole to be dragged out like a sick sheep. There's work." He turned his head. His gray eyes found me, and his expression changed. "Miss Vale."

"Mr. Thorne."

"I frightened you."

"Yes."

"I'm sorry. I thought—" He coughed again, shorter. "I thought you'd bring Ashcombe. That it was a trap. That he'd sent you."

"He didn't."

"I know that now."

"Then why the pistol?"

A faint, tired smile touched his mouth.

"Because I'm a coward too," said Samuel. "It's a family failing."

The third niche was behind a broken column near the seaward end of the vault.

Samuel showed us. He had known it for two years. He had found it by accident, he said, crawling about in the dark for a place to hide a loaf; he had put his hand into a crack and felt the edge of an iron box. He had not opened it. He did not know what it held. "It felt like something that wasn't mine," he said.

The stone was carved with a cross, upside down.

I knelt before it.

It took the two of them together to pry it loose. A slab, a foot square, set into the rock with lime, so old that it crumbled at the edges. Behind it, a cavity. And in the cavity, wrapped in a square of oilcloth gone green with age and bound with a hempen cord, a book.

It was larger than I expected. A folio, bound in tarred canvas, as thick as my wrist. The cord had rotted. When I lifted it, the cover fell open.

A True Account of the Island's Share.

I turned the pages, and my hands shook.

I will not set down what it said. I have told myself I would not; there are things that should be left for the Assize. But I will say that it was written in four hands, across a hundred and twelve years, and that the earliest entry was in a clerk's copperplate dated 1779, and that the last was in a heavy square script that I knew from the cheques on my father's desk. *Ashcombe. Per Sparrowhawk. £340. Vale's third: £113 6s. 8d.*

Each name had a column. Each column had a sum.

On the final leaf, pinned with a corroded pin, was a folded sheet of notepaper. Cream-colored. Margin ruled in blue.

My mother's stationery.

I knew it before I touched it. I knew it the way you know a footstep on a stair. I unfolded it with a hand that did not feel like mine, and the paper crackled, and my mother's handwriting rose off the page like a voice.

28th September, 1879. Four in the afternoon.

I am in the crypt. The tide is out. I have hidden the ledger in the third niche, under the stone with the cross cut upside down, and I am writing this by the light of a candle, kneeling on the wet floor, because I will not be able to write it at home.

I must record what I heard this morning.

I was in the garden at nine. Josiah was in his study. The window was open. He had Lord Ashcombe with him, and the door was shut, and they spoke in low voices, and I stood beneath the sill among the lavender and heard every word.

Josiah said: "She has the ledger. She has found it. I've seen her go down."

Lord Ashcombe said: "Then it must be recovered."

"She'll not give it up."

"She will be made to."

A silence. I heard the clink of a glass.

Then Josiah said — and I set it down exactly — "Whatever is needed, Edward. But not Eleanor. Never Eleanor."

"Your wife, then."

"She's… yes." A pause. "Do it however you must. Only keep her from suffering."

I did not move. I could not. I stood among the lavender, with the bees droning and the sun hot on my back, and I heard the man I had married speak of my death as a question of arrangements.

It is, I find, a very peculiar sensation.

I thought I should feel rage. I did not. I felt only a kind of enormous, infinite tiredness, as though a great weight I had been carrying for twenty years had been lifted off and replaced by one infinitely heavier.

He did not say it with malice. That is the thing I cannot bear. He said it as one says, "Pass the salt." He said it as a man says, "I've decided against the horse."

I have been loved by a weak man, and that is a worse thing than being hated by a strong one.

I am writing this so that someone will know. Not for justice. I do not expect justice. For truth. Because it is a kind of crime to let a lie sit unnamed in the dark.

Eleanor. My darling. If you read this, you will know that your father was not a monster. He was only a man who could not say no. He did not wish me dead. He wished that things might be otherwise, and he lacked the courage to make them so. Forgive him if you can. If you cannot, forgive yourself for not being able to.

I am going to the lighthouse tonight.

I cannot stop what is coming. But I can light the lamp.

One ship. Fourteen men. If I am too late, then I shall have tried. And that, I find, is all I have ever wanted to be known for.

Margaret.

P.S. Gabriel. If you find this. You will have tried to hold me. I know you. I can see you doing it. Do not.

I will not allow you to be the man who dies on a gallery for a woman he barely knows.

Be kind to my daughter. And be kind to yourself.

I read it to the end.

Then I read the postscript again.

The crypt was very quiet. The sea sighed against the stone. Somewhere in the vault a drop of water fell and fell, a slow soft clock. I knelt on the floor with the paper in my lap and my hands pressed flat against it, and I was aware of Gabriel standing a few feet away, rigid, not breathing.

“Gabriel.”

He did not answer.

“She wrote this at four o’clock that afternoon. Before she knew you would be there.”

“Eleanor—”

“She said *Do not.*”

“I know.”

“She said she would not allow you to die for her.”

“I heard.”

“Then why—”

I stopped.

Because I could see his face. In the lantern light, it was a mask of agony. I understood suddenly, with a kind of cold clarity, what I should have understood weeks before.

It was not the rail he had been unable to forgive himself for. It was not even the nine seconds.

It was that she had *told* him not to hold on.

And he had known. In some part of himself, in the instant that Ashcombe said his brother's name, he had known that she wanted him to let go. That she was already lost. That to hold would have been to drown with her. And he had opened his hand, and she had fallen, and for twelve years he had asked himself *which was it?*

Which was the coward's reason, and which the kind one.

He had never been able to tell.

"Gabriel," I said, very softly.

He turned away.

I rose. I went to him. I laid my hand on the middle of his back, between the shoulder blades, and felt the great shuddering of his ribs, and he did not turn, and I said:

"I knew."

His head came up.

"I knew," I said. "Since yesterday. Adrian told me. He was on the stair. He saw you."

"And you came anyway."

"I came to the lighthouse."

"And—"

"And I did not ask."

"Why?"

"Because I wanted to know who you were," I said, "before I knew what you'd done."

He turned then. He stood looking down at me in the lantern light, his face naked, his eyes red-rimmed and enormous.

"And now?" he whispered.

"Now I know," I said. "And I'm still here."

For a long moment he did not move.

Then he made a sound that was neither laughter nor weeping, and put his arms around me, and held on as though the floor had dropped away beneath us and I was the only solid thing in the sea.

Behind us, from the edge of the water, Samuel Thorne coughed once, discreetly.

"If you two are quite done," he said hoarsely, "I'd like to propose a plan."

Chapter Twenty-One

The Truth Between Us

Gabriel

We carried Samuel out of the crypt at the first gray of dawn.

He had refused, at first. He had stood swaying against a pillar, gripping the ledger to his chest, insisting that he would walk. Then his knees had given way, and I had caught him, and for the first time in six years I had held my brother's weight in my arms and felt how little of it there was. He weighed no more than a boy.

We laid him on the cot in the lighthouse cottage. I built up the fire. I put a poultice to his chest, and brewed willowbark in a pan, and watched his breathing for an hour. When at last he slept, fitfully, with his mouth open and his fingers curled on the blanket, I stood over him a long time.

"He'll live," I said.

"Will he?"

Eleanor stood in the doorway. She had taken off her wet oilskin and wrapped herself in my gray blanket. Her hair hung in a rope over her shoulder. Her face was smudged with crypt-dirt, and her eyes were huge and tired and soft.

"I think so. If he rests. If the fever breaks." I turned. "He's strong. He's stronger than I am."

"Is he?"

"He survived."

"So did you."

"I let go."

"Gabriel."

"I need to say it." I did not look at her. I looked at my hands. "I told you in the crypt, because he demanded it. But I have not *said* it. Not to you. Not as I mean to."

She came into the room. She sat down on the edge of the table, near the fire, and drew the blanket over her knees.

"Then say it."

I sat opposite her on the stool.

I am not a man who speaks well. I have tried, over the years, to put the thing in words, and every time it has come out wrong, too soft, too hard, a shape of self-pity or self-defense. So I took a breath and told it as it was, flatly, in order, the way a surgeon records a case.

"Your mother came up the stair at about eleven. I was behind her by two minutes. I heard Ashcombe's voice before I saw them. He was shouting over the wind. She was shouting back.

"I came up through the hatch. It was black. The lamp was out. There was rain driving across the gallery like needles. Lord Ashcombe had hold of your mother's arm. He was dragging her toward the rail, and she was fighting him, and she had the lantern key in her hand; she'd taken it off the hook. She said, *I will light it. You will not stop me.*

"He said, *Margaret, be reasonable.*

"She said, *Fourteen men.*

"He hit her.

"It was an open hand across the face, the sort a man gives a servant. She staggered. The rail was rotten. I had known it for weeks; there was a section by the northeast corner that the Board had marked for replacing. She went against it. It gave."

I stopped.

Eleanor made no sound.

"I got there. I don't remember crossing the gallery. I was just there, on my stomach, with my arm over the edge. And I had her. I had her left wrist. It was the one I'd stitched. I felt the sutures under my thumb."

"Gabriel—"

"She looked up at me." My voice was a thread. "She was hanging by one arm over a hundred feet of air, with the sea breaking on the Teeth under her. And her face was *calm.* That's what I cannot forget. She was perfectly calm. She looked at me as though I were a boy who had dropped his books.

"And Ashcombe leaned over my shoulder and said, *Let go, boy. Or your brother hangs.*

"And I thought of Sam."

I stopped again. The fire cracked.

"I thought of him in a cell. I thought of the rope. I thought: *I can hold her. I'm strong enough. I can pull her up.* And I thought: *And then he will kill us both, and Sam will hang anyway.*

"And your mother said—"

I could not.

“What did she say?”

“She said, *Gabriel. Let go.*”

Silence.

“Just that. *Let go.* In a perfectly ordinary voice. And then she smiled.”

I heard her breathe in.

“And I opened my hand.”

I had expected her to weep. I had expected a hundred things: anger, horror, the cold withdrawal I had imagined for twelve years in the long white hours before dawn. But Eleanor did not weep. She sat very still, with her eyes on my face, and when I finished she was silent for a long time.

“Thank you for telling me,” she said.

“That’s all?”

“What else would you have me say?”

“That I’m a murderer.”

“You are not a murderer.”

“I killed her.”

“Ashcombe killed her.” Her voice was steady. “He struck her and dragged her to a rotten rail. You could not have held her. You said it yourself. You’d have been dragged over, or he’d have cut your hand off. She knew it. She knew what was coming. She *chose.*”

“She was told to by me.”

“She was told to by *nobody.* She had written it that afternoon.” She leaned forward. “Gabriel. She wrote *Do not.* She wrote it before the fact. She said she would not allow you to be the man who dies on a gallery for a woman he barely knew.”

“I knew her.”

“Then she didn’t.”

I stared.

“She thought of you as a boy,” said Eleanor. “She thought she was protecting you. And you, you thought you’d failed her. And you’ve been two people on either side of a wall for twelve years, each one convinced the other was lost.” Her eyes were bright with tears she did not shed. “Don’t you see? It was *mercy.* Hers. And you’ve been treating it as a sin.”

“I took the money.”

“Yes.”

“I took it, and I left.”

“Yes. You did. That’s the part I find hard.” She did not look away. “You ran, Gabriel. You were twenty and you ran. I understand it. I ran, too. I went to London at eighteen and I didn’t come home for twelve years. We’re two cowards in a boat, you and I. But a man who builds a tombstone for his brother and keeps a lamp for six years is not a coward. He’s only someone who’s been waiting for permission.”

“Permission?”

“To stop.”

I put my face in my hands.

She slid down from the table. I heard the soft rustle of the blanket. She knelt before me and drew my hands from my face, gently, one at a time, and held them in her own.

“Look at me.”

I looked.

“I forgive you,” Eleanor said.

I could not breathe.

“I do not think there is anything to forgive. But if there is, if you need the words, then I forgive it. All of it. The nine seconds, and the money, and the six years.” She pressed my hands. “And I love you.”

The world stopped.

It did not go quiet. It went *still,* the way a held note goes still just before it breaks. I heard the fire. I heard Samuel’s slow breath. I heard the sea, and the lamp turning in its cage overhead, and my own heart, doing something unexpected and enormous in my chest.

“Say it again,” I whispered.

“I love you.”

“Eleanor.”

“Don’t tell me what it means. Don’t say it’s impossible. I know.” Her mouth trembled. “I know what I’m promised to. I know what it will cost. I only wanted you to hear it, once, plainly. In a room. Before the rest.”

I took her face in my hands.

I did not kiss her. I only looked, for a long time, the way a man looks at the shore after years at sea.

“I love you,” I said.

“I know.”

“I loved you from the first morning. From the moment you stood in my doorway in that gray coat and said *you wrote to me.* I have loved you every day since. I will love you after I am dead.”

“Don’t say that.”

“It’s true.”

“Then say it later.” She smiled through her tears. “When there’s time.”

We sat by the fire until the light came up.

She told me about Adrian. About the confession, and the pistol he’d cleaned, and the look on his face when he left. She told me about the plan. Samuel had outlined it, between fits of coughing, in the dark of the crypt. A boat, the Reverend’s, a stout little cutter called the *Faith.* A crew of two: Blackwood himself, who could handle a sheet, and Trevennick’s son. A course for the mainland, a landing at Mousehole, a cart to Bodmin, where the winter Assizes would sit.

The ledger. The diary pages. The confession. The witness.

“Reed,” I said.

“If we can free him.”

“And the sea?”

“It’s the seventh,” Eleanor said. “The day after tomorrow. At dawn, on the flood.”

“The glass is falling.”

She looked up.

I had been watching it for three days. The great brass barometer on my cottage wall had been creeping down, tenth by tenth, since the evening of the spring tide. A bad sign, in a month like this. A *very* bad sign.

“How bad?”

“I don’t know yet. A blow. Maybe worse.”

“Can the boat sail?”

“If we leave early enough.” I swallowed. “If the light holds.”

“The light?”

“There’s only one way through the Teeth at night, at that tide,” I said. “A narrow channel, three cables wide, lined with rocks. A boat can only find it by the beam. If the lamp should fail—”

I did not finish.

She understood.

“Then you’ll keep it burning,” Eleanor said.

“Yes.”

“No matter what.”

“No matter what.”

She took my hand and laid it against her cheek. It was warm and damp. The dawn was coming through the window in a long gold bar, and it fell across her face and made a halo of the loose hair at her temple.

“Gabriel.”

“Mm.”

“When this is over.”

“Yes?”

“What shall we do?”

I thought about it.

I thought about a house with a garden. I thought about a piano in a room with open windows, and a woman’s hands moving on the keys, and the sea in the distance. I thought about a child. About a morning with nothing in it but light.

It was a good dream.

I let myself have it for exactly as long as it takes a wave to reach the shore.

“Live,” I said.

She smiled.

“I’d like that.”

Outside, the barometer on the wall gave a small, dry tick. The needle dropped another tenth. And far out to the west, beyond the Teeth, beyond the last pale line of the sea, a bank of copper cloud began to climb the sky.

Chapter Twenty-Two

The Broken Promise

Eleanor

Adrian was waiting in the library.

I had known he would be. I had known it from the moment I crossed the stile and saw Corbett's black shape standing at the gate of Vale House, hat in hand, an unreadable statue in the early morning. I had known it as I walked up the drive with the dawn at my back and a night's silence in my hair. And I had known it when Mrs. Crowe met me in the hall, her face gray, her lips pressed so tightly that they had nearly disappeared.

"He's been here since six," she whispered. "He would not be put off. He's in the library with a pistol on the desk."

"A pistol."

"It isn't pointed at anyone. It's just—there."

I took off my cloak.

I handed it to her. I smoothed my hair with both hands, and straightened my collar, and drew a long breath. Then I opened the library door.

He sat in my father's chair behind the writing table, with his hands folded on the blotter. The curtains were drawn. A single candle burned beside the pistol, which lay on a sheet of white paper like a specimen. He did not rise.

He looked ten years older than he had the day before.

"Good morning, Eleanor."

"Adrian."

"Sit down."

"I would rather stand."

"You will want to sit," he said gently, "when you hear it."

I sat.

He regarded me for some time. I had the odd sensation of being weighed, of being measured against some private standard, a scale in which my worth in the world was being balanced against something I could not see.

"You went to the abbey," Adrian said.

I did not answer.

"You went down into the crypt, with the keeper. You found a man living there. You found a ledger. You took the ledger, and the man, and carried them to the lighthouse, and you spent the morning in the keeper's cottage." He held up one hand. "I do not ask you to deny it. Corbett followed you from the church wall. He is a very thorough person."

"Then you know everything."

“Almost.”

“What do you want?”

“To make you an offer.”

I waited.

“The man in the crypt is Samuel Thorne,” said Adrian. “He has been dead, in law, for six years. Dead men do not hold property, or sign for bread, or write threatening letters. But a deserter does.”

My blood ran cold.

“Deserter—”

“Of Her Majesty’s Navy. Absent without leave on the night of the wreck, and thereafter.” His eyes were pale and steady. “The penalty is, as you know, severe. I could have him in irons by noon. A man in his state of health would not survive a week in the Penzance gaol. It would be a very quiet death.”

“You wouldn’t.”

“I would prefer not to.”

“You *wouldn’t.*”

“I would prefer,” said Adrian, “to be asked.”

He opened a drawer. He took out a paper and laid it on the table beside the pistol. It was a warrant, in his own clerkly hand, with a blank where the name should go.

“I have signed it,” he said. “I have not filled it in.”

I could not take my eyes from it.

“There is also the question of the keeper,” he said. “Gabriel Thorne was present at your mother’s death. He was, by his own account, the last to hold her. He took a bribe in return for silence. In the eyes of the law, that makes him an accessory after the fact. The penalty is less than for the other. Seven years’ transportation, perhaps. Ten. A man with his record would find it hard.”

“I will testify—”

“To what? That he was *kind?*” He smiled, a terrible, patient, tender smile. “My dear. You are very clever, and you are very brave. But you are not a lawyer. A woman who spent the night at his cottage would be a poor witness for him.”

I felt the blood leave my face.

“You knew.”

“I have known since Tuesday week.”

“And you said nothing.”

“I was waiting for you to tell me.”

He leaned back. The candle flame wavered. In its flicker his face looked carved from wax.

“I will tell you what I want,” Adrian said.

“Say it.”

“I want you to marry me on Saturday.”

“Saturday is the seventh.”

“I know the date.” He drew a breath. “I have spoken to the Reverend. He has agreed to read the banns today. We shall be wed in the parish church at noon, with the harbor in attendance and a feast after. I shall settle upon you the entire estate of Vale House, in your own name, to be held absolutely. I shall give you all the money you require. And I shall give you my full cooperation.”

“Cooperation?”

“With whatever you plan to do with the ledger.”

I stared at him.

“I will not stop the boat,” said Adrian. “I will not intercept the Reverend. I will not touch the Thornes. Samuel may recover in comfort at Marlowe House, if he wishes, or at the cottage, if he prefers. He and his brother will both be free men, and they will remain so.” His voice dropped. “And I shall go with the Reverend to the Assizes at Bodmin, and I shall confess it all. The *Sparrowhawk.* The *Halcyon.* My father’s key. I shall put my own head in the noose.”

I could not speak.

“In return,” Adrian said, “you will give up Thorne.”

The room swam.

“You will not see him again. You will not write. You will not go near the lighthouse. You will marry me, and you will bear my name, and you will be—” His voice cracked. “You will be *mine,* Eleanor, for as long as I live. Which, if the Assizes do what I expect, will not be long.”

“You *want* to be hanged?”

“I want you to be *safe.*” His eyes were wild. “I want to know, in the last days of my life, that I have done one thing for you that was right. That I stood on the scaffold and you were in my house, in my bed, with my name on your finger, and that it was a clean name at last. I want to be the one who saved you. Not him.”

“That is not love.”

“No?”

“It’s ownership.”

“Is there a difference?”

“Yes,” I said. “You have never learned it.”

He laughed. It was a broken sound. “Perhaps not.”

“And if I refuse?”

“Then I fill in the warrant.”

I do not know how long I sat there.

There is a silence that comes when all the doors in a house have closed at once, and one stands in the middle of a room hearing the echoes die. I have heard it three times in my life. The first was the night my mother went into the rain. The second was the day my father’s will was read. And the third was that morning in the library, with the candle burning and the pistol on the blotter and the man I had known since I was fourteen sitting across from me like a stranger.

I thought of Samuel in the cot, his chest rattling.

I thought of Gabriel’s face when I said *I love you.*

I thought of the ledger, the fourteen men of the *Sparrowhawk,* the names on the walls. The tide that came every night and washed them clean and left them whole.

I thought: *One day. Two days. That is all I need. The boat leaves at dawn on Saturday. If I can hold Adrian until it sails—*

“Saturday,” I said.

“Saturday.”

“At noon.”

“Yes.”

“And Samuel will be unharmed until then.”

“On my word.”

“And Gabriel.”

“On my word.”

“Your word,” I said. “Is worth very little, Adrian.”

“It is worth something to me.”

I stood.

I walked to the window and drew back the curtain a hand's breadth. Outside it was full morning, pale gold, mild and windless. Over the sea the sky was a delicate green. And at the edge of the world, low on the horizon, a thin dark line lay along the water like a smudge of soot.

The storm.

"I accept," I said.

I heard him exhale.

"I accept on one condition. I will go to Gabriel myself. I will tell him. I will do it to his face." I turned. "I will not have him learn it from Corbett."

"Eleanor—"

"It is my price."

He studied me. Then, slowly, he nodded.

"As you wish."

"Alone."

"Corbett will be at the gate."

"Let him."

I crossed the room, and took up the warrant, and tore it in half.

Adrian watched me do it. He did not move.

I tore it again, and dropped the pieces on the carpet.

"You will not need that," I said.

I did it at noon.

I walked the cliff path in the full light of a colorless day, with the wind beginning to rise and the first white horses breaking beyond the Teeth. Corbett followed at a distance. I did not look back. When I reached the cottage, Gabriel was at the door, in his shirtsleeves, with a smile already breaking on his face.

I did not let it finish.

"I cannot see you again," I said.

His smile stopped.

"I have promised to marry Adrian Ashcombe on Saturday. I came to tell you so." My voice was flat and level and cold. "I have done a great deal of thinking. You are a good man, Gabriel. But you are a man who lets go. And I do not think I could love someone who lets go."

He stood quite still.

“Eleanor—”

“I need a husband who will hold on. Who will stay.” I lifted my chin. “Adrian has stayed. For twelve years. He has asked for nothing. I find that I admire it.”

“You don’t mean this.”

“I do.”

“You said last night—”

“I said a great many things last night.” I could feel Corbett’s eyes on my back, a physical pressure between the shoulder blades. “I was tired. I was grateful. I mistook one for the other.”

“You’re lying.”

“I am not.”

“Look at me.”

I looked.

I have done many hard things. I have played Brahms with a broken finger. I have buried my father. I have stood on a platform in a black dress and watched a coffin go down. But I have never done anything as hard as that: stand on the step of that whitewashed cottage in the thin wind and look into the eyes of the man I loved, and say, in the voice of a stranger, “Goodbye.”

His face did not change.

That was the worst of it. It simply went out, like a lamp, all at once. The light left it. The color left it. He stood there with his arms at his sides, and he said, in a perfectly steady voice:

“I understand.”

“Gabriel—”

“I understand. You’re right. I’m a man who lets go.” He bowed his head. “I wish you happy.”

He stepped inside.

The door closed.

I stood there with my hand against my mouth, and I did not weep. I could not. If I had wept, Corbett would have seen. So I stood, and breathed, and counted: *one, two, three, four.* I counted to forty.

Then I turned and walked back the way I had come.

And behind me, through the closed door, faint but unmistakable, I heard a sound I had never heard from him. A low, cracked, animal sound. The sound of a man who has been struck in the heart and does not yet know how to fall.

I did not turn around.

I did not turn around, and I did not stop, and I did not stop until I reached the stile, where I put both hands on the rail and bent double and was sick in the grass.

Corbett came up behind me.

“All right, miss?”

I straightened. I wiped my mouth.

“Quite all right, Mr. Corbett,” I said. “Walk me home.”

Chapter Twenty-Three

The Storm Warning

Gabriel

The glass fell all through the night.

I watched it as a man watches a dying friend. By dawn it stood at twenty-nine point four. By noon, at twenty-nine point one. By evening the needle had crept below twenty-nine, into the region marked in faded red *STORMY,* and the wind, which had held mild all day, had begun to moan in the lantern gallery like a woman singing in another room.

I did not sleep.

I did not do anything. I sat on a stool by the stove and stared at the wall. Samuel slept on the cot behind me, his breath rasping, and I listened to it the way I listened to the sea. Overhead the lamp turned. I cleaned the lens. I trimmed the wick. I did every task that remained, in the order set down in the Trinity House manual, and when there were no more tasks I sat.

I understand. You are right. I am a man who lets go.

I had said it. I had meant it. That was the horror. Standing in the doorway of my own house with the wind in my face and Eleanor’s eyes fixed on mine, as cold and clear as the lens of a lamp, I had felt not anger but something much worse: relief.

At last, some small tired animal in me had whispered. *At last it’s over. She has seen what you are.*

I had gone inside. I had sat on the floor with my back against the door. I had put my fist in my mouth and bitten down until I tasted blood.

And I had not once thought: *She is lying.*

Samuel woke at dawn.

He lay for a time staring at the ceiling. Then he turned his head, and his gray eyes found me on the stool, and a long silence stretched between us.

“You look like hell,” he said.

“You look better.”

“I feel like I’ve been dug up.” He tried to sit. I went to him; he waved me off. “I can manage. Where’s the girl?”

“She’s not coming.”

“Why?”

“She’s marrying Ashcombe.”

He did not move.

“On Saturday,” I said. “At noon. She came yesterday to tell me. She was most clear.”

“Gabe.”

“I’m told I’m a man who lets go.”

“Gabe—”

“It’s all right. It’s true.”

Samuel swung his legs over the side of the cot. He sat, swaying slightly, his big knuckly hands on his knees. He looked at me for a long time, with the same hard level look our father used to turn on a mended net.

“You’re a bloody idiot,” he said.

“I beg your pardon?”

“I said, you’re a bloody idiot.” He coughed, and wiped his mouth. “Did she cry?”

“No.”

“Did she look at you?”

“She looked at me.”

“Did she look at your *face,* or past you?”

I thought.

“At my face.”

“And she was dry-eyed.”

“Perfectly.”

“With Corbett behind her.”

I opened my mouth. Then I closed it.

“I spent six years watching that man in the dark,” Samuel said. “I know every move. He’s got the eyes of a heron. He never stops. He has a way of standing where he can see both of you and the door. If Ashcombe had been fool enough to send him to follow her, he’d have been there. Right there.” He looked at me. “She told you with him at her back?”

“I… didn’t see him.”

“You wouldn’t.”

“Sam—”

“She was *lying,* you great ox.” Samuel’s voice cracked on a laugh. “She was putting on a play for the audience. Holy Mother. And you swallowed it whole.”

I sat very still.

The wind howled in the chimney. The lamp whirred in its housing. And a thing began to rise in my chest, slow and enormous, like a diver coming up from a great depth, a thing that was neither joy nor terror but both, with a bright cold edge.

“I made her say it,” I whispered.

“You what?”

“I told her I understood. I told her she was right.”

“Well, that was clever.”

“I wished her *happy.*”

Samuel put his face in his hands.

By midday the clouds had come up from the west like a wall.

I stood on the gallery and watched them. They were a color I had seen only once before, on the night of the *Halcyon,* a dark purple-black, tinged underneath with a sulphurous yellow. The sea beneath was a sheet of lead. The first rollers were beginning to break on the Teeth in long slow explosions of white, and the spray hung in the air like smoke.

Below, in the cottage garden, a figure was coming up the path.

I knew the gait. A short, square, determined woman in a black bonnet, with a basket on her arm and her skirts clutched in one fist against the wind.

I went down to meet her.

“Mrs. Crowe.”

“Mr. Thorne.” She was out of breath. “I’ve little time. He’s in the stables with Corbett and the horses. I told the cook I was going to the village.”

“What is it?”

She put the basket on the step and drew from beneath the cloth a small packet wrapped in brown paper and tied with twine.

“From Miss Eleanor,” she said.

I took it.

Inside the paper was a sheet of cream notepaper. A single line.

I have not forgotten.

Under it, in a different hand, shakily but unmistakably in pencil, another line:

I would have said it to your face if they had let me.

I sat down on the step.

“She wrote it at midnight,” said Mrs. Crowe. “By candle. She had me stand at the door. She tore up the first four.” She sniffed, fiercely. “I don’t hold with deceiving a man. But I held with it that night.”

“Where is she now?”

“In her room. With the door locked. Mr. Ashcombe has a man on the stair.” She gripped my sleeve. “She says you’re to go on. You’re to sail on Saturday’s flood, before dawn, as agreed, with the Reverend and the cutter, and not to wait for her. She’ll find a way.”

“There’s no way. She’s to be married at noon.”

“She says there is.”

“What?”

“She wouldn’t tell me. She said, *Mr. Thorne will know when it’s time.*”

I looked at the paper in my hand. The wind tugged at the corner. The ink was already blurring from the first fine drizzle that had begun, unnoticed, to fall.

“Mrs. Crowe.”

“Yes?”

“Did she say anything else?”

The old woman’s face softened. For a moment, under the severity, I saw something very young.

“She said,” Mrs. Crowe repeated slowly, “that she would see you again. And that she would not be late.”

The storm came on in earnest at nightfall.

It came in four stages, like a symphony. First the wind, rising from a moan to a roar to a shriek. Then the rain, driving flat across the headland in sheets that hit the tower with a sound like gravel flung against a drum. Then the sea, which began to climb the cliff face in white slabs, and break against the rock, and hurl spray as high as the gallery. And last the dark, a thick complete blackness, solid as velvet, in which nothing existed but the lamp and the noise.

I stood in the lantern room with my hand on the brass rail.

The lens blazed above me, a hundred prisms throwing rainbows on the streaming glass. The beam went out, a white road across the water, and every few seconds the rain caught it and turned it to a shaft of silver. I could see the Teeth, a ragged line of black and white a quarter mile out, and beyond them the great gray hills of the sea moving in to break.

Keep it burning.

No matter what.

At nine o'clock, Samuel appeared on the stair.

He was gray and sweating and leaning on the rail. He had put on my old oilskin over his shirt and a pair of my boots, and he looked like a scarecrow dressed for church.

"Lie down," I said.

"I'm going to the cove."

"You're not."

"The Reverend's expecting me. The boat's rigged, Gabe. We sail at one, on the flood. It's the only tide." He coughed. "Blackwood will have the crew in the harbor by midnight."

"In this?"

"It'll blow harder before it blows out. We'll go in the lull."

"There is no lull. Not in this."

"There's always a lull."

"Sam—"

"If we wait for fair weather, Ashcombe will have us all in irons by morning." He caught my arm. His grip was weak but fierce. "She's giving us the time. She's paying for it. If we waste it, then what was it for?"

I looked at him.

I thought of Eleanor on the step of this cottage, white-faced, saying *I do not think I could love someone who lets go.*

I thought: *She was lying. She said exactly what would hurt me most.* And I thought: *She knew it would work.*

I put my hand over his.

“I’ll take you to the cove,” I said. “I’ll light you out.”

“And Ashcombe?”

“Let him come.”

I took my brother’s weight against my shoulder.

Together we started down the hundred and twelve steps.

The wind struck us at the bottom like a fist.

I had thought myself used to storms. I had been in the Bay of Biscay in a January gale, with the sea breaking over the foremast, and thought nothing of it. But this was something else. It had a voice. It howled and tore and pulled at our clothes, and it was cold, bitterly cold, with a freezing edge of rain in it.

We got Samuel across the headland by inches.

The path to the cove ran along the cliff, then down a gully to a shingle beach at the foot of the abbey ruins. In the dark, it was a river of mud and loose stone. Twice I lost my footing. Once Samuel went down on one knee, and I hauled him up by the collar, and he swore in a whisper that would have shamed a bargeman.

At the bottom we saw the lantern.

A tiny light, swinging, in the lee of a broken wall. A huddle of men in oilskins. The shape of a boat drawn up on the shingle, black against the white of the surf.

“Mr. Thorne?” called a thin voice.

“The Reverend!” Samuel croaked.

Blackwood came forward out of the dark. He wore a seaman’s slicker over his cassock, and a sou’wester tied beneath his chin, and he looked about as much at home in it as a bishop in a brothel. In one hand he carried a lantern. In the other, a boat-hook.

“My son,” he said. “You’re alive.”

“So they tell me.”

“And the ledger?”

“In my coat.”

“And Reed?”

Samuel’s face fell. “We don’t have Reed.”

“We do not.”

“Then we have nothing.”

“We have you,” said the Reverend, quietly. “And the ledger. And a letter, which Miss Vale sent by hand this afternoon. It names the day, the place, and the court. If we reach Bodmin, we have a case.”

“If.”

“If.” He glanced past me, up at the cliff. “Mr. Thorne. Will you keep the light?”

“I’ll keep it.”

“All night?”

“Until you’re clear.”

“And after?”

I looked at the sea.

It heaved and boiled under the beam. The white road shone and shivered on the water, and at the end of it, hardly visible, a line of white foam marked the Teeth.

“I’ll keep it after,” I said.

The Reverend nodded.

“God keep you,” he said. “God keep us all.”

He put out his hand, and I took it, and Samuel took mine, and for an instant the three of us stood together in the howling dark with the sea at our feet.

Then I turned and began the long climb back to the light.

Chapter Twenty-Four

The Burning Letter

Adrian

The storm broke over Marlowe House at six in the evening, and by seven I had made up my mind to ruin everything.

I did not know it then. I thought I was only restless. I paced the study with my hands behind me while the windows rattled in their frames and the chimney roared, and I told myself that I was a man about to be married. That in less than a day I would stand at the altar of St. Piran’s with Eleanor Vale on my arm. That I had done, at last, the one thing that mattered. I had *won.*

I had won in the way that a man wins who has paid a thousand pounds for a dying horse.

She had come to me with her chin high and her eyes dry. She had said *I accept.* She had looked at me across my father's desk, as straight and cold as a blade, and I had known with a terrible clearness that she hated me.

Not hated. That would have been a kind of tribute. She had *looked through* me, the way one looks through a window at a view.

I had said to myself: *It will come. In time. When she sees what I have done. When she sees that I kept my word.*

But I knew, even then, what I had bought.

I had bought a woman's body in a church, and the loan of her name, and the sight of her face across a breakfast table for the rest of my short life. I had not bought one moment of that look she had given the keeper, the look I had seen through the glass on the cliff, a look like a lamp lit behind a face.

I would never see it turned on me.

At eight, Corbett came in, dripping, and told me the sea was running over the harbor wall.

"Is the cutter still at her moorings?"

"No, sir." He wiped his face. "She went out at dusk. The Reverend and young Trevennick took her round to the abbey cove."

"Without waiting for Saturday."

"They'll sail tonight, sir. On the flood. There's talk on the quay."

"In this?"

"They say the Thorne boy is aboard."

I stood very still.

I had given her my word. *I will not stop the boat.* I had said it in front of the candle, with the pistol on the blotter. And I had meant it. God knows I had meant it. I had wanted, with a violence that frightened me, to be a man whose word was good.

"They will drown," I said.

"Very likely, sir."

"The channel is three cables wide."

"Yes, sir."

"They'll have to pass the Teeth. In the dark. In a gale." I swallowed. "The only light is the lamp."

Corbett said nothing.

He stood with the rain running off his hat brim and his small pale eyes fixed on the middle distance, and I understood, with a slow cold lurch in the stomach, why he had come to tell me.

“No,” I said.

“Sir?”

“Whatever you are about to suggest. No.”

“I haven’t suggested anything, sir.”

“You have been standing in my father’s study for forty years suggesting things,” I said. “Get out.”

He bowed. His face did not change.

“The boat’s key is in your desk, sir,” he said. “The second one. If you should have need.”

He went out and closed the door.

I sat down.

I put my head in my hands.

Somewhere on the headland, in the dark, the lamp turned. I could not see it. I could feel it. A faint white pulse behind my eyelids, steady, relentless, like the beat of a heart.

I went to Vale House at nine.

I told myself I wished to see her. I told myself I wished to be certain that she was well, that the storm had not frightened her, that Mrs. Crowe had kept up the fires. I put on my oilskin and walked the half mile through a wind that nearly took the hat from my head, and when I reached the front door and rang, there was no answer.

I rang again.

I tried the latch. It gave.

The hall was dark. A single candle burned on the table at the foot of the stair. The portraits stared down from the walls, Josiah and Margaret, side by side, and the great chandelier swayed above me on its chain and threw long shadows across the marble.

“Eleanor?”

My voice rang. No one answered.

I went up.

The man I had posted on the landing sat slumped against the banister, his hat over his eyes. I touched his shoulder and he fell sideways, quite limp. A neat red mark stood out on his temple. He breathed, thickly, evenly.

Struck. Not killed.

I pushed open Eleanor's door.

The room was empty. The bed was made. The window stood wide open and the curtains streamed into the room like banners, soaked, flapping, dragging rain across the floorboards. A rope of knotted sheets hung from the sill.

For a moment I could not think.

Then, very clearly, I thought: *She never meant it.*

I crossed the room in three steps and looked out. The garden lay below, black and tossing, the lavender thrashing flat. The rope of sheets ended four feet short of the ground. At the bottom, in the mud, I could see a long smear where someone had dropped and rolled.

She had gone.

She had gone to him.

She had *always* been going to him.

I sat down on her bed.

The mattress sighed under me. On the pillow lay a little book bound in black cloth. I picked it up and turned it over, and my thumb found the worn place on the spine where a hand had held it. It fell open.

This is the private diary of Margaret Vale.

I read the first line.

I read the second.

Then I stopped, because the page was blurring, and I found that I was crying again, silently, shamefully, without any sound at all.

She had left it for me.

I do not mean that she had meant to. But she had put it on the pillow, in plain sight, where a man who knew her would find it; she had known I would come. And I knew what she was asking. She was not asking me to read it.

She was asking me to *understand.*

I turned the pages. I saw my father's name, written in a hand that was steady and unforgiving. *Lord A. has the key.* I saw my own, in an entry dated the summer I was twenty-two. *The Ashcombe boy was at the harbor this morning, helping a lame sailor with his nets. He has his mother's eyes and none of his father's. I wonder what the island will make of him.*

I turned a page.

28th September. They have taken Eleanor's keys. She is locked in her room for her own safety. I am to go to the lighthouse.

Adrian was on the stair when I passed him. He was white. I touched his hand. I said, "Whatever you see tonight, you are not to blame for it." He didn't understand.

He will.

I hope he will forgive himself before I'm cold.

I closed the book.

I sat there for a very long time with it in my lap.

Margaret Vale had known. She had stood on the cliff stair in the rain with a murderer waiting above her, and she had stopped to touch the hand of a frightened boy and absolve him.

You are not to blame.

For twelve years I had waited for someone to say it. For twelve years I had imagined, in the long hours of the night, the voice of the woman I had failed, telling me it was all right. And she *had* said it. She had said it before it happened. And I had carried her body up the cliff, and put it in the grass, and never once let myself hear.

I stood.

The room swayed. I put out a hand and caught the bedpost.

Burn it.

The thought came quite clearly, in my father's voice. *Burn it, boy. Burn it all. There is no proof but paper. Burn the paper and the girl is yours.*

I looked at the diary.

I looked at the fireplace, where Mrs. Crowe had laid a good fire against the cold, and where the coals still glowed in the grate.

I do not know what I would have done, if I had been left alone. I think, in the end, I would have put the book down. I think I would have walked out of that room and down the cliff and knelt in the mud and begged.

But the door opened behind me, and Corbett said:

"She's at the lighthouse, sir."

"How do you know?"

"The Penrose boy saw her on the cliff path. In her mother's oilskin. Running." He stood in the doorway with the lantern behind him, a vast dark shape. "She came out of the abbey. By the tunnel. The one beneath the stairs."

“I see.”

“The boat sails at one.”

“I know.”

“The lamp must be dark by half past twelve, sir. If it’s to be done.” His voice was perfectly even. “I have three men below.”

I looked at the book in my hand.

I looked at Corbett.

And I did what I had spent my whole life doing. I did what my father would have done. I did what a hundred Ashcombes had done before me, on a hundred nights like this one, with a key in their pockets and the dark behind them.

I walked to the fire.

I held the diary over the coals.

It was only a small black book. It weighed almost nothing. I felt the heat of the grate on my knuckles and thought: *This is the last thing she wrote. This is the last thing she was.*

You are not to blame.

I opened my hand.

It fell onto the coals with a soft sigh, and for a moment nothing happened. Then the cover began to curl. A tongue of blue flame ran along the spine. The pages blackened and lifted, one by one, and the writing showed for an instant in glowing gold, line after line, *Eleanor has a cough again, the ham was dry, J. has gone to Truro and I confess I am glad,* and then crumbled to ash.

I watched all of it.

When it was done, I turned to Corbett. My face was quite dry.

“Get the men,” I said.

“Yes, sir.”

“I’ll go to the lighthouse myself.”

“Sir?”

“If it is to be done,” I said, “I will do it. I will not have it said that I sent another man to do my father’s work.”

He bowed.

I took my oilskin from the bed where I had dropped it. I took my father’s pistol from the pocket of my coat, and checked the priming, and put it back.

At the door I paused.

The room was cold. The curtains still streamed in the wind. On the pillow lay a dent where her head had been, and beside it, scattered across the white linen, a few long dark hairs.

I bent, and gathered them, and put them in my breast pocket.

Then I went out into the storm.

Chapter Twenty-Five

The Lighthouse

Eleanor

I climbed out of my window at eight o'clock with a rope of bedsheets and a stolen kitchen knife.

I will not pretend it was brave. I had planned it for hours, with Mrs. Crowe holding the door and the maid weeping in the corner, and when the moment came my hands shook so badly that I tied the third knot twice. The man on the landing was an islander named Pascoe, with a face like a boiled egg and a wife expecting. I had knocked on the door and asked, in a small voice, for water. He had come in with the jug. Mrs. Crowe had stepped out from behind the screen with the poker.

I will say, for the record, that she struck him very kindly.

Then I went out of the window into the wind.

It snatched me at once. The rope swung and slammed me against the stone and I hung there, breathless, with the whole black garden tossing under me, and thought: *I am thirty years old, and I am doing this.* Then my arms gave out, and I dropped the last four feet, and landed on my back in a bed of wet lavender with the air knocked out of me.

I lay there for a count of five.

Then I got up and ran.

Not for the cliff path. Corbett had men on it, I was certain. I ran for the house, around to the east wing, to the little door in the cellar wall that I had found in the pantry, the one Samuel had used for six years. It opened onto a stair, and the stair went down, and at the bottom was the study with its chart and its lamp. I crossed it. I pushed open the iron-hinged door in the stone. And I went into the tunnel with a candle in one hand and the knife in the other, and a mile of black rock before me, and the sound of the sea like a beast breathing in the walls.

I emerged in the crypt a little before ten.

The tide was high. The floor was a shallow lake. The names on the walls glimmered faintly in the wet, and the water lapped at my knees, and a great swell lifted through the seaward

opening and rolled in like a hand, shouldering the candle out. I stood in the dark, soaked to the thighs, and did not mind.

I felt my way to the stair.

I came up through the vestry. I crossed the open nave, with the rain sheeting through the broken roof and the wind roaring in the ruined arches like an organ played by a madman. I came out at the north door. And there, a quarter mile off, high on its headland, with its great white eye turning in the murk, stood the lighthouse.

I had never seen it so beautiful.

It was a blade of light cutting the dark. It hung over the sea like a promise, steady, impossible, defiant. The storm tore at it. The rain flew past it in streaks. And it kept turning, round and round, as it had turned for sixty years, as though nothing in the world could put it out.

I put my head down and ran.

He was on the gallery when I got there.

I knew because I heard him. The wind carried his voice down the tower, a long ragged shout, not words but a sound, an exultant cry like a man who has seen a ship. I stood at the foot of the iron stair and looked up, and saw him leaning over the rail, a black figure against the swinging beam.

“Gabriel!”

He did not hear.

I put my hands to my mouth.

“*Gabriel!*”

He stopped.

I saw him look down.

I do not know how to describe what happened next. He did not call. He did not wave. He simply stood with his hands on the rail, staring, and then he turned and disappeared into the tower, and I heard his feet on the iron treads, a long ringing thunder, a hundred and twelve steps taken three at a time.

The door at the foot of the stair burst open.

He stood in it, soaked, breathing hard, with the lamp-oil on his hands and the lens-light in his hair.

“Eleanor.”

“I wasn’t lying,” I said. “I want you to know that. I said it to Corbett, not to you. I was never going to marry him.”

“I know.”

“You know?”

“Sam told me. I was a fool for a day.” He crossed the space between us. “And Mrs. Crowe brought your note.”

“I’m so sorry—”

“Don’t.”

“I said terrible things.”

“Eleanor, *don’t.*”

He took my face in his hands.

He did not kiss me. He looked at me, and his hands were shaking, and his eyes were enormous and wet. I saw the rain on his lashes. I saw his throat work.

“I thought I’d lost you,” he whispered.

“I told you I wouldn’t be late.”

“You’re soaked.”

“I came through the sea.”

“You’re *mad.*”

“I know.” I laughed. It cracked in the middle. “I have been told.”

He pulled me against him so hard that the breath went out of my lungs. I felt his heart through his shirt, and his arms around my back, and the damp wool of his jersey against my cheek. He smelled of oil and salt and rain, and he was alive, and warm, and mine.

We stood there in the roaring dark, at the foot of the tower, and held on.

He took me into the cottage.

The stove was lit. A kettle sang on the hob. The lamp in the window had been trimmed low. Samuel was gone; the cot was bare, the blanket folded in a square. A note lay on the table: *Gone to the cove. Don’t be an ass. S.*

I laughed again, and this time it did not crack.

Gabriel wrapped me in a blanket and sat me by the fire and knelt to pull off my sodden boots. His hands were gentle and clumsy. He worked on the laces for a long time, and when he had them off he held my bare foot in both palms and rubbed it between them, and I looked at the top of his dark head and thought: *I would give anything for this to be all.*

“Gabriel.”

“Hm?”

“Where is the letter?”

His hands stopped.

“The one she gave you. In August. The sealed one.” I touched his hair. “The one for me.”

He looked up.

“I think it’s time,” I said.

He sat back on his heels.

For a moment he said nothing. Then, slowly, he rose and went to the shelf where the books were stacked. He drew down a thick one, Gray’s *Anatomy,* its spine cracked, and opened the back cover. A thin leather pocket was sewn into the lining. I had not noticed it. He slid two fingers inside.

He came back and knelt and held out a letter.

It was small. Not much larger than a playing card. The paper had gone the color of weak tea, and the wax seal on the back, a plain red disc stamped with a ship in full sail, was worn smooth by years of thumbs. It had been handled so many times that the corners had softened to velvet.

On the front, in my mother’s hand:

For Eleanor, when she is a woman grown.

And beneath it, a second note on a separate scrap, fastened to the first with a pin. The paper was stained brown. Stained, I saw, with something that had once been red.

Gabriel. Take this. Keep it from them. I do not blame you for anything that happens tonight. M.V.

“She left it on the stair,” Gabriel said. His voice was very low. “At the foot of the tower. Under a stone, with the corner showing. I found it the next morning. There was blood on it from her hands.”

“Why didn’t you give it to me?”

“I tried. When you were eighteen. I came to Vale House in the winter and stood at the gate. I saw you in the window, in your black dress. You looked like a ghost.” He swallowed. “I couldn’t. I had no right to be the one to carry her last words to you. I thought, *if I give her this, I must tell her the rest.* And I couldn’t.”

I took the letter.

It weighed nothing at all.

“I won’t open it yet,” I said.

“No?”

“Not tonight. Tonight I only want to hold it.” I closed my fingers on it. “Because when I read it, it’ll be over. She’ll be done speaking. And I would like, for as long as I can, to have her still say something to me.”

He bowed his head.

“I understand.”

“I know you do.”

He leaned his forehead against my knee.

And from the window, across the storm, over the roar of the sea and the shriek of the wind, I heard the faint clang of a bell.

A boat’s bell. Small and thin.

Far out on the black water, below the lamp, a single yellow light was moving.

“The *Faith,*” Gabriel said.

We stood together at the window.

She was tiny. A crumb of wood on a mountain of water, plunging and rising, plunging and rising, with a spark of lantern at her masthead. A scrap of brown sail clung to her. As we watched, a white wave broke over her bow and she vanished, and my heart stopped, and she came up again, streaming, still afloat.

“She’s early,” I breathed.

“They went at the lull.”

“Is she clear?”

“No.” His hand closed on mine. “She has the channel to run. A mile of it. And she needs the beam.”

I looked up.

Above us, in the tower, the lens turned. A great white arm swept down across the sea, and caught the little boat, and held her, and passed on.

“It’s one hour,” I said. “Until they’re through.”

“One hour.”

“We can keep a lamp burning for an hour.”

“Yes.”

“Gabriel.”

“Yes?”

“I think someone is coming up the path.”

He turned his head.

Through the streaming glass, a hundred yards off along the cliff, a row of lanterns was bobbing in the dark. Five, six, seven of them. The light caught the long black shapes of men. And at the head of the line, tall and straight and walking with the unhurried confidence of one who has never in his life been refused, came a figure in a long dark coat.

“Adrian,” I said.

“Yes.”

“He said he wouldn’t.”

“He lied.”

“He doesn’t know how to do anything else,” I whispered, and found, to my surprise, that I was weeping. “God help him.”

Gabriel took my hand.

We stood side by side, in the window of the keeper’s cottage, in the roar of the storm, and watched the lanterns come on.

Chapter Twenty-Six

The Confession

Adrian

They were standing at the window when I came up the path.

I saw them through the glass, two dark heads close together, her hand in his. I saw the lamplight on her wet hair. I saw her turn, and look at me, and not look away.

I stopped at the garden gate. Behind me the six men halted in a ragged line, lanterns swinging, the rain hissing off their hats. Corbett stood at my shoulder. I could smell the wet wool of him, and the tobacco, and under it the faint sweetish smell of a man who has done this before.

“Wait here,” I said.

“Sir—”

“Wait.”

I went on alone.

The door of the cottage opened before I reached it. Thorne stood on the threshold with the light behind him, bareheaded, in his shirtsleeves, with a short iron bar in his right hand. He did not raise it. He only held it, loose and ready, the way a man holds a tool.

“Mr. Ashcombe.”

“Mr. Thorne.”

“You said you wouldn’t stop them.”

“I said a great many things.”

“You gave her your word.”

“Yes,” I said. “I am told it is worth very little.”

Behind him, in the small bright room, Eleanor rose from the hearth. She had a blanket round her shoulders and her boots in her hand. She looked at me, and I saw in her face not rage, and not fear, but something that made my breath catch.

Grief.

For me.

“Adrian,” she said. “Come in out of the rain.”

I sat at their table.

It was an absurd thing to do. I sat at the keeper’s table with my wet oilskin dripping on the flagstones, and a mug of hot tea in front of me that I did not touch, while the storm shook the windows and the lamp turned overhead and two people I had wronged stood watching me from opposite sides of a stove. Thorne had put the bar on the shelf. He had not put it far.

“You’ve come to put out the light,” Eleanor said.

“Yes.”

“Why tell us?”

“Because you deserve to hear it first.”

She said nothing.

“I have brought six men,” I said. “They are outside. They have orders to take the keeper and the lady into custody at my word. Corbett will go up the tower. I will go with him. At eleven fifty-two I will turn the key, as it has been turned on this night every year since I was a boy.”

“There are four men on that boat.”

“Five. The Reverend, young Trevennick, the Thorne boy, and two hands from the harbor.”

“They will die.”

“Very likely.”

“Adrian.”

“I know.” I looked at my hands. “I have known since I left Marlowe House. I knew when I burned the diary. I knew, I think, when I signed your confession and put it in your drawer. I have known my whole life what I am.”

“What are you?” said Gabriel.

I raised my eyes.

He was standing very straight, his hands at his sides, his gray gaze fixed on my face. There was no anger in it. That was the strange thing. Only a kind of patient, appalled attention, such as a surgeon gives to a wound.

“I am my father’s son,” I said.

I told them.

I had not known I would. I had come up the cliff with a speech prepared, short and cold, an ultimatum. But as I sat at that table and Eleanor’s eyes rested on me, quiet and steady, the speech went out of my head like water down a drain. And what rose in its place was the truth, all of it, in the order it had happened, as simply as a man might read a ledger.

“I was twenty-two. My father came to Marlowe House at nine on the night of the twenty-eighth and said, *Come.* I came. I did not ask why. I had never asked why.

“We walked the cliff in the storm. He talked the whole way. About the island. About duty. About how a gentleman’s first obligation is to the people he commands. He said it as one says the Creed. When we reached the lighthouse he took out the key and showed me, once more, the three turns, and I watched the lamp die.

“A little after eleven, Margaret Vale came up the stair.

“I had never seen her so. She was white, soaked, with her cloak half off and her hands wrapped in rags. She looked at my father and said, *I will light it.* And he said, *Margaret, be reasonable.*

“And he struck her.”

I stopped. The kettle sang. Somewhere above us the great lens whirred.

“I was at the head of the stair,” I said. “I saw it. I saw him hit a woman I had known all my life, who had given me barley sugar when I was seven, who had taught me my notes. I saw her stagger. I saw the rail. I saw the boy come up through the hatch, and fling himself across the boards.”

I looked at Thorne.

“I saw you take her wrist.”

He did not move.

“I saw you hold her. I saw your face. I heard her speak to you. I could not hear the words, but I saw her lips.” My voice shook. “I saw her smile. And I saw you let go, and I knew, in that

instant, what I'd always known. That the thing I'd been told was a lie. That a man may be a coward without being a villain, and a villain without being cruel. And that my father, who had never raised his voice to me, was the most dangerous creature on earth."

"Adrian—" said Eleanor.

"Let me finish."

She bowed her head.

"I went down the rocks," I said. "I did not run. I think that is the one thing I did right. I went down, and I stood in the sea to my waist, and I found her. I pulled her out. I carried her up the cliff to the grass and wrapped her in my coat. And I looked up, and there was a white shape in the window of Vale House, and I knew who it was.

"I thought: *She will remember me.*

"And I thought: *She will be right to.*"

I paused.

I wanted, very badly, to stop there. It was a good place to stop. It made a story. A boy, frightened, who did the one decent thing in a night of cowardice. If I stopped there, she would have forgiven me, I think. In time.

But I was done with stories.

"There is one thing more," I said. "I have never told it. I have not told a priest. I have not told God."

Eleanor lifted her head.

"Penhallow," I said.

Silence.

"My father did not die by accident. You know that, I think. You have always known." I felt my mouth twist. "He had been ill for a year. Consumption. He knew it. He drank to ease the pain, and the drink made him cruel. The night he died was the eleventh of December. Eleven weeks after your mother.

"I came home at ten. He was in the east wing, in the library, drunk, with a lamp. He was reading the ledger, the *copy,* the one he had kept for himself. He looked up and said, *Ah, there you are. We must talk about the girl.*

"Eleanor. I mean you.

"He said you were a danger. That you had been at the window. That you had seen. He said, *The Vale girl will have to be dealt with. Discreetly.* He said it exactly as he had said it of your mother."

Her face had gone gray.

“I said, *No.*

“He said, *Adrian*—

“I said, *No. Not her. Not again.*

“And he laughed.

“He stood up. He swayed. He took a step toward me with the lamp in his hand, and the lamp tipped. I saw the oil spill. I saw it catch on the Turkey carpet. I saw the flame run along the floor to the curtains, and up the curtains to the ceiling, and my father standing in the middle of it all, laughing.”

I breathed.

“I could have pulled him out. It was twelve feet to the door. I was strong. I was young. I could have taken him by the collar.”

“You didn’t,” said Gabriel, very low.

“I stood in the doorway,” I said. “I watched. I counted to sixty. I told myself I was waiting for him to come. And when I could not hear his laughter any longer, I closed the door.

“I closed it. I turned the key.

“And I walked out of the house into the garden, and found you at the gate in your black dress. And I said I would never let anything hurt you.”

The only sound was the rain.

I had expected a horror. I had braced myself for it, as for a blow. But when I looked up, Eleanor was not recoiling. She stood quite still, with her hand against her mouth, and tears running down her face, and I understood that she was not weeping for him.

She was weeping for me.

“Adrian,” she said at last. “Why are you here?”

“To put out the light.”

“No.”

“Eleanor—”

“You don’t want to. You didn’t want to at the Assembly Room, or in the library, or in the study with the pistol. You’ve never wanted to. You’ve been looking for someone to stop you since the day you were fifteen.” She took a step toward me. “Why tell us, if you mean to go on?”

“Because I do not know how to stop.”

It was the truest thing I have ever said.

"I have a key in my pocket and a man at my back and a lifetime of habit in my hands. I have been told what to do since I was a child. I have *done* it. I have sat in the magistrate's chair and done it." I stood. "Do you think I have not tried? Do you think I have not stood at that window every night for twelve years and thought, *tonight, I will not?* And in the morning I wrote the order."

"You didn't write it this year."

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because you were coming home."

She looked at me for a long time.

"Then don't," she said.

"I cannot."

"You can."

"I *cannot.*" My voice cracked. "Eleanor, I am going to be hanged. If that boat reaches Bodmin, I shall stand in the dock and hear my father's crimes read out, and mine, and they will take me to Bodmin gaol and break my neck. I will die in disgrace, and the name of Ashcombe will be spat upon in every harbor in Cornwall. And you will be *free.* You will go away with him, and have children, and play the piano, and in fifty years you will say, *Oh yes, I knew a man once.*"

"That's not—"

"It is exactly so."

"Adrian."

"So I have decided," I said, "that I would rather you hate me."

Thorne moved then.

He took one step forward, between us, quite deliberately, and stood with his hands open.

"Mr. Ashcombe," he said. "You are not your father."

"No?"

"A man who is his father's son does not sit at a kitchen table and confess to the woman he loves." He regarded me steadily. "Whatever you do tonight, you have already done the hardest thing. You have said it. Don't throw that away."

I stared at him.

I had hated this man for six weeks. I had hated him with a purity that had warmed me through the long nights. And here he stood, the man who had held Margaret Vale's wrist and let go, who

had taken my father's money and sold his silence, who had taken the woman I loved and the life I could not have, and he was speaking to me with a kind of tenderness.

It was unbearable.

"Corbett," I said.

The door opened.

"Sir."

"Take them."

I will not describe it.

I will say that they came in quickly, three of them, with their lanterns and their boots, and that Thorne fought. He struck one man to the floor with the iron bar and broke another's wrist. For a few moments the little room was a roaring chaos of limbs and shouted curses and the splintering of furniture. Eleanor was against the wall, her hand at her throat. I stood by the table, quite still, with my father's pistol in my hand, and did not know when I had drawn it.

"Enough," I said.

No one stopped.

"*Enough.*"

I fired into the ceiling.

The report was enormous. Plaster rained down. The room froze.

"Tie him."

They bound Thorne's hands behind his back with a length of cord. He stood under their grip, bleeding from a cut above his eye, and looked at me.

"You'll regret it," he said.

"I regret everything."

"I mean tonight."

"I know."

I turned to Eleanor.

She had not moved. She stood at the wall in her blanket, her bare feet on the cold stone, and her eyes were enormous.

"I'm sorry," I said. "I truly am. You'll be kept here, with two men at the door, until it is over. No one will harm you."

“Adrian—”

“And in the morning, I’ll come and tell you how it ended.”

She said nothing.

I pocketed the pistol. I took the key from my coat, the heavy iron key with the notch like a bird’s beak, and held it in my palm. It was warm.

I went out into the storm.

Behind me, through the door, I heard her say, quite softly, not to me but to the man in the cords:

“Gabriel. We have fifty minutes.”

And his voice answering, steady, almost gentle:

“Then let’s not waste them.”

Chapter Twenty-Seven

The Last Night

Gabriel

They left two men to watch us.

One sat on the step outside, with his back to the door and a lantern between his boots. The other stood at the window, a big silent fisherman named Hocking, with a cudgel under his arm. Neither spoke. Corbett had gone up the tower with Ashcombe. We could hear them on the stair, a slow ringing climb, boots on iron, fading into the roar of the storm.

I sat on the floor with my wrists bound behind me.

They had tied me to the leg of the stove. It was a cruel little irony. I could feel the iron hot against my spine, and the cord biting into my wrists, and my own blood running warm down my face from the cut above my eye. Eleanor sat beside me on the flagstones, with her blanket around her, free. They had not thought it necessary to bind a woman.

She leaned her head against my shoulder.

“Don’t move,” she said, very quietly. “Hocking’s watching.”

“I wasn’t going to.”

“I’m going to look as though I’m weeping.”

“Are you?”

“Not yet.”

Her fingers were already moving behind me. I felt them find the knot, small and cold and deft, picking at the cord. She worked without a sound, her face turned into my collar, her breath stirring my neck. To anyone watching, she was a woman in despair, clinging to a man. I felt each loop give.

“Where did you learn this?” I murmured.

“Sailors’ knots. My father taught me. I was seven.”

“He taught you to untie a man?”

“He taught me to tie a bowline. This is the same thing, backward.”

I almost laughed.

“Forty-nine minutes,” she breathed.

It took her six.

When the last coil fell loose I held my wrists together behind me, still, as though bound, and waited for my heart to quiet. Hocking had not turned. The man on the step coughed and spat. Overhead the lamp turned and turned, and the beam swept the walls, and I counted the seconds between each sweep: twelve, twelve, twelve.

“Now?” I whispered.

“Not yet.”

“Why?”

“Because we have a little time.” She raised her head. In the dim light her face was white and calm and very close to mine. “And I should like to use some of it.”

I understood.

“Eleanor—”

“Gabriel.”

“We can’t.”

“We can’t do anything else.” She smiled, with such tender, rueful, steady courage that I felt my chest crack. “I’ve counted. It’s forty minutes. Twenty to get free, and the stair, and the tower. Perhaps twenty to spare.” She drew a breath. “I would like, if it’s to be the last, to spend some of it as a person.”

“It isn’t the last.”

“No?”

“No.”

“Then it won’t matter if we spend it well.”

I bent my head.

She kissed me.

It was a small kiss, and a quiet one, in a room full of enemies, with my hands behind my back and a cut on my brow. It tasted of salt and rain and her own breath. Her mouth was soft and certain. She did not close her eyes. She watched me the whole time, and I watched her, and across the inch of air between us something passed that was larger than words.

“Open it,” I said, when she drew back.

“What?”

“The letter.”

Her face went still.

“It’s inside your blanket,” I said. “I saw you put it there. Open it. Read it to me. I should like to hear her say it.”

“Gabriel—”

“It’s what she wanted. And—” My voice failed. I swallowed. “And if I die tonight, I’d like to have heard it. Just once. In her words.”

She looked at me for a long time.

Then she reached into the blanket and drew out the little square of paper.

Her fingers were quite steady. She broke the seal with her thumbnail. The wax cracked and fell in a few red flakes to the floor. She unfolded the page. And in a low voice, scarcely louder than the rain, with her head against mine and Hocking’s shadow on the wall, she began to read.

My darling Eleanor,

If you are reading this, you are a woman grown, and I am not there to see it. Forgive me. I am so sorry. I should have liked to watch you become whatever you are.

I do not know what you will have learned by now. I do not know whether you hate your father, or pity him, or have forgotten him entirely. I pray you have not forgotten me.

I have been trying to think what a mother ought to say at the end. I have written four pages and burned them all. The truth is I have only one thing to tell you. It is so small that I am almost ashamed.

It is this. Be brave in the small things.

I was not brave in the large ones. I was frightened of Josiah. I was frightened of the island. I let a great many days go by in a house I knew to be wrong, because it was easier than leaving. When

at last I found my courage it came too late, and in an odd shape, and cost me more than I had to give. Do not wait for it to be large. It does not arrive that way. It comes in small pieces, in unremarkable moments, and you must pick it up each time, like a coin you find on the road.

Tell the truth when it is easy. Then, when it is hard, you will already know how.

Mrs. Crowe will help you. She is the staunchest woman alive. Be kind to her; she has carried more than she shows.

Gabriel Thorne will have carried this letter. He is a good man, and he is a frightened one. I wish I could have lived long enough to see him less afraid. If you should find, in the course of things, that you have a tenderness for him, do not be ashamed of it. I would not be.

Do not avenge me.

I mean that. Do not let the thought of me poison you. Do what is right, because it is right, and because the names on the wall are not the only ones the tide has kept. It has kept mine, too. And it has kept yours, though you do not know it yet.

You have my hands. Play something for me.

Your loving Mother.

She finished.

The room was very still.

Rain beat on the roof. The lamp turned. Somewhere outside, a long way off, a bell was tolling on the water, thin and silver and brave.

I did not look at her. I could not. I sat with my head bowed and my eyes shut, and the tears ran down my face, and I let them. The cord around my wrists was loose. My hands were free. I did not use them.

“She knew,” I said.

“Yes.”

“She knew I would be there.”

“I think she hoped.”

“She said *tenderness.*”

“Yes.”

“I would have given anything,” I said, “to have her say it to my face.”

Eleanor put her arms around me.

She held me against her breast, and her cheek was wet against my hair, and she rocked me gently, back and forth, like a child. And I understood that she was giving me back what her

mother had given her. That the whole long inheritance of grief and love and unfinished business had come down in that single letter and been placed in my hands.

“Gabriel.”

“Mm.”

“I have a thing to say.”

“Say it.”

“If this goes wrong. If it ends badly. If one of us goes into the sea.”

“Eleanor—”

“I want you to know that I would not change it.” She drew back and looked into my face. “Not one hour. Not the lighthouse, or the study, or the night in your bed. Not the crypt, or the storm, or the cord on your wrists. If I had it to do again, I’d come back to this island on the same carriage, in the same rain, and walk up the same path, and knock on the same door.”

“You’d choose this?”

“I’d choose *you.*” Her voice shook. “Every time. Every road.”

I could not answer.

I kissed her again. Her mouth, her eyes, her wet cheeks. She slid her fingers into my hair. And in the warm dim room with the storm roaring outside, I held the woman I loved in my arms, and for the space of a dozen heartbeats, nothing existed in the world but the two of us.

Eleanor

At eleven forty-one by the clock on the mantel, Hocking turned from the window.

He looked at us.

We were sitting on the floor, side by side, with our heads together, as we had been sitting for half an hour. My eyes were red. Gabriel’s face was tracked with tears. We must have looked, I thought, exactly like a pair of beaten lovers waiting for the end.

“It’s almost time,” said Hocking.

“Yes,” I said.

“I’m sorry, miss.”

“Are you?”

“My wife’s cousin was on the *Sparrowhawk,*” he said slowly. “A cook. Billy Tregear. I never knew till the Reverend told me. Nobody ever told us.” He shifted the cudgel. “I’d not have taken the shilling, if I’d known.”

I looked at him.

Behind my back, Gabriel's hand closed on mine.

"Mr. Hocking," I said, gently. "Put the cudgel down."

"Miss—"

"Please."

He did not move.

"The lamp goes out at eleven fifty-two," I said. "It's eleven forty-one. In eleven minutes, five men on a boat will be in the channel, in the dark, and they will die. Two are islanders. One is a priest. One has a scar from your own magistrate's whip." I held his eyes. "You have a choice. It's very small. But it's yours."

He stared at me.

His lips moved.

Then, with a kind of slow grinding reluctance, like a man laying down a stone he has carried for years, he bent and set the cudgel on the floor.

"What do I do?" he whispered.

"Open the door," said Gabriel, rising.

He stood. The cord fell from his wrists. He rolled his shoulders, and flexed his hands, and the lamp-light fell on his face, battered and bloody and quite transformed.

I had never loved him so much.

"Hocking. Tie up the other fellow on the step. Quietly. Then come with us."

"And Mr. Ashcombe?"

Gabriel's eyes met mine.

"Mr. Ashcombe," he said, "is a man who's about to be asked a question. And I think—" His voice softened. "I think he's been waiting a very long time for someone to ask it."

Chapter Twenty-Eight

The Sea Takes Everything

Eleanor

A hundred and twelve steps.

I counted them, going up. I counted them aloud, under my breath, the way one counts in a dream, with the iron ringing under my boots and the whole tower shuddering round me in the

wind. Gabriel took them three at a time ahead of me. Hocking pounded behind, wheezing. The stair spiraled up through the whitewashed throat of the lighthouse, and each turning showed us a slit of window, and each window showed us the night: black, streaming, a madness of rain and spray and tearing cloud.

At forty I could feel my heart in my teeth.

At eighty I stopped being afraid.

I do not know why. It came over me like a hand laid on the head. A strange, tranquil lightness, as though the long weight of the last twelve years were falling from me, step by step, like stones from a pocket. I thought of my mother kneeling in the crypt with her pen. I thought of her smile on the gallery. *Be brave in the small things.* There is nothing smaller than a step. And there I was, taking one more.

At a hundred and ten, Gabriel stopped.

He stood with his hand flat on the lantern room door. He did not look back. In the yellow glow from beneath the sill I could see his shoulders rise and fall.

“Eleven fifty-one,” he said.

“Yes.”

“If he’s turned it—”

“Then we relight it.”

“If Corbett’s armed—”

“Then you’ll hit him harder.”

He laughed.

He put his shoulder to the door and pushed.

The lantern room blazed.

I had been in it before, in sun, on a morning of blue and silver, and thought it the loveliest place on earth. At night in a storm it was another thing entirely. The great lens turned in its brass cradle like some enormous glittering animal, and every prism flung a spear of light through the streaming glass. The rain beat on the panes in a constant roar. The wind shrieked in the ventilators. Under our feet the whole structure thrummed like a struck bell.

Two men stood beside the lamp.

Adrian was nearest the lens. He stood with his back against its brass pedestal, white as paper, his hands hanging. His oilskin lay in a puddle at his feet. He wore only his shirt and waistcoat, and the wet cloth clung to him, and the beam as it came round lit his face from within like a lantern, then left it dark.

Behind him, vast and square, with a pistol in his hand, stood Corbett.

“Ah,” said Corbett. “The keeper.”

“Mr. Corbett.”

“I’d thought Hocking had more sense.”

“He found some.”

“Pity.” The pistol rose, quite slowly, until it pointed at Gabriel’s chest. “Come in, Mr. Thorne. Shut the door. You’ll let the draught in.”

Gabriel did not move.

I stepped past him.

“Adrian,” I said.

He lifted his head.

“It’s eleven fifty-two,” I said. “Isn’t it?”

His lips parted. A kind of tremor ran through him, from head to foot. His right hand went to his waistcoat pocket, and came out clenched around something that gleamed. The key.

“Eleanor.”

“Don’t.”

“Eleanor, I—”

“Look at me.”

He looked.

I do not know what he saw in my face. I know only that I stood in the full blast of the lamp, with my wet hair plastered to my cheeks and my mother’s oilskin hanging off my shoulders like a rag, and I looked at him with every particle of love I had ever had for the boy who gave me a brass lighthouse in a handkerchief. I let him see it. I let it all show. I did not pretend that it was gone.

“You are not your father,” I said.

“I—”

“You are not.”

“Sir,” said Corbett, softly. “The hour.”

“I know the hour.”

“It’s now, sir.”

“I *know.*”

“Then if you’ll permit me—”

The pistol did not waver. With his left hand, almost delicately, Corbett reached across Adrian’s shoulder and plucked the key from his fingers.

It happened so quickly.

I saw Adrian’s hand close on air. I saw Corbett slide the key into the lock at the base of the pedestal. I saw his thick wrist turn, once, twice, three times, with a steady, practiced, almost tender motion. Something in the machinery clicked and ground and went still.

The lens stopped turning.

The great white arm of light swung once more across the sea, slowly, slowly, as the mechanism coasted, and halted, and pointed to the west, at nothing, at a wall of rain.

And then, with a soft cough, the lamp went out.

The darkness was total.

It was the dark of a closed box. It fell on us like a hand. For an instant there was nothing but the sound of the storm, the wail of the wind and the drum of the rain, and the hiss of four people breathing. I put out my arms. I could not see them. I could not see my fingers.

Then Gabriel roared.

I have never heard a sound like it. It was not rage, exactly. It was something from further down, a cry torn from the same place that had made him sit weeping on a stone floor. I heard the thud of his body striking Corbett’s, and the clang of the pistol hitting the brass, and a shot, deafening, enormous, a gout of fire in the black.

Glass shattered.

Somebody screamed. I think it was I.

Then a vast roaring gust blew in through the broken pane, and in the sudden sheen of lightning I saw them: two men locked together at the door to the gallery, wrestling, their faces inches apart. Corbett’s thick hands were at Gabriel’s throat. Gabriel had his knee in Corbett’s belly. They crashed through the door.

Out onto the gallery.

Into the rain.

“*Gabriel!*”

I ran.

At the doorway a hand caught my arm, hard. Adrian. He stood behind me with his face stark and wet and wild.

“The lamp!” he shouted over the wind. “Eleanor, the lamp! Leave them!”

“I can’t—”

“The *boat!*” His fingers dug into my sleeve. “Four minutes! They have four minutes before they strike!”

I looked at him.

He was weeping. He was laughing. His eyes were enormous. “Help me turn the key,” he said. “It has to be unlocked. Counter-clockwise, three turns. Corbett took it with him—no, there’s the second—” He fumbled at his waistcoat. “I have it. Come. I can’t do the wick alone.”

I looked at the gallery.

Through the streaming glass, in the flash and flare of the lightning, I saw two black figures struggling at the rail. One was huge. One was lean. The rail, the rotten northeast corner, the section the Board had marked for repair, shivered between them.

Let him. Let him fight. He is stronger than he thinks.

I turned and followed Adrian to the lamp.

We did it together.

I held the oil lantern. He knelt at the base of the lens with the iron key trembling in his hand. His fingers shook so that he could not find the lock. I put my hand over his, cold and wet, and guided it. The key slid in. He turned.

Once.

Twice.

Three times.

Something in the clockwork groaned and caught. The great bronze cradle gave a shudder, and the lens began, slowly, to move.

“The wick!”

I struck a lucifer on the brass. It guttered. I cupped it with both hands, my body between it and the draught from the broken window, and lowered it to the lamp. For a heart-stopping moment the flame bent, bowed, flattened. Then it caught.

A small blue bud. A yellow flower.

And then the whole lens leapt into radiance.

The beam shot out. It lit the sea for twelve miles, white and furious and beautiful, and I saw below us the whole black scene laid out in a single frozen instant: the Teeth, a ragged line of

foam; the mountain of the swell; and, in the very mouth of the channel, a tiny cutter plunging, tilted, her brown sail in tatters, her lantern swinging.

“She’s there,” I whispered.

“Yes.”

“She’s *through.*”

“Not yet.” Adrian’s hand gripped mine. “The channel turns at the third rock. She needs to see it.”

The beam swung.

The boat, in its light, was a toy. A chip. A scrap of wood on a hillside of water. As we watched, she came round, heeling, hard on the wind, into the white lane the lamp laid down across the dark. A great sea lifted her. She hung on its crest. For one dreadful instant I thought she would be driven onto the rocks.

Then she slid down the back of the wave and into the channel, and the beam swept after her, and I saw a figure at her stern wave an arm.

A thin figure. In a long dark coat.

“Sam,” I breathed.

Beside me Adrian made a sound I had never heard, a low broken exhalation, half a sob, half a laugh. He bent his head, and I saw the tears pour down his face. And he said, to no one, to the lamp, to the long line of dead Ashcombes receding behind him into the dark:

“I turned the key.”

I found them on the gallery.

Gabriel was alone. He stood at the rail with one arm hooked round a stanchion, drenched, bleeding from the nose and mouth, his shirt torn open to the waist. Of Corbett there was no sign. The northeast corner of the rail was gone. A jagged gap showed where it had been, and the iron stubs of the uprights were bent outward like the fingers of a hand.

I did not ask.

I went to him through the wind. I put my arm round his waist, and he put his around my shoulders, and together we stood in the lee of the lantern wall and looked down at the sea.

“They’re through,” he said.

“Yes.”

“We kept it burning.”

“We did.”

“I held on.”

I turned my head.

His face in the white wash of the beam was cut and bruised and radiant. There was blood in his teeth. He was smiling. And in the smile there was a thing I had never seen before, in all the weeks of watching his face, a thing so clean and so complete that it stopped my breath. It was relief. It was pardon. It was the look of a man who has put down a stone.

“I held on,” he said again, wonderingly. “To a man. By the throat. I had him over the edge, and I held on. And he went anyway. But I *held.*”

“Yes.”

“It was different.”

“I know.”

“Eleanor—”

“I know.”

He kissed me, there in the rain, with the beam sweeping over us, white, white, white.

And I saw it over his shoulder.

I have tried to tell this part many times.

I have never found the words. It was not a wave. It was a wall. It rose out of the western dark a quarter mile off, a vast smooth wall of water taller than the lighthouse, with a crest of white and a face of black glass. It came on without a sound. I saw the lamp strike it, saw the whole lit face of it blaze green. I saw the Teeth vanish under it, one by one. I saw the little boat in the channel, far to the east now, safe, tiny, turn her stern to it and ride up like a gull.

I opened my mouth to scream.

“Gabriel—”

He had already turned.

I felt his arm tighten round me. I felt the whole hard length of him against my side. He pulled me into the lee of the door, and hooked one hand into the iron frame, and with the other he took my hand in his and held it with such force that the bones ground together.

“I have you,” he said in my ear.

“I know.”

“I have you. I won’t let go.”

“I know.”

“Eleanor. I won’t.”

The sound reached us then. A roar, a rising thunder, like the end of the world. The tower shook. The whole stone shaft quivered. A shriek of metal as the lantern gallery, the old iron gallery with its rotted rail, tore itself from the wall.

I looked back through the doorway.

Adrian stood in the lantern room, clinging with both arms to the lens pedestal. His face was turned toward us. His mouth was open. He was reaching, and I saw his hand stretched out across the heaving floor, the fingers spread, and the look in his eyes was the look of a man who has only now understood what he was for.

“*Eleanor!*”

The wave struck.

Gabriel

I held on.

I want that to be what is remembered. Whatever else, in the end, the island chooses to say of me, whatever the Board puts in its reports or the Reverend in his register or the children in their skipping songs, I want it written plainly, once, in one place, where it cannot be taken out.

I held on.

I felt the water take us. It lifted us from the gallery like a hand lifting a leaf. It was cold, and it was black, and it was enormous, and it had no malice in it at all. It went through me the way a river goes through a reed. I had her hand. I did not let go. I felt the iron frame tear out of my fingers and the world turn upside down, and the stars were below us, and the light was above, and I thought, quite clearly:

She is warm.

She is warm, and she is here, and I have her.

We fell.

We fell for a long time. Or perhaps it was only a moment. It is hard to tell, in the sea. The beam went round overhead, steady and white and patient, and for an instant I saw her face, turned up to mine, pale as a pearl in the dark, with her mouth open and her hair streaming. She was not afraid. She was smiling.

She said something.

I could not hear it. The sea was in my ears. But I saw her lips, and I knew the shape of them as I knew my own name.

Play something for me.

No.

I love you.

I tightened my grip on her hand.

I said it back.

And the last thing I saw, before the black water closed over us both, was the great lens above, turning, turning, turning, throwing its beam out over the Teeth and the channel and the little cutter far away and safe in the lee, as steady as it had ever been, as steady as the night Margaret Vale fell, as steady as the day I was born.

It did not go out.

It never went out again.

Chapter Twenty-Nine

What Remains

Adrian

They found me at dawn, still holding the lens.

Hocking told me afterward. He had come up the tower an hour after the wave, half drowned himself, with a broken arm and a lantern, and found the lantern room a ruin: the windows gone, the floor awash, the gallery torn from the wall as a child tears the crust from bread. And in the middle of it all, the great lens, turning. Turning still. Its brass cradle was bent. Its prisms were cracked. But it turned, and the beam went out over the gray water, and kneeling at its foot with both hands locked on the iron handwheel, turning it by force when the clockwork failed, was a man in a wet shirt who did not seem to hear his name.

I had kept it burning.

I have no memory of the three hours. I know only what they told me. That I turned the wheel by hand, a quarter turn every twelve seconds, until my palms split and my fingers froze to the iron. That when Hocking tried to take my place I struck him. That when the sun came up I was still turning, and the Reverend's cutter was seen far out in the Channel, a speck of brown sail, bound for Mousehole, and Hocking said *Mr. Ashcombe, sir, they're clear,* and I said *I know,* and could not let go.

They had to cut my hands free.

I was tried at Bodmin in the second week of December.

I will not give the whole of it. It has been written down elsewhere, by clerks, in the dry hand of the law. It took six days. The Reverend gave evidence for two. Dr. Reed, who had been found in

my cellar by Mrs. Crowe on the morning after the storm, weeping and unharmed and quite sober for the first time in a decade, gave evidence for one. He produced the page from the lining of his bag. He read aloud the words he had written in a steady hand twelve years before: *Contusion to the left temple, consistent with a blow. Fracture of the right radius. Death by drowning, but not accidental.*

The court was very quiet when he finished.

Samuel Thorne gave evidence on the fourth day. He was brought in on a chair. He had been in the infirmary at Penzance for six weeks, and he looked like a man who had been dug out of a bog and set to dry. But he spoke for an hour and a half in a clear, hoarse, level voice, and when he had done there was not a dry eye on the jury benches, nor, I think, among the counsel.

He did not look at me once.

I understood.

The ledger was entered as an exhibit. It was passed from hand to hand along the bench. I watched the judge turn the pages, and I saw his face change, from the fixed professional blandness of a man of the law to something older and more disturbed. He read for a long time. When he looked up, he looked, not at me, not at the dock, but at the gallery where the island's gentry sat in their best black, shoulder to shoulder, with their hats in their hands.

I saw them see it.

I saw the Trevennicks, and the Penroses, and old Mrs. Vivian from the Assembly Room, and Sir Henry Tregenza, who had sat on the Board of Trade, and the Bishop's secretary from Truro. I saw them look at the book in the judge's hands, and I saw the thing pass through them like a cold breath.

Every one of them had had a share.

Every one.

I pleaded guilty.

I did it on the first morning, before the indictment was read, in a voice I did not recognize as mine. I pleaded to the manslaughter of the crew of H.M.S. *Halcyon.* I pleaded to being an accessory to the deaths of the brig *Sparrowhawk.* I pleaded to the concealment of the death of Margaret Vale. I asked that Corbett's name be struck from the indictment, for he was dead, and that my own take its place.

My counsel wept.

The judge asked whether I understood the consequences.

I said that I did.

He asked whether I had anything to say before sentence.

“Only this,” I said. “I should like it recorded that Eleanor Vale and Gabriel Thorne lost their lives on the night of the sixth of October, in the service of the light, in an act of conscience which saved five men on the cutter *Faith.* That the lamp was relit by their hands, and by mine. That without them I should have been a murderer twice over. And that the court should know their names.”

There was a silence.

Then the judge, an old man named Pollock with a face like a walnut, bent his head and wrote for a long moment.

“It is recorded,” he said.

They did not hang me.

I had expected it. I had wanted it. In the long nights of the Bodmin cell, with the wind in the chimney and the clock on the prison church tolling the quarters, I had rehearsed the scaffold as other men rehearse a speech. I had walked it in my mind from the condemned cell to the trap, forty-one paces, and I had known where I should put my feet.

But on the sixth day they brought in the verdict, and the judge put on the black cap, and I stood.

“Adrian Thomas Ashcombe,” said Pollock. “You have confessed to crimes which, in the ordinary course, would take your life. I have considered with great care whether the law requires it. I have concluded that it does not.”

I did not understand.

“The evidence before this court,” he went on, “is of a kind which has not, to my knowledge, been laid before any English bench. It discloses a conspiracy of generations, in which a great part of the gentry and clergy of a county have been, to some degree, concerned. The Crown has been advised that to proceed to a full prosecution would be to put upon trial not an individual but a community.”

A murmur ran through the court.

“The Crown has accordingly seen fit to confine the indictment to your own acts,” said the judge. “And I am instructed, on the advice of the Home Secretary, that the capital sentence shall not be sought.”

“My lord—”

“You will serve fifteen years’ penal servitude.”

I could not breathe.

“Fifteen—”

“In the Convict Prison at Dartmoor.”

“But the others—”

“The others,” said Pollock, quite quietly, “will not be proceeded against.”

He looked at me.

I saw, in his old shrewd face, a thing I had never seen in a man of power: shame.

“I regret it,” he said. “I want it understood. I regret it, and I think history will regret it more. But the Crown has judged that the peace of the Duchy would not survive the truth. The ledger will be lodged with the Bishop of Truro, under seal. The report of this trial will be abridged. The island will rebuild its lighthouse, and its wrecking will end, and it will be left to bury its dead.”

“And Margaret Vale?”

“Is dead, sir.”

“And the fourteen?”

“Are dead.”

“And the two on the gallery?”

Judge Pollock closed his eyes.

“God rest them,” he said. “The court will not name them in its report.”

“You will *not*—”

“Take the prisoner down.”

I write this in my cell at Dartmoor, in the fourth year of my sentence, on paper smuggled in by a kind warder.

I am thirty-eight. My hair has turned white. I have a window the size of a hymnal, through which, if I stand on my bed, I can see a rim of moor and a piece of sky. At night I hear the wind in the tors. It does not sound like the sea.

The island has been quiet.

Mrs. Crowe writes me every month, a single page in a cramped, formal hand. She tells me the weather. She tells me the price of fish. She tells me that the new lighthouse, a handsome gray tower of Cornish granite, built on the same headland by the Trinity House, was lit in the autumn of that year by a keeper from Plymouth who knows nothing. The old tower stands empty. The gallery has not been replaced. Children dare one another to climb to the lantern room, and the Reverend, who is eighty, preaches against it from the pulpit, and they go anyway.

She tells me that no one on the island will speak of what happened.

Not in the Assembly Room. Not at the Gannet. Not at the harbor, where the nets are mended in silence and the boys no longer sing *The Tide Keeps Our Names,* the old counting rhyme. A thing that was once the common knowledge of every household has simply gone out, like a lamp. A generation hence it will be as if it had never been.

She tells me that Samuel Thorne is well.

He has married. A girl from Mousehole, a fish-merchant's daughter, who laughs at his jokes. He lives in a cottage by the old harbor, and keeps a boat, and takes the Reverend out when the weather's fine. He has a daughter, three years old. He has called her Margaret.

He has never written to me.

Last winter, however, a package came. It was addressed in a hand I did not know, a firm, square, rather boyish script. Inside, folded in oilcloth, I found a single sheet of cream notepaper, creased in thirds, and on it, in a hand I knew better than my own:

Adrian.

If you are reading this, I did not come home, and you have found my mother's diary on the pillow. I left it for you. I wanted you to read what she wrote on the stair.

She told you that you were not to blame. She told me, too, in her last letter, in a different way. I think she must have said it to everyone she loved. It was the kind of thing she did.

I want to say it as well. I have never hated you. I loved the boy who gave me a lighthouse in a handkerchief, and I think he is still in there somewhere, under all that sorrow. If you find him, be kind to him.

Whatever you do tonight, you can still stop. It's only a key. Put it down.

Eleanor.

On the back, in Samuel's hand, were four words.

Mrs. Crowe found it. Schubert.

I understood. She had tucked it inside the score on the music stand, at the page of the impromptu. Where, of all places on earth, only one person would have thought to look.

I put it against my face.

It smelled of dust, and old rooms, and the faintest ghost of orris and lamp oil.

I did not weep. I have no tears left. But I sat on my bed in the gray light, with the page against my cheek, and I thought of a girl of fourteen with a handkerchief and a brass lighthouse. *So you will always know where home is.*

I have it still. The little brass lighthouse. They let me keep it. I have it on the shelf beside my Bible, and every evening, when the warder has made his round and the lamp has gone out in the corridor, I take it down and hold it in my hands.

I know where home is.

I always did.

It was only that I could not bring myself to go.

Chapter Thirty

The Tide Keeps Our Names

Samuel

I was the one who found them.

I have not told this to anyone but my wife, and she did not ask me twice. It is not a thing one says across a table. But I have a daughter now, and a granddaughter coming, and I am an old man with a cough that never quite left, and I have decided that someone ought to write it down. Not in the court record. Not in the Bishop's sealed box. Here, in a plain notebook, in my own bad hand, where the next one can find it.

The *Faith* made Mousehole at six on the morning of the seventh. We had been eleven hours in the Channel with the sail in ribbons and the pumps going, and when I stood on the quay at last and saw the sun come up red over the Lizard, I fell down on my knees on the granite and could not rise. The Reverend, who is a very strong old man, picked me up and carried me to the inn. He did not say a word.

I did not ask what had happened to the light.

I knew.

I had seen it from the stern, in the last half hour, a single white eye over the black. I had seen it go out and come on again. I had seen the wave, a vast smooth shoulder of water rolling in from the Atlantic, and the tower standing in front of it like a candle in front of a mountain. And I had seen the beam go on turning, after, over the wreck of the gallery, steady and white, through the hours of the night.

Gabe, I had thought. *Gabe, you great ox. You held it.*

I did not know the rest until the Reverend told me, a week later, on the road to Bodmin.

I went back in November.

I was not yet strong. They had let me out of the infirmary on condition that I did not go near the sea, and I went directly to the sea. I took the packet from Penzance. I stood on the deck in the cold with the old red scarf of Gabriel's round my neck, and watched the island come up out of the mist, small and gray and wet and stubborn.

The lighthouse stood against the sky.

The new one was not yet built. The old tower stood alone on its headland, its lantern room dark and ragged, the gallery gone. Seen from the water it looked like a bone from which something had been taken. I stared at it for a long time. Then I turned my face away.

Mrs. Crowe met me at the quay.

She did not weep. She was past it. She took my arm in her small hard hand and led me up the harbor road, through the stares of people who looked quickly away, to Vale House. The door stood open. The hall was dark. She did not light a candle. She took me by the wrist and led me straight through the house, past the portraits, past the great stair, to the green door.

“Are they—” I said.

“Not here.”

“Where?”

“Come.”

We went down at the spring ebb, a little after four in the morning, on the first of December.

The Reverend was with us. He carried the lantern. He walked slowly now, with a stoop he had not had in October, and he stopped often to rest his hand against the wall. Mrs. Crowe carried a bundle of clean linen. I carried a crowbar, and my heart was a stone.

I knew the way. I had known it since boyhood. The tunnel, the stair, the black door behind the press. The twenty-three steps. The smell of brine and rot and cold deep water. And at the bottom, the great vault, with the sea breathing at its mouth and the moon making a white road across the floor.

The names glimmered on the walls.

I did not look at them. I had read them all, a hundred times, in six years of nights.

I looked at the third niche.

It was at the far end, behind the broken column. The upside-down cross. The hole where the ledger had lain. Before it, on the flat stone ledge where I had slept, the water had left something.

I saw her hair first.

Dark. A long wet rope of it, trailing over the lip of the ledge, coiled like a sleeping snake. Then the gray wool of her coat, my sister-in-law’s coat, I almost said, and my mind recoiled at the word. Then the shape of her, small and straight, lying on her side with her knees drawn up, as a child lies in a bed.

And Gabriel.

He lay behind her, along her back. His body curved around hers. One arm was crooked under her head. The other lay across her, and in it, between the two of them, locked so tightly that the fingers had gone white and the knuckles stood out like pebbles, was her hand.

They were not hurt.

I want that known. I have seen drowned men. I have seen what the Teeth do to a body, and I braced for it. But the sea had been kind. They lay as if asleep, with their faces calm, their eyes

closed, their mouths a little open. The cold had kept them. There was not a mark on either. The water had carried them, God knows how, through the old sea passage, a mile under the cliff, along the black channel that the monks had cut for their smuggling, and laid them in the one place on the island where the dead were already waiting.

I knelt.

I put my hand on my brother's hair.

It was dry.

I do not know how it was dry. The water had been on them eight weeks. I have asked the Reverend, and the Reverend says that the Lord moves in mysterious ways, and I have asked Reed, who says it was probably the lie of the stone, and I have asked myself, at three in the morning, in the dark, and I have no answer. I know only that when I touched him, my brother's hair was dry and warm, as though he had just put down a book and fallen asleep in the sun.

I wept then.

I wept the way I had not wept in six years. I put my head on his shoulder and sobbed, and the Reverend knelt beside me and said the Office for the Dead in a voice that kept breaking, and Mrs. Crowe stood a little apart, with the linen in her arms, and her lips moved, and I do not think she was praying.

We could have taken them out.

I want that understood. We discussed it, in whispers, in the grey cold, with the tide beginning to make. We could have carried them up the stair and through the vestry and laid them in the churchyard, under the north wall beside the stone I had never lain beneath. There would have been a funeral. The island would have come. Two coffins, two names, two wreaths of sea-pinks.

And the island would have had to look.

That was what stopped us.

The judge would say it, a fortnight later, in the court. *The peace of the Duchy would not survive the truth.* Everyone on the island had known it for twelve years, and would know it again as soon as they stood at an open grave. They would stand with their hats in their hands and look at the lighthouse keeper and the daughter of Margaret Vale, drowned together, and understand exactly what they had done.

They would not forgive us for it.

They would bury it.

And Eleanor and Gabriel would be buried with it, in a corner of the churchyard, under a stone that said *Lost in the great storm,* and in fifty years the grass would grow over the name.

"No," said Mrs. Crowe.

I looked up.

“No, Mr. Samuel.” Her voice was very quiet. “Not up there. Not where they can forget.”

The Reverend rose slowly.

“Hester—”

“She’s with her mother,” said Mrs. Crowe. “Look.”

She raised her lantern.

I have said the wall was full of names.

It was. But at the very end of the vault, to the left of the niche, where the rock bent toward the sea, there was a space. A long smooth tongue of bare stone, six feet by four, which Mrs. Crowe, in her grief, had once told me was the place where the hand had grown too tired to go on.

I had always seen it so. A blank. A silence.

But in the lantern light, now, it was not blank.

Someone had written there.

I stepped closer.

The carving was deep. It had been done with a hard, steady hand and an edge of iron, and done slowly, over many hours. I counted the letters. I read them once, and read them again. They were old. They were not scratched this autumn, nor last. The edges had gone soft, as stone does that has been washed by the tide for a decade.

MARGARET VALE. 1842–1879.

I recognized the hand.

I had seen it in the ledger. In the pencilled margins of the map in the study. In the postscript of a letter that a woman had read aloud by candlelight to a man with his hands bound behind him.

She had carved her own name.

Twelve years ago. On the afternoon of the twenty-eighth of September, by candle, on her knees. Before she went up the cliff. She had stood in front of this blank stone, and she had known what she meant to do and what it would cost, and she had put her name to the wall of the drowned as one signs a will.

And beneath her name, in a smaller hand, a single line:

The tide keeps what we write. Add the others as they come.

Below that, a space.

A long smooth space, the length of a man.

And in the space, so freshly cut that the stone-dust still lay pale in the grooves, were two more names.

ELEANOR VALE.

GABRIEL THORNE.

I stood and stared.

The lantern shook in Mrs. Crowe's hand.

"Who?" I whispered.

Nobody answered.

"Who carved them? I didn't. The Reverend didn't. We came straight down. There's been no one —"

"It was done in the last week or two," said the Reverend, in a voice I did not know. "Look at the edges. The dust. A week old. No more."

"But *who?*"

He did not answer.

I turned, slowly, and looked at the two on the ledge. At the girl in the gray coat, and the man curled round her, and their joined hands.

Neither had a knife.

I looked at their fingers. The right hand of my brother, the one that lay across her breast, was clenched, and under the nails, I saw, there was a fine pale grit.

Stone dust.

I do not know what happened in that place between the wave and the dawn. I do not know how two drowned people, a mile under the sea, in the black, came to lie dry on a ledge before a wall of names. I do not know who cut the letters. I have heard it said that the dead can write. I have heard it said that the tide is a mind. I have heard it said, by old Hocking, who is a Methodist and a sensible man, that Margaret Vale has been waiting twelve years for her daughter to come down to her, and that when they came she was not about to let them go unrecorded.

I know only what I saw.

Two names, in a hand I knew. In the stone. Beneath their mother's.

The tide keeps what we write.

We buried them where they lay.

The Reverend and I carried the stone ourselves. A long flat slab from the broken floor of the vestry, which we laid over the ledge on iron bars, and sealed round with lime. It took three nights. On the third, when the work was done, the Reverend stood before it with his hat in his hand and said the last prayers, and Mrs. Crowe laid a posy of sea-pinks on the stone, and I put the old red scarf on top.

Then we went up the stair, and I shut the door, and put the press back in front of it.

The tide came in at five.

It came in as it always has, slowly, a long dark whisper over the black stone floor, and rose over the ledge, and rose over the slab, and covered the foot of the wall. It covered the names of the *Anne Marie* and the *Constant* and the *Sparrowhawk.* It covered the names of the unknown boy of nine. It covered Margaret's, and then, slowly, as the moon pulled it higher, her daughter's, and the keeper's.

And it will go out again.

That is the thing I want you to know, whoever you are, reading this. It always goes out. It goes out twice a day, forever, and every time it goes it leaves the names. Clean. Whole. Nothing washed away. A hundred years from now, if the roof of the abbey falls and the vestry is a heap of stones and every living soul on the island has forgotten what the sea took from it, still, at the spring ebb, a person may stand in that vault with a lantern, and read.

Margaret Vale.

Eleanor Vale.

Gabriel Thorne.

And fourteen men of the Sparrowhawk, *and two hundred and eleven of the* Halcyon, *and nineteen ships before them, and a boy of nine, and a Breton cook, and a woman with her child.*

They are not lost.

The tide keeps our names.

It always has.

Epilogue

The Sound of Their Names

Penhallow, 1934

Margaret Thorne came to Vale House on the first of September, in a motor-car borrowed from her husband's brother, with a trunk of sheet music and a letter from a solicitor in Penzance.

She was forty-three. She had her father's gray eyes and her grandmother's way of standing, and she taught the piano to the daughters of bank managers in Plymouth. She had never lived on the island. Her father had refused to speak of it, except on the rarest of evenings, with a glass of rum in his hand and his eyes on the fire, and then only in pieces, as one hands a child something that might cut.

He had died in the spring. He was seventy. The cough had finally taken him, thirty years late.

In his will he had left her three things: a red wool scarf, a battered tin of brass buttons, and a key.

"What does it open?" she had asked the solicitor.

"A house," he had said. "On Penhallow. It was left to your father by a Mrs. Hester Crowe, in nineteen-twelve, on the condition that it should pass to the first Margaret in the family who could play." He had paused. "I am instructed to say that the piano is included."

The house had been empty twenty-two years.

It stood gray and enormous on its headland, with ivy to the second story and the sea-wind in its chimneys. Half the slates were gone. The garden was a jungle of lavender gone woody, nettles, a collapsed greenhouse. But the door opened to the key, and the hall, when she stepped into it, smelled of salt and dust and old roses, and she stood a long time on the marble with her hand on her mouth.

Two portraits hung above the fireplace, cracked and brown with damp.

A man, heavy and fair, with a weak mouth.

A woman in white, with pearls, and dark hair pinned loosely at the nape of her neck. She had a smile that did not reach her eyes. The painter had caught the mouth and missed the sadness.

Grandmother, thought Margaret, absurdly.

She was not related to her. She was not related to anyone in the house. But she had a photograph in a tin box, a small brown carte de visite from Penzance, and the woman in it was laughing, and she stood beneath the portrait for a long time and tried to make the two faces agree.

The piano was in the music room.

It was a Broadwood grand, rosewood, with the ivory gone the color of old teeth. The lid was closed. Under the lid, when she lifted it, the strings were slack and green. The felts were moth-eaten. The wooden frame had warped.

She sat down on the bench.

She had been playing since she was four. She could play in a train, in a bath, in the dark, in the heart of a quarrel. She put her hands on the keys. They were cold. She struck the low A, and it gave back a sound like a drowned bell.

She laughed.

"Well," she said aloud. "That's torn it."

She would have to get a man in from Truro to restring it. She would have to get the whole house in from Truro. She picked up her hands, and lifted the lid, and bent to see the damage.

A page fluttered down.

It had been tucked into the groove where the lid met the frame, so carefully that she would never have seen it from above. A single sheet of music. Schubert, an old Peters edition, yellow as parchment, soft as a cloth. She smoothed it on her knee.

Impromptu in G-flat, Op. 90, No. 3.

The margin was thick with pencil.

Two hands had written there. One was a firm upright script, in a strong black lead, that she took for a teacher's. It said, in the margin by the first bar, *Slower. Let the left hand sing.*

The other was fainter.

She turned the page toward the window.

Reading the diary was meant to give me a name. Instead it gave me a debt.

That is the thing nobody tells you about the dead. They leave you what they could not finish. And they do it so lovingly that you cannot refuse.

Below this, in the same pencil, but in a different light, as if written at another hour, another day, another weather:

6th October. Eight in the evening. I am about to climb out of a window. I have a rope of bedsheets and a kitchen knife and no plan. Mrs. Crowe has the poker. If I do not come home, then this is the last thing I shall write in this house, and I would like it to be true.

I do not know how the story ends. I think it ends badly. I have thought so since the first night, when the light went out. But I have discovered something unexpected. I am not afraid.

My mother wrote that she was not brave. She was wrong, and I will not let her be right. She was the bravest person I ever knew, and I am going to do one small thing tonight and then another, and another, like picking up coins on a road.

Here is what the island will want to forget. I set it down so that it cannot.

That for sixty years, it killed strangers for their cargo.

That the men who did it sat in the front pews.

That the women who knew kept silent, and the children who saw were told they dreamed.

That a woman named Margaret Vale found the names and put hers beside them.

That a man named Gabriel Thorne held her wrist and let go, and spent twelve years learning to hold on.

That a man named Adrian Ashcombe was not his father, and did not know it until too late.

That I loved a man in a lighthouse. That I loved him in the morning, in the dark, in a room with the shutters closed, in a crypt in a gale. That he was frightened and kind and tired and entirely mine. That it was the best thing I ever did.

That none of it was a mistake.

If you are reading this, I did not come back, and the light was kept. I shall have asked someone to see to the rest.

Do not mourn. Please do not mourn. The sea is not cruel. It is only large, and it keeps what we give it.

One more thing. I am writing it in the margin, over the repeat, where the right hand comes in. It is the only place I could find room.

Play something for me.

E.V.

Margaret Thorne read it three times.

Then she put the page on the stand, and opened her hands on the keys.

She did not tune them. She did not think. The slack strings groaned and slid, and the first notes came out flat and sour, a ghost of a melody. But she played on. She played the Schubert, the opening bars, the long singing line of the right hand over the rippling left, a stream running under ice. And the Broadwood, which had been shut up in the dark for twenty-two years, did something she had never known an instrument to do.

It remembered.

The strings steadied. The pitch rose. The warped frame shuddered and, for a few bars, held. The notes came out round and dark and full, the sound of a rich old voice, and the whole bare room filled with it, and went out through the open window, over the lavender and the cliffs and the wide gray sea.

On the quay below, an old man mending a net lifted his head.

He was seventy-six. He was a Hocking, and he had once, on a stormy night, put down a cudgel. He stood quite still, with the needle in his hand and the twine hanging, and he listened, and his face worked, and he could not have said what he heard.

A woman in a doorway put down her basket.

Two boys on the harbor wall stopped fighting.

And out beyond the Teeth, where the old gray tower stood roofless on its headland with its gallery long gone and its lens long since removed to a museum in Truro, a single shaft of late afternoon sun came out of the clouds and struck the empty lantern room. For a moment, just a moment, the broken glass lit up from within, white and gold and burning.

Margaret did not see it.

She had her eyes shut. She was playing for a woman she had never met, in a room she had never seen, in a house that was not hers. And the tide was coming in over the rocks below, as it had come in every day for a thousand years, slowly, a long dark whisper over stone.

It covered the Teeth.

It covered the wreck of the gallery.

It covered a vault under a ruined abbey, and a wall of names, and a sealed slab of limestone with a posy of sea-pinks long since dust.

And it kept them, as it kept them all.

The End

Acknowledgments

[Add your own acknowledgments here. Thank the readers, editors, and first-draft friends who made the book possible.]

About the Author

[AUTHOR NAME] writes gothic romance and historical suspense about love, secrets, and the places that keep them. [Add two or three sentences of personal biography, your website, and a mailing-list link.]

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